

THE SECRET WORLD

NORTH AMERICA



THE SECRET WORLD

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CHAPTER ONE: THE ILLUMINATI

You answered a voice call from an unknown number. No one does that anymore. I like it. Yes, we know your number. We know about that test you cheated on in high school. I know your current heart rate—rising—and I can see you did a sloppy job of plucking your eyebrows today. I also can't help but notice you noticing the tiny red dot that's appeared on your chest. Ignore it. Just a formality.

One of our headhunters chatted with you earlier today. Consider this the final job interview, only I'll be doing all the talking. Please stand still.

You know our name, but what does it mean? What are we all about? We're about power—grabbing it, keeping it, using it. Power is our currency, our DNA, our god. In power we trust.

We control the world. Did you enjoy not hitting a single red light today? Maybe it was just a coincidence. We provide the blueprint, and we give the instructions. We're the people in grainy photos and on grassy knolls. We're the shadowy faces in smoky back rooms and darkened boardrooms. We're right here, hiding in plain sight, buying and selling favors.

Blackmail, treason, deceit—these are our stock and trade. We work the magic of drunken evenings with senators and chiefs of staff. We shake down demons and negotiate with sorcerers. We have stocks in Hell and compromising photos of angels.

Now, you might be saying to yourself, "Secret society? Why is their name plastered all over every aggressively mediocre thriller novel at the airport bookstore and in the rants of every reeking conspiracy theorist screaming into the void in ALL CAPS?"

I'm so glad you hypothetically asked that question. You see, while some of our competitors play X-Files cover-up games, we know better. This is the age of information. Stealth is not about hiding; it's about inundating. We leak the truth. Then we leak whole zettabytes of other junk. Opposing data. Similar data. Nonsense



data. Ad nauseam. Mesmerism by cat memes. Hypnotized. Apathy for the win. The human brain has only so much bandwidth. Critical thought can actually OD on input. Bury the ultimate secret of the universe in the shallow grave of the fifth page of a Google search ... and no one would ever find it.

Cover-ups are so 10 minutes ago. We deal in paradigm construction. When the most powerful of us shed this cramping mortal coil, we'll ascend as zeitgeists. Paying attention? Because I'm giving you just a taste of true knowledge.

Now ... hold out your hand. Good. This is the point in the interview where you give your answer, thumbs-up or thumbs-down. No need to negotiate a salary. You can throw as many zeros behind it as you like. I see that red dot dancing over your body has had many, many children while we've talked. Please don't let them affect your decision.

You can, of course, entertain the offers of our competitors. We know they talked to you. You could cosplay as a holy knight. You could religiously wank to chaos theory while trying to conjure hurricanes with torn-off butterfly wings. Or ... you could accept the one and only truth: that the world is a bad place, and you can either do or get done.

We are the Illuminati, and we are not done.

COSMIC MESSAGES THROUGH THE MEAT BRAIN

From: Dr. Charles Zurn

To: Kirsten Geary

Subject: Automatic Writing Test #33

Hey Boss,

I appreciate the violently angry patience you've shown, but you know what they say: the thirty-third time's the charm. We hit pay dirt! We know that anima-imbued individuals (designation: Bees) receive communications from an omni-dimensional collective entity (designation: the Buzzing). However, receiving a secondhand report on what was communicated is like playing a meth-fueled game of telephone through an Einstein-Rosen bridge.

Capturing a more direct transcript is difficult. It's impossible to say when such a transmission will occur, harder still to keep the subject coherent enough to relay said message. But I've refined my process! I've combined the spiritualist practice of automatic writing (whereby a subject writes without conscious thought, "guided" by something other) and a cocktail of drugs I took from MK-ULTRA.

Using eye-and-pyramid imagery, we were able to trigger a Buzzing interaction with one of our Bee agents. Though she screamed the entire time (three minutes and thirty-three seconds to be precise), she maintained the manual dexterity required to write.

What follows is an attached transcript of her writings. Doubtful it's a one-to-one translation. Some things get lost when transdimensional data from the beyond is passed through the physical brain of a hyper-evolved ape. All part of the meataphysical studies (that's not a spelling error ... I fear my humor is lost on everyone).

-Zurn

PS Don't freak out! This is a look at our organization from the outside (VERY outside). If you don't like what you read, don't shoot me. I'm just the messenger. Really, I'm just the guy who overstimulated the pineal gland of the messenger, using a medley of narco-synthetics that caused a salamander to briefly gain self-awareness in the late sixties. Soon thereafter, the salamander committed suicide. But our agent is fine!

ATTACHMENT: TRANSCRIPT OF AUTOMATIC WRITING

Our wisdom flows so sweet. Taste and see.

TRANSMIT-initiate pyramid signal-
RECEIVE-initiate NWO frequency-
DOWNLOAD-initiate Big Brother broadcast-
NEW AND IMPROVED-initiate Sex, Drugs,
& Rockefeller Prerogative-THAT'S THE WAY
TO DO IT!-initiate the Crowley cadence-
YOU MUST BE PRESENT TO WIN-the blue
spectrum-WITNESS-The Illuminati.

Cue curtain: The Punch and Judy Show

O child wandering in the dark, do you remember the puppet show? See Mr. Punch beat puppet after puppet with his stick. The

lesson: we all fall down. See the puppet master manipulating the brutal slapstick and drinking from a hidden flask. Behold the conspiracy of conspiracies, the most secretest society.

They began in Egypt, during the Old Kingdom. We came to them on the tears of Ra. But that was not the first beginning. Sweetling, do you really think this is the first age? Ever dream of the Long Ago? Ever gasp awake, remembering beginnings birthed before the Before?

Cue curtain: A New Age

Time moves not in lines, but in circles. Ancient ideals pass down the generations, transcend cataclysms. Old becomes new, different yet

same. Powerful mystics take the stage, form a cabal, and call themselves the Enlightened Ones.

Initiate Latin translation: "Illuminati."

The children of the Eye and Pyramid fertilize the Nile. Can you see them, sweetling, through the time refraction in our text? They pollinate the skulls of scribes, viziers, priests, and philosopher kings. Thoughts germinate and bloom. They vie to guide humanity toward an esoteric culture, to influence the world through the houses of Pharaohs.

Pluck the petals. The centuries tumble like she-loves-me-nots. The scenes change—Jericho, Damascus, Alexandria, Babylon, Jerusalem, Rome—but the plots and plays remain the same. Always, the Illuminati gather occult writings and treasures. They rise behind each new throne. And always, they encounter the Templars.

The secret-society siblings snatch kings, generals, and great thinkers like coveted toys. The dolls break in the tug-of-war. The Illuminati grab guilds and banks. The Templars clutch the military. Vicious games of tag ensue. Sometimes one flees, sometimes the other—that familiar dance.

The Illuminati skip east, fostering high culture in Byzantium. In Asia, they meet the Dragon. Tag, you're it. They skip back west. Now three great factions dance.

These secret societies—these migratory birds flying from one kingdom to the next, according to geological seasons. Always there is the prize: the lands of milk and honey, the most powerful nations.

Cue curtain: The New World

A misstep in the dance. The Illuminati limp west. On the new continent, away from their enemies, the children of the Eye and Pyramid weave a new backdrop infrastructure so tightly that none of the other factions have been able to gain a foothold there since.

Cue psychic currency exchange. Cue the viral pyramid. The one-dollar bill is always watching.

Defeats in Europe taught the Illuminati to play more subtly. Since then, they have been the most secretive of the three siblings.

Their clever fingers learned to make shadow puppets. Decoy ciphers dance on the dank wall.

While conspiracy theorists chase the echoes of Freemasons, Bilderbergs, and Bohemians, the true Illuminati have room to work.

Cue curtain: the Dark Days

The Eye and Pyramid are a well-oiled machine, serrated cogs lubricated on aptitude, ambition, and ruthlessness. In this epoch of information and equality, the Illuminati is king. The ruled do not complain if they detect no ruler. The Illuminati spill seminal thoughts into the gravid heads of the masses, while the other factions flail to the old dance.

Cue the ritual chant: "Fuck or be fucked!"

Conventional warfare is obsolete. Cue the paradigm war. The Illuminati strive to ascend as a pantheon of zeitgeists.

Beneath the Brooklyn streets, they experiment with thaumaturgy and technomancy. In their labs, demons shriek as they beat the walls of hard-drive purgatories, circuits soldered in patterns forming Enochian words. Old bleeds into new, the cutting edge fornicates with the antediluvian.

The three siblings have a choice: battle the sleeping horrors ready to engulf the world, or toil on in the struggle to define those who rule and those who are ruled. The children of the Eye and Pyramid so long to reign, and diabolic rumors follow them like a fouled cloak. Yet despite these ambitions, they have no intention of giving their planet to monsters. Perhaps they will fight back against the darkness, and find a tidy profit in it.

And yet you little termites war with each other over your little termite mounds, and somewhere in the Outer Dark, hungry mouths made of event horizons salivate and grin.

Dear sweetling, did you pay attention to that gruesome puppet show as a child? We hope so. The Illuminati are Mr. Punch, and hidden in that nonsense play is their plot. They have a big stick and conspire to bludgeon all competing puppets, and then the Devil himself. And if you get in their way ... you will be another broken Judy, splayed on the floor.

Cue the shrill voice from the Outer Dark: "That's the way to do it!"

Cue curtains.

AN UNSCRUPULOUS HISTORY

Greetings, new recruit. The discomfort from the microchip recently grafted to your spinal column will fade in time. I will reiterate previous warnings: do not tamper with or try to remove said microchip. Congratulations.

The next portion of your onboarding process will involve the history of our organization. You have already received the broad brushstrokes—our roots in ancient Egypt, our on-again and off-again alliance and rivalry with the Templars, our expansion into Rome and Europe, how we fled the Old World and got the drop on all our rivals in the New World, and our eventual primacy over the Americas.

What follows is a series of interest points in our illustrious history. Some or all of this information may be apocryphal, unsubstantiated, or fabricated. You are to examine each item and give your detailed assessment. You will be graded on criteria that will not be divulged to you.

You are invited to a celebratory rave, which begins after today's onboarding schedule. You are highly encouraged to attend.

Good luck.

KING SOLOMON

Consider King Solomon, whom many in our organization look to as an exemplar of Illuminati ideals. Let us examine the legendary accomplishments of the fourth monarch of the Kingdoms of Israel and Judah, son of David the Giant Slayer. As a monarch, astronomer, magician, and demonologist, Solomon commanded preternatural wisdom. Solomon is known as he who controlled the wind, knew the language of birds, and could hear the communications of the ants; whose subjects included all beasts, fowl, reptiles, and spirit kind. Animals entered his kitchen willingly to be his food, and his 700 wives and 300 concubines prepared these feasts and brought their foreign gods with them.

Consider the Seal of Solomon, his magic signet ring, which gave him the power to rule over jinn, inspire obeisance among the divs, and exorcise and enslave demons. When a genie displeased him, he sealed the being in a bottle with his ring

and threw it into the sea. He commanded angels to build his temple, and ordered the angels Uzza and Azazel to reveal every mystery he desired to know. At his bidding, armies of demons brought him precious stones from far-off lands, making him the wealthiest of kings.

According to the elaborate and grotesque demonology of the Testament of Solomon, he stamped the Ornias with his ring, binding the demon. Through Ornias, Solomon bound Beelzebub and, through him, all of demonkind.

To use the parlance of the youth, Solomon had swag. Supernal wisdom, opulent wealth, and the obedience of angels, demons, and other supernaturals. He embodied the aspirations of the Illuminati—and we have not even touched upon his many erotic verses in the Song of Songs. But what if Solomon was not merely a symbol some Illuminati look to, but an early (if not founding) member of the secret society? Some Illuminati scholars believe this to be true. We indeed use many of the occult seals and wards attributed to him.

There is even speculation that Solomon is a man who came from the Third Age, somehow surviving the transition of the epochs. Indeed, we have records of certain beings accomplishing this. Consider also the Throne of Solomon—a wondrous mechanical contrivance said to move and follow its master, a spectacularly complex device of moving parts, beyond anything else found in its time and place. A device out of time? A device from the Third Age, perhaps?

And there are those among our organization, too timid to put forth their name officially, who whisper that Solomon yet lives, that he is one of the so-called “Talking Heads” or even the true master of our society, hiding behind that construct. Perhaps these murmurers have reason to hide their names.

THE DARKNESS WAR

We of the historical department of the Illuminati have made extensive study of the stories written on ancient stones throughout Solomon Island. These words are attributed to the raven entities Huginn and Muninn, reputedly the Thought and Memory of the Norse god Odin. We have reason to believe this may be literal. We are combining this mythological data with the more direct data we have gathered with agents who (through the

time-bending properties of Agarthā) had their feet on the ground in this ancient battle we call the Darkness War. Here is the best translation of the rune stones we have to date (annotated as necessary):

We laid our blades up on this far shore, exhausted, only to lift them against worshippers of a dark sun. We carved this story in stone, here it waits still to be read.

From our frozen birthland, we crossed a white-capped sea to green isles of endless rain. This, too, we carved in stone.

While the text seems to be from the point of view of Odin's ravens, the "we" here seems to be the ravens speaking from the point of view of Viking warriors. Traditionally, ravens are said to eat the eyes of the dead, perhaps taking on the perspectives of others with ease. The warriors appear to be following some sort of divine inspiration or omen to the New World—either received from their gods or transmitted from Gaia and filtered through their own cultural biases.

A wise man once asked of a king: "Who is the great one who grasps the earth, swallowing wood and water? Bad weather he dreads—wind, but no man—and picks a fight with the sun."

We carried a sword out from the lands of rain, and gave thanks to the gods. All must pass before the gods.

The same wise man asked the king: "What beast is that which defends fighters? It bears a bloody back, but men it saves; meets spears, gives life to some, and lays itself inside a soldier's palm."

The meaning of the "man asked the king" riddles is hotly debated in our office. Of more practical interest is the sword, believed to be a Third Age relic that took on the Excalibur mythos in our Age. I've been told the Talking Heads are particularly interested in that detail (and the one who told me had the tell-tale bleeding nose, so I believe her).

In our longships, we sighted where the dawn-people and sun-worshippers warred. We joined them, a hail of arrows sent before us to mark the path.

The "sun-worshippers" here are that particular sect of Mayan cultists who worshipped a Dreaming One. Our own time-traveled agents confirm that the Vikings did indeed join the Wabanaki tribe in fighting off the invading cult.

Wise man, king, you know the drill: "The mind-whacker, the word-thwarter, the word-upraiser."

They did not know Loki walked among them, as he walks today. He fought at their side, but he is a trickster, guided only by rivalry with his brother. Let the thunder god also guide you.

We have it on good authority that Loki still operates today. His mortal alias is above my security clearance.

The wise man asked: "Four hang, four sprang, two point the way, two ward off dogs, one dangles after and it is always rather dirty."

More riddle games. Is there significant information hidden here, or is it a decoy bit of nonsense to distract the would-be reader?

The game was done, this battle won. They had earned the wealth which was their reward, and only one place remained for them to go.

Had you guessed? The wise man was the All-Father, the Wednesday man. The raven-god. In his honey dreaming we shall carry him these new thoughts, these new memories.

Here, "honey dreaming" may be a nod to Gaia-related imagery. Our Bee agents often refer to honey-related imagery expressed in their confusing communing with the Buzzing. Scholars have noted that the Buzzing is to Gaia what the two ravens are to Odin.

In time, they made to return to the lands of snow. Only to be taken by the sea where the draug drown. This Loki knew, so he did not sail. South he went, to find the secrets of the dark sun.

This last passage has us excited. It fits in with the tracked movements of the entity we are calling Loki. Beyond fanciful poetry, it points out a specific fact, indicating that the rest of the writings may contain valuable information. The "dark sun" might be more imagery related to the Dreaming Ones, also called Sun Eaters, who have spawned various cults with sun-related

motifs. This ends the translations, until when and if we discover any more stones.

The mainstream world is now aware that Vikings visited the New World centuries before Columbus and his ilk. They are not aware of the supernatural conflict and time-space anomaly we refer to as the Darkness War.

Much of what we know comes from a study of history (both secret and otherwise), Wabanaki folklore, artifacts, and interviews with more than one tormented spirit. We know the conflict took place on what is now Solomon Island. As unlikely as it sounds, we know that a corrupted cult of Mayans somehow traveled all the way to the island and brought war upon the local Wabanaki tribe. The Wabanaki called the beginning of the invasion the Day of Red Rain.

The Mayan cultists followed the poisoned visions given to them by a Dreaming One, and they came to awaken their master and god. The Wabanaki, however, were not alone. Vikings arrived on grim longships from distant lands, driven impossible distances by their own visions and omens. They joined the native Wabanaki to fight against the mad cult and keep them from performing a terrible awakening.

The battle was one of blades and broken bones, but it was also a war of opposing rituals. Spilled blood fueled the apocalyptic workings of will. The Wabanaki called on their ancestors and

spirit allies. The Dreaming One cult fought with the lunacy of a willing sacrifice, happily giving themselves as offerings to Xibalban Bloodhound, an avatar congealed from underworld nightmares.

It is said Blue Mountain shuddered. It is said a Norse chieftain wielded a strange weapon, a blazing beacon that drove away both its foes and their unnatural fog. Deranged cultists called, and the Hound of the Nameless Days answered—the herald of an older horror. And yet, through the efforts of the Wabanaki and the illumined weapon of the Viking lord, both the herald and its master were sent back through the veil of reality.

This is what we know from the folklore. Though it has all faded to the faintest of legends, the Wabanaki of today still seem affected. Their dream catchers practically drip with the black tar of echoing terrors.

We also know much more concrete details of the Darkness War through our second source: our own modern-day agents. It seems a contingent of Bees representing the Illuminati (and the other secret societies) used the space-and-time-warping branches of Agartha to travel back to the Darkness War and take part. Their efforts helped win the day, creating any number of temporal paradoxes that our in-house physicists still argue over.

There is a problem with this data ... it seems to be changing. The exact date seems to shift. The roster of agents seems to change, always with different names. At least, we think so. No one can agree. It is an overcomplicated knot of Mandela Effects.

It is maddening. Every week, we check, and every week, it seems a different team of agents went to the Darkness War. Digital data changes. Even printed hard copy! At least, we think so. It not only changes, but the new change becomes the way it always was. Only some of us can remember. How can we properly chronicle this event? How do we complete a satisfactory report!

We know that in quantum physics, experiments show that particles can behave as if future measurements are influenced by their past states. Retrocausality. Backward causation! If the Darkness War replays, again and again, will the result always be favorable? Will the apocalypse always have been forestalled?



BUILDING THE LABYRINTH

Among Secret Worlders, it is well established that the Illuminati claimed and wove themselves into every aspect of the New World. Our wards and sigils were already in place long before the colonists arrived. The geomancy of the continent was already working for us.

We took New York as our hub. The Labyrinth is our base of operations, located beneath the streets in tunnels that predate the city itself. Much of the Labyrinth has been centralized since its initial design, though it is still an easy place to get lost in.

A German architect (whose name is redacted) designed the layout of the Labyrinth headquarters and developed its sacred geometries. The commonly accepted story is that soon after turning in the blueprints, he went mad and committed suicide. However, the personal journal of an acting agent of the time indicates a slightly different story.

According to the journal entry, the agent accompanied the architect to survey the tunnels and go over the finer details of the blueprints. Belowground, the architect began acting “erratically” before “smiling in such a way as to dislocate his jaw.” Through the “ruin of his mouth,” the architect said, “Violet! It’s all violet!” The architect then ran and “fell into a strange angle,” never to be seen again.

No other reports or documents corroborate this version of events.

SUB-FACTIONS

The Illuminati is riddled with sub-factions—from official departments and sub-organizations to unofficial cliques, cabals, conspiracies, and more than a few cults of personality. A few of these secret societies within secret societies are listed below.

QUESTIONS AND ANSWERS

Q&A is the internal police force of the Illuminati. It operates out of its own designated section of the Labyrinth—a section methodically soundproofed for “convenience.” This is the sub-faction every Illuminati operative fears, the one that makes even the most acid-grade, snarky tongues go silent. Q&A is who you answer to when you mess up. They ask you the question,

SUB-FACTIONS

Players are encouraged to develop their own sub-factions. Entire campaigns can be played with player characters all belonging to their own sub-faction. Alternatively, belonging to different sub-factions can offer dramatic tension and the stretching of loyalties between player characters (even when they belong to the same secret society).

but you remain silent while they answer it themselves—because they already know.

Erin Mahler, head of Q&A, says the Illuminati use a stick-and-carrot method to motivate agents. She and her organization are the stick. They are always watching, always punishing any sign of weakness. The department is known for its merciless, unrelenting, and creative forms of torture. Even with the extensive soundproofing, faint screams can often be heard emanating from the offices of Questions and Answers. It is very likely that this is intentional.

INTELLIGENCE AND PROPAGANDA

This branch of the Illuminati specializes in programming the mundane populace with a special diet of entertainment, social media, and even more insidious forms of influence. Among the Illuminati, the Intelligence and Propaganda team is known for having the easiest-going and most positive office environment. Every day is casual day, naps are encouraged, and the team regularly socializes at game nights and team-building activities, keeping things cheerful even as they selectively lobotomize the masses with surgical applications of dopamine, fear, and cognitive dissonance.

THE WYRMWOOD HUNTING LODGE

Throughout their contentious—and sometimes violent—history, the Illuminati and the Templars have had close ties. Some groups maintain those ties, and none more so than the Wyrmswood Hunting Lodge. The Wyrmswoods are an ancient family of infamously wealthy and powerful eccentrics. Their history includes many warriors, occultists, and leaders. They are known to be

hedonistic, nefarious, and frightfully charming. The family has agents in both the Illuminati and the Templars, and it is said that their blood runs thicker than company ink.

The Wyrmswood Hunting Lodge is not a location, but a floating fraternal order of monster hunters. The Wyrmswoods offer very exclusive memberships to select members of the Illuminati and Templars who evince a desire to hunt supernaturals. A couple of times a year, the Wyrmswoods host a hunt at one of their lavishly appointed lodges around the globe. It is a chance to gather, socialize, enjoy twisted levels of decadence, and kill.

The Lodge does not hunt supernaturals out of any sense of mission, but for the perverse pleasure of it. It is said that the members are exquisite epicureans and gastronomes, throwing feasts for the rarest of tastes. Some rumors suggest that the Lodge is also a sect of parazoophagous eaters, who impress each other by devising gourmet dishes using the meat from the supernaturals that they slay.

The Wyrmswood Hunting Lodge is a fine way to bring together a party of player characters from different factions who share close (even familial) bonds. It is also an excuse to hold a monster hunt for nearly any creature desired.

The Lodge sometimes invites lowly peons from their secret societies. This can seem like an amazing opportunity to move up in the ranks, but the Lodge members don't expect such guests to survive long. In fact, they choose such joke invites as an opportunity for a good profane laugh.

Perhaps the Talking Heads are the far-flung future versions of the player characters, come back in time to take control.

THE TALKING HEADS

Not an official name or sub-faction, "the Talking Heads" is just what those who work for the Illuminati have taken to saying when referring to those above ... Way above. These secret masters of the Illuminati are a mystery to the society's operatives, whether they are low, middle, or even upper tier. No one seems to know exactly who or what rules at the top of the pyramid, though all become nervous at the thought of that eye gazing down on them.

In the dark of unknowing, rumors breed like flies. These are just a small selection of the rumors regarding the Talking Heads:

- They are a cabal of the original founders of the secret society, kept immortal through profane rites.
- They are a cabal of supernatural entities (anything ranging from vampires to angels to the gods of fallen pantheons).
- They actually control all three major secret societies, putting on a puppet show of conflict for some unknown design.
- Whoever they are, they are getting old, and they are currently courting Säid and the Kingdom, desperate for the mummification ritual as a way to prolong their existence.
- They are, in fact, grotesquely giant heads floating in massive tanks of a mysterious fluid.
- The Illuminati is ruled by one person, who uses the Talking Heads as an obfuscating mask. This individual is rumored to be anyone from an ambitious mortal to Lucifer to King Solomon himself.
- Whatever controlled the Illuminati has vanished! Those in middle management keep the myth of the Talking Heads alive to keep everyone else in line until they figure out what the hell they are going to do.

CHAPTER TWO: THE SECRET WORLD OF NORTH AMERICA

North America is an enormous continent filled with an incredibly diverse array of environments and people. Across the three nations, countless government, corporate, and criminal groups strive to increase their power and destroy their enemies.

The Illuminati claims to be in control of it all, and strives to make good on that claim. Below are a number of cities that the Illuminati consider key to their operations in North America.

ATLANTA

Atlanta is a thriving city of living connections.

It's a massive transportation hub that connects points throughout the continent, lying at the heart of a vast network of railroads and highways and hosting the busiest airport in the world.

The people and parts of the city are likewise connected in a web of support and interdependencies.

The Illuminati make the most of these connections. They use them to spread their power and influence where it's needed most, and to pull in the assets they want to claim as their own. Unfortunately, such assets aren't always what they seem.

SECRET HISTORY

Atlanta started out as a village at the site where several railroads converged, and was established as a city a decade later in 1847.

As its importance as a rail hub grew, Atlanta struggled to keep up with its industrial demands. At the Illuminati's suggestion, local sorcerers summoned and bound elemental creatures of fire, using them to boil water in steam engines and melt steel. But these were no mere flame elementals. They were jinn, and they would not easily submit to the humans they hated so much.

The jinn got their chance for revenge in 1864. During the Civil War, Atlanta fell and the invaders put its industrial center to the torch. Seizing on the existing fire, the jinn freed themselves and proceeded to burn as much of the city as they could. Area ritualists, with the backing of the Illuminati, were able to seal the jinn away again, but the damage had already been done.

Descendants of those ritualists, now calling themselves the Society of Flame, were called upon again in 1917 when the jinn once more did their best to turn the city to ash. This time they built a permanent shrine to lock out the demons, and established traditions to keep them in stasis.

The Society still persists today. Along with a number of other influential corporate and occult groups, it coordinates with the local Illuminati to ensure that Atlanta stays safe from outside influence and continues to grow.

HIDDEN POWERS

The Illuminati of Atlanta are well connected with the other local power brokers. Under the guidance of local Illuminati head Thaddeus Walker, his office coordinates closely—some might say *too* closely—with the corporations and government agencies of the area. The Illuminati never reveals its true nature to these regional allies, of course, but presents itself as a representative of a group of mysterious, wealthy benefactors. Thaddeus Walker defends this practice of working with, rather than secretly manipulating, the other groups, claiming it is more efficient. “Not only does it save us time and energy,” he drawls, “but it gives us an opportunity to look at the folks we might want to recruit.”

A number of the Illuminati's connections are subsidiaries of the Orochi Group. While these corporations appreciate the assistance of the secret society, they are loyal only to their bottom lines. They'll gladly work with the “mysterious benefactors” so long as it makes financial sense.

But when it's more lucrative to betray them, they won't hesitate to do so.

Orochi's most influential companies in the area are QBL Media, which runs the Carter Studios media empire; Váli, a biotech-focused subsidiary with deep ties in the CDC; and Faust Capital, which finances it all.

Although the Templars of Atlanta don't have a permanent headquarters, they have been maintaining a presence here for the past few years. They have been drawn here by stories of the strange new creature haunting the back alleys of West Midtown (which they long to research, as well as destroy), and rumors of vampire legions, lying in stasis and waiting to rise. After seeing the ruin that feral vampires brought to Transylvania, the Templars are committed to ensuring nothing like that happens in Atlanta.



POINTS OF INTEREST

ALEXANDER PARK

An urban nature preserve, Alexander Park isn't maintained by the city. It seems to maintain itself. The grass grows until it stops, the weeds stay away, and there are always flowers blooming. Those who walk or jog along the trails beneath its leafy canopy feel a welcoming presence here.

The park is kept by a nature spirit. It was summoned here a century ago by a well-meaning socialite hoping to preserve some greenery in the city. The spirit agreed to preserve the park, and is bound by that agreement, but it needs blood to continue. It uses illusions to lure people into the park's deepest, darkest spots, where the earth opens and swallows them whole. The park requires at least one such sacrifice a year.

Rare plants grow here. Witches seek them out for their medicinal effects, as do researchers from the CDC, Váli, and Plethron. The plant hunters are subtle, in hopes of hiding what plants they find from other prying eyes.

- **Harvest Time (page 82).** The heroes are sent to Alexander Park to retrieve certain rare-blooming herbs, but they aren't the only ones looking to pluck the plants of fate.

CARTER STUDIOS

In 1980, entrepreneur Cam Carter bought a small Atlanta TV station and turned it into one of the first cable stations. Over the course of the next 40 years, Carter grew that single station into a media empire that included a 24-hour news network, six different entertainment stations, three newspapers, and a major online streaming service. Thanks to tax breaks from the state of Georgia, he also helped build a number of movie, TV, and streaming production studios in the region as well.

Carter's biggest investor was Orochi subsidiary QBL Media, which quietly took control of Carter Studios in 2010. Carter Studios is one of Orochi's key assets in North America.

Under QBL's direction, Carter's programming has nothing but positive messages about Orochi's corporate activities, and it says nothing at all about things the company wants to keep quiet. Its various news organizations are dedicated to investigative reporting, but they only investigate

Orochi's enemies and rivals. Not everything its investigators discover is reported. The most shocking and horrifying secrets are kept under wraps and used for blackmail. The Illuminati believes that the Carter News Network building in Atlanta has a data vault full of this blackmail material—and would do anything to access it.

CENTERS FOR DISEASE CONTROL

While conspiracy-mongers love to dream up new horrors for this federal agency to be orchestrating, the truth is much stranger than chemtrails or microchips in vaccines.

The CDC is aware of the supernatural. Its researchers don't refer to it as such, of course. Superstition and magical thinking have no place in this scientific institution. But they can't deny that the world contains strange creatures and events that can't be explained or controlled through standard scientific techniques. They turn to nonstandard methods, often supported by nonstandard research partners.

Project Prometheus: The CDC sees vampires and other such creatures as people who are suffering from conditions that can be controlled or cured. To that end, the agency has set aside several labs for studying and monitoring what many consider monsters. These labs contain a number of vampires, deep ones, draug, and other critters, and the staff are confident that their sedatives and security systems will keep everyone safe. The Illuminati have helped with these precautions and share this confidence.

Zero-Point Studies: After receiving a sizable private grant from Sycoil, and at the unofficial encouragement of the Illuminati, the CDC started researching the alien material its scientists refer to as "unknown substance 19." Bees in the Secret World know it as Filth. The CDC is treating it as the lethal pathogen it is, so there have been no serious leaks yet.

National Center for Biomedical Research: NCBR is dedicated to using its knowledge of "extra-normal" entities and materials to create experimental treatments for serious illnesses. It's developing cancer cures, organ replacements, longevity serums, and other breakthroughs that should be science fiction. The Illuminati secretly has its hand in the program, of course, but so does Orochi. More than a few top-secret technologies have made their way out of the CDC and into the

clutches of the billionaires who can buy anything but immortality.

FIRE STATION NUMBER 6

Built in 1894 and operating until 1991, the building that was once the oldest fire station in Atlanta is currently a museum. While it's publicly dedicated to the history of desegregation in the Atlanta fire department, it's secretly the temple of the Society of Flame.

When members of the Society sealed away the jinn in 1917, they did so using a large brass disk that they covered in occult runes and embedded in a secret wing of the fire station's basement. A single flame forever flickers atop the disk. Since then, the Society has maintained a vigil over the seal, ensuring that its charges don't escape. Unsurprisingly, many members of the Society are themselves firefighters.

The seal is not perfect. Over time, the pressure of the jinn will eventually cause it to break. To prevent this, the Society must temporarily release a jinn or two every few years—under ritually managed conditions, of course. This results in fires and injuries, but the Society claims it's better to perform a controlled burn than to risk a wildfire.

Not every Society member agrees. Some feel that firefighting technology has advanced enough since 1917 that if they were to simply release all the jinn, the Society could stop their rampage and banish them from the city. A few members are even ready to try.

HORIZON NORTH

When the Green Horizon real estate development company broke ground on what would become the Horizon North parking garage in suburban Atlanta, its contractors made a grisly discovery: a jumble of human bones some 10 feet below the surface.

The executives realized two things: One, they were likely building atop a forgotten mass grave from the 1800s. Two, if they revealed it, they would lose years on the project as forensic archaeologists swarmed the site. So they paid off those in the know and simply buried the evidence even deeper.

Now the parking garage is haunted. Angry ghosts stalk the building after hours, terrifying—and even harming—the innocents who see them.

They also haunt the vehicles parked here, often going home with their drivers and haunting them in their own homes.

Properly burying the bones of these ghosts would put them to rest, but so would arranging for another living person to take their place in the land of the dead. Most of the ghosts are too insubstantial and feral to carry out these murderous impulses, but not all. Horizon North ghosts fall into a few categories:

Drifters: These ghosts aren't sentient, but merely spiritual echoes filled with rage. They are frightening when they appear, but they rarely harm people directly, and mostly stick to the garage itself.

Transformers: While immaterial, these angry spirits are powerful enough to possess and temporarily warp vehicles left in the garage. When they haunt a vehicle, they can interfere with its operation, causing accidents. They can also transform it into a horrific version of itself, covering it with spikes and barbs, cutting the flesh of its passengers and those around it, and lashing out at the living with the only bodies they have.

Whisperers: The most devious of the Horizon North ghosts, whisperers influence the minds of the living. Through hallucinations and intrusive thoughts, they drive their victims to acts of violence and despair.

PROMETHEUS WAREHOUSE

In a nondescript warehouse at the edge of town, the CDC has a stock of monsters for use with Project Prometheus. They have vampires from New Orleans, deep ones from Seattle, and more. Each is kept unconscious in a stasis tube, packed into a dark industrial crate.

Not all the creatures are comatose. One of them, a Filth-tainted elder vampire named Varen, is calling out telepathically for others to help him. He has attracted a group of psychically sensitive, emotionally unstable followers who have shared dreams of seeing an angel in this place. They don't know what to make of these visions, but they know there's something special about this mundane-looking warehouse.

The warehouse isn't guarded, but it has high-tech locks and security cameras and is

surrounded by a chain-link fence. Trucks from the CDC come here every few weeks to pick up and drop off specimens. Their drivers don't know what they're delivering; they only see crates and barcodes.

- **On Ice (page 82):** The CDC's warehouse is the subject of a lot more online chatter than usual, especially among urban exploration outfits. Maybe it's nothing. Maybe it's the tip of a terrifying iceberg. It's up to the heroes to find out.

WEST MIDTOWN

This region of Atlanta consists of numerous smaller neighborhoods that were once mostly industrial. They are now home to art galleries, entertainment venues, residential areas, office lofts, and trendy retail shops.

West Midtown is also home to a monster the likes of which the Templars have never seen before.

For the past year, *something* has been attacking people on the streets of West Midtown. The descriptions of the beast from the few terrified survivors are muddled and contradictory: it looks like a 10-foot-tall man, it slithers through storm drains, it's covered in tentacles, it's covered in horns.

When the Illuminati were unable to find the thing, Thaddeus Walker reached out to David Ennis, one of his many connections, who happened to be a top monster hunter for the Templars. Others in the Illuminati were displeased by the decision, but Walker dismissed their concerns. "When you have rats, you call the exterminator. I'm not wasting our resources on this."

Ennis is keen to stop the so-called "Westside Slasher," but other Templars suggest that perhaps he should focus on capturing the beast rather than killing it. After all, it's not every day they get to learn the secrets of a new foe.

- **The Westside Slasher (page 83):** When the heroes are recruited to help stop the mysterious monster, they find themselves caught up in inter-faction politics while the bodies of innocent victims continue to pile up.

PERSONS OF INTEREST

ALFRED NAVARRO

A veteran investigative reporter for Carter News Network, Navarro knows more than he should. He's uncovered fragments of the Secret World and, without his bosses knowing, has started piecing those fragments together. He long suspected there were conspiracies at work in Atlanta; when his third investigative installment was killed by the network, his suspicions were confirmed. If the heroes need a person to talk to about the secrets of the city, Navarro's name might come up. He offers information in exchange for secrets—and any protection the agents can provide him. He knows he's made enemies. Sooner or later, someone's going to come gunning for him.

CLARA AYERS

The head of Project Prometheus grew up hearing stories about monsters from her grandparents who emigrated from Transylvania. As she got older, she dismissed the stories as fairy tales, but as a grad student in medical science, she realized there was truth to the tales. These so-called “monsters,” she theorized, were medical problems—which meant they had medical solutions. When the Illuminati saw Dr. Ayers's theories, they placed her in the CDC and opened the doors for her to create Project Prometheus. In her role and with the blessings of her “mysterious benefactors,” Dr. Ayers seeks out new test subjects and new materials to use in her unorthodox experiments.

DAVID ENNIS

Ennis is one of the Templars' top monster hunters in the region. He knows how to identify, track, and destroy countless types of creatures. While others may hunt intuitively, Ennis is very “by the book.” The system is there for a reason, he points out. But there is no guidebook for destroying dozens of monsters held inside a secure, top-secret government facility. Ennis is aware of Project Prometheus, and has made it his mission to destroy every one of its test subjects, as well as the dangerous lunatics behind the project. He's momentarily unsure how to proceed, and needs to find more information, more firepower, or both.

RUBY HORNE

Ruby doesn't know that her great-grandfather was one of the original members of the Society of Flame. She doesn't even know how, exactly, a demonic binding works. What she does know is that the old, disk-shaped bronze pendant she found in Grandpa Horne's lockbox lets her talk to a spirit that she's named Mister Sparky. Mister Sparky is some sort of fire spirit, and he will manifest as a giant, burning man upon her request and set fire to whatever she wants. In return, he just wants human suffering. As a freelance arsonist, Ruby is more than willing to let the spirit hurt anyone he wants. Recently, he's been insisting that she let him burn down some old museum in the Sweet Auburn neighborhood. It's an odd request, but she's thinking of granting him his wish.

THADDEUS WALKER

The local head of the Illuminati presents himself as a classic southern gentleman, full of charm and manners. The gray-haired executive is a bit beyond his prime, but he makes up in charisma what he may have lost in physical prowess. He prides himself on his vast “old boy” network of connections and that he gets along with everyone, no matter their allegiance or agenda. When others point out that this means he might be aiding or working with those who seek to undermine the Illuminati, he dismisses such concerns as “poppycock.”

MEXICO CITY

The capital of Mexico and the most populous city in North America, Mexico City is a hub of culture and commerce. It's bursting with activity, productivity, and the secrets of a previous age.

SECRET HISTORY

Long before Europeans arrived in what would someday be known as Mexico, the Quinametzin ruled the land. These creatures looked human, but stood 10 to 18 feet tall. At various times, the Nephilim and Grigori have each taken credit for creating them—and then disavowed all knowledge of the creatures. It's possible the giants

were once human, but fell into worshipping the Dreamers and were mutated by Filth.

The Quinametzin built enormous structures and had an advanced society, but they could not stand against the invading Aztecs. The new rulers of the land drove out the surviving giants and established their own society that was just as advanced ... but it couldn't stand against the invading Spaniards.

When the Spanish arrived in the 1500s and 1600s, the Templars came with them. The secret society dominated the region until the 1700s, when the Illuminati began to invade the continent in earnest. Still, it wasn't until the 20th century that the Templars ceded Mexico City to their rivals, and they still maintain pockets of power throughout Mexico and Latin America.

HIDDEN POWERS

The Illuminati sits atop a precarious pyramid of scheming factions, cults, and criminal organizations, many with supernatural elements that the secret society would like to keep under wraps. To that end, its scientists are working on a network of technologies they call a "reality filter." Through a complex network of mind-altering chemicals in the water, subliminal messaging, and traditional propaganda, they hope to ensure that people outside the Secret World will be literally unable to process any strangeness they may see or hear. They have a prototype system in place, but its bugs have killed over 50 people, so it remains a work in progress.

One of the Illuminati's most successful tools is the National Institute of Anthropology, or Instituto Nacional de Antropología e Historia (INAH). This government agency manages access to archaeological sites and artifacts—especially those possibly tied to the Second Age. The Illuminati has thoroughly infiltrated INAH, and uses it to control outside access to these potentially dangerous locations and the artifacts they produce.

Because of its great size and importance, Mexico City hosts every major player in the Secret World. The Dragon's agents are trying to subtly guide the city's archaeological exploration for reasons no one knows. The Templars have gone underground, but they are often associated with old churches that, like the Templars themselves,

lost their power in the last century. Orochi is everywhere in this industrial city: Plethron grows its food, Sycoil processes its fuel, and Faust Capital keeps the money machine running. The Orochi group makes no effort to hide its presence or influence, but the Illuminati is too busy managing larger threats to worry about corporate corruption.

Organized crime isn't as obvious in Mexico City as it is in other parts of the country. The cartels and families wield a great deal of power here; their bribes and threats fuel entire industries. But under the influence of the Illuminati, the crime organizations avoid obvious displays of violence. It's easier to conduct business if you aren't under constant threat.

The Society of Giants is a philanthropic organization aimed at helping the people of Mexico achieve greatness, then share that greatness with others. It takes its name from the semi-mythical Quinametzin of ancient Mexico. For the wealthy of Mexico City, the Society of Giants offers charitable tax write-offs and networking opportunities. For others, it offers assistance in the form of food and medicine, alongside various programs to improve one's mind through meditation and asceticism. These programs have no connection the Morninglight Foundation, yet their teachings are suspiciously similar, and their Filthy results are the same.

POINTS OF INTEREST

CONVENT OF SANTA MARIA

The convent was established in 1552 as a place of contemplation and education, where nuns came to study scripture and teach religion, reading, and math to the people of the region. But its mission began to change in 1623 when the local bishop quietly changed the policy regarding pagan artifacts. If missionaries or other church workers found an object of significance, they were to bring it to the convent for safekeeping. The bishop probably intended "safekeeping" to mean "stripped of its jewels and precious metals," but the nuns took their job seriously. Over the next two centuries, they became experts in these arcane artifacts, and the convent became a storehouse of the occult. Scholars from across Mexico—including Secret Worlders—came here to study in the secret sanctuary.



During this time, the convent grew in power and wealth. Perhaps it was the influence of the mystical objects in the nuns' possession. Or perhaps it was a natural result of a region dominated by Catholicism. But by the 1850s, the government of Mexico had grown hostile toward the Church. In 1862, the convent was officially shut down. Most of its land was turned over to the state, leaving only the church building—which was still used by its congregation—and the secret vaults.

Today, the vaults remain full of priceless artifacts. The Church has tried to move them, but the head of the operation, Flora Aranda, insists that it's dangerous to do so. She enjoys her role as the curator of a secret museum, or the head librarian of a secret archive.

Mother Aranda is always trying to add to her collection. Her top agent in this endeavor is Estefania Flores, who is working on behalf of the Dragon. Sister Flores has been tasked with collecting certain artifacts from the Second Age and placing them in a certain configuration. She suspects doing so will unleash a massive effect, but her Dragon masters have told her nothing about the purpose of her task.

EL INTERNACIONAL

A luxury hotel built in 1956, the Internacional has changed very little since that time. It retains the same decor and sense of casual luxury. Even the people who work here look straight out of a previous era. Oddly enough, though the hotel doesn't get a lot of traffic, anyone stopping in to get a room is informed with regret that they are booked up indefinitely.

The hotel is stopped in time. The workers are not human, but demonic parts of a hive-mind entity trapped here by the Illuminati in 1961. The Illuminati uses the hotel to secure sensitive prisoners. Those who check in to the hotel are caught in a time loop and slowly forget who they are, as a mystical artifact slowly drains their memories. High-level Illuminati can access those memories from the artifact, which is a glowing crystal box the size of a car that is kept locked in the basement.

- **Trapped in Luxury (page 84):** When the wrong person is trapped in the hotel, it's up to the heroes to break them out—without getting captured themselves.

GATEWAYS TO HISTORY

Mexico City is rich with archaeological sites of note. Some are major tourist attractions, such as the Templo Mayor. Others are more inconspicuous, or actively locked away by the authorities. Scholars and historians are often investigating such places, looking for secrets of the ancients and artifacts of a previous age. These sites are under the jurisdiction of INAH, which is under the control of the Illuminati.

In addition to those sites known to the public, the INAH has secretly secured the following locations:

Artifact Alley: Scholars theorize that this site may have once been a temple, a storehouse, or maybe even a great ruler's vault. In any case, they've found hundreds of objects here, most made from gold and intricately carved. Some confer supernatural powers, such as the ability to reverse aging, read minds, or briefly fly. Most seem to be mundane, though it's possible that their secrets have simply not yet been uncovered. This area is kept under tight security, and any artifacts discovered here are immediately turned over to the INAH for further study.

The Black Altar: One of the least-secured sites can be found in the heart of a dangerous, crime-riddled neighborhood, where a cult has grown up around its black stone altar. The cultists offer animal and even human sacrifices here in order to secure the gods' protection for their own activities and those of their criminal associates. It seems to be working. While the authorities have tried to destroy the cult and lock down the altar, they have been unable to do so.

The City Beneath: At the bottom of these ancient ruins is a large, loose stone. Behind the stone is a narrow tunnel that leads into a vast cavern containing an entire forgotten city. The dusty buildings are remarkably well preserved. Judging from the design, the few archaeologists who have seen the place think they are from the 1300s or before, though some of the imagery predates the arrival of the Aztecs. Secret Worlders suspect this is left over from the Third Age. The existence of the city is one of INAH's greatest secrets. Though the institute's leaders would love to fully explore the city, they realize that if word got out, the site would be quickly overrun. So they quietly send in a few small, discreet teams of specialists every few years to explore

and document. Some members of these teams come back pale and shaken, offering reports of “hissing, chittering things” scurrying through the primal darkness. The last team to visit the city has yet to return.

Giants’ Graveyard: One of the more secure sites is known to conspiracy theorists as the spot where numerous giants have been buried. Dozens of skeletons have been extracted from here, and there may be hundreds more, buried in caverns beneath the city. Each skeleton appears to be that of a human, albeit between 12 and 20 feet tall. Some skeletons are wearing armor with symbols similar to those referencing the Egyptian sun god Aten.

- **Idol Hands (page 83):** A golden idol has been stolen from an archaeological site. It has already killed once, and it’s up to the heroes to stop it from killing again.

LAS PUERTAS DISTRICT

For centuries, the people of this small, poor neighborhood have guarded a secret. Buried beneath the ground, but accessible to those who know the old tunnels beneath residents’ basements, are seven ancient stone seals, each marked with the face of what they believe to be an Aztec god.

But now real estate developers want to buy up the neighborhood. They have been encroaching for decades, and the new people moving in have no idea of the danger beneath their feet. The remaining watchers are doing what they can to keep the developers away, but they know time is running out. They could tell INAH about the archaeological importance of the site, which would prevent development, but they fear the leaders of the institute might break the seals to satisfy their academic curiosity. What would happen after that, they aren’t sure—the warning has been garbled over the centuries—but they know it would be catastrophic.

The watchers of Las Puertas are looking for help. They seek someone who can help them identify what’s sealed away beneath them, and figure out how to defeat it. It’s a desperate move, but it might be the only one they have left.

LOS MERCADOS

Mexico City is known for its many street markets. Some are open-air affairs that pop up on market days. Others are permanent fixtures inside warehouses and repurposed factories. Each market has its own identity based on its neighborhood, vendors, and clientele. When Secret Worlders shop the markets of Mexico City, they’re most likely to hit one of the following:

Mercado de Medellín: While countless other markets offer local meats and produce, Mercado de Medellín also offers foods from Latin America, including mysterious items from unknown regions. These include fruits and vegetables that no one recognizes, which even the sellers themselves might not be familiar with—though they swear the food’s good, and that they’ve eaten it themselves. Many of these mystery foods are the products of Plethron’s experimental programs—the corporation tests its designs here before releasing them to the masses.

Mercado Sonora: Mercado Sonora is known as the place to buy ingredients for occult rituals, items for talismans, and the occasional supernatural artifact. It is traditionally neutral ground for all Secret Worlders. Mercado Sonora is the best place in the region to acquire some of these items, and no one wants to endanger it by picking a fight here with a rival secret society or enemy sect.

Tianguis de la Fayuca: This open-air flea market offers a mind-numbing array of clothing, electronics, small appliances, and consumer goods of every stripe. It also offers stolen and illegal items, such as weapons and narcotics. If a buyer needs a specific item or service, there is a vendor here who can either sell it or acquire it. The market is under the protection of the Illuminati itself, which has made arrangements to ensure that the various criminal organizations that benefit from it don’t (intentionally or not) disrupt it.

NIGHT SPOTS

Mexico City is renowned for its nightlife. Depending on the neighborhood and the visitor’s budget, it offers everything from drug-fueled upscale techno bars, to smoky dives, to everything in between. The city’s clubs make a great neutral ground for members of the Secret World, and a great hunting ground for those of a more predatory persuasion.



Apartamento: One of the largest nightclubs in the city, Apartamento boasts five different dance floors, each serving a different clientele. The lower levels are always open to the public, and often have their share of tourists. The higher levels each have an additional cover charge, which can sometimes be quite exorbitant. Still, so long as customers can pay, they can come on up. Apartamento is known as a place where high rollers can come down to mix it up with the commoners, and anyone with the cash can meet with the VIPs on the upper floors. Those VIPs include tech-bro industrialists, scions of old wealth, and a trio of Dragon agents who offer enigmatic advice to Mexico City's movers and shakers. Their words are often misinterpreted, but are never wrong.

Velos Negros: While it rejects the label of "goth club," Velos Negros nevertheless revels in its reputation as a place where witches, occultists, and others with a taste for the arcane or macabre come to mingle. It's a fun bit of kitsch, which helps sell the overpriced drinks, but in the private back rooms and secret basement chambers, actual practitioners meet and perform their mysterious ceremonies. The place is said to be haunted, protected by demons, and stalked by vampires. If questioned about such things, the owners just shrug and smile enigmatically.

Sunspot: Sunspot is a classy joint with a dress code, a steep cover charge, and a reputation as the hangout of Dario Loza, the leader of the Loza crime family. Ironically, criminal activity of all stripes—including drug use—is forbidden here. The police have never had cause to visit Sunspot, and Loza wants to keep it that way. Nevertheless, the place is crawling with armed gunmen. Anyone who can pay the cover and stay out of trouble is welcome here. Visitors might even be able to finagle a meeting with Loza or his close associates. But if they cause any trouble, they will find themselves removed at gunpoint. Repeat offenders have a tendency to show up dead in an alley a few miles away.

- **Hexed (page 83):** The daughter of a high-ranking government official is dying from a curse that was placed on her when she visited Velos Negros. Can the heroes break the curse in time?

PYRAMID OF THE GIANTS

Just outside downtown, allegedly on the site of an ancient temple, stands a modern building that's shaped like a classic step pyramid and serves as the headquarters of the Society of Giants. The first floor is open to the public and showcases the society's humanitarian efforts throughout Mexico. It also offers up public spaces for meetings, lectures, performances, and art displays. Upper floors are reserved for member meeting rooms and training centers. The top floors are dedicated to spiritual indoctrination; only the highest-level members are allowed up here, where their mind are filled with Filth.

The Society operates a number of smaller pyramids throughout the city, where they offer aid and enlightenment to those who seek it. Temporary pyramid-shaped tents often pop up when and where folks gather, such as at street markets, to serve and convert people where they live.

PERSONS OF INTEREST

ALBERTO MONTOYA

Mexico City is the largest, most complex territory that the Illuminati controls in all of North America, and Alberto Montoya is just one man. He has an army of agents to help him, but between the economy, the cartels, and the sheer number of factions all fighting to get ahead, it's almost more than he can handle. To cope, Montoya secludes himself in his office, where he monitors hundreds of data feeds and issues orders in clipped tones to his trusted lieutenant, Claúdia Najera.

CLAÚDIA NAJERA

While Alberto Montoya is very hard to reach, his right hand, Claúdia Najera, is the point woman between the Illuminati's local leadership and its agents. She represents Montoya at all but the most important Illuminati functions, and issues orders on his behalf to keep things running smoothly. She appears loyal to Montoya and has no interest in usurping his position, though she does exert influence over him by directing his attention to what she considers important. Local agents know to stay on Najera's good side. The best way to do that is to efficiently carry out whatever assignment they're given.

FIDEL RIVAS

When Mexico City millionaire Fidel Rivas's wife left him a decade ago, he broke down. He was rich, but his life was without meaning. He journeyed deep into the Mexican desert, where he planned to contemplate his existence and then, in the morning, end it. That night, he dreamed of a giant. The man was 20 feet tall and spoke to him in modern Spanish, explaining that the ancient giants, the Quinametzin, were not only real, but were supernatural entities that served as messengers between humanity and the cosmos. While many of their bodies remain scattered across the earth, their true essence returned to the stars to await the time of awakening. That time was now, and Rivas was to be the one to make it happen. Guided by his dreams, the millionaire immediately started work on what would eventually become the Society of Giants. He is still guided by the giants in his dreams, who have suggested that he and his followers must soon seek out and dig up ancient giants for the spirits to inhabit.

JUSTINO CRUZ

The 25-year-old owner of Velos Negros has no idea what he's doing, and no idea how badly he's doing it. The playboy son of a billionaire, Cruz bought the place because he thought it would be fun to run his own goth-themed nightclub. He has no business experience, no relevant education, and no inclination to listen to anyone's advice. He is only now realizing that the occult trappings on the club's surface hide the occult realities of what goes on in the basement and back rooms. He may never realize that the contract he signed allows the previous buyer to eventually possess his body, and run the old club inside his new flesh.

SOFIA MORSE

The Templar Sofia Morse has come to Mexico City in search of the legendary artifact known as the Heart of the Giants. According to colonial records, this golden bauble is capable of instilling a warrior with great size and strength, making them equal to one of the giants of old. Morse was given this quest by her superiors in London, and she has sworn to see it through.

MONTREAL

One of the largest, most important cities in North America, Montreal is a key Canadian transportation hub and a powerhouse of industry and innovation.

SECRET HISTORY

People have always lived on the island that's home to Montreal. Countless indigenous tribes have called the place home over the millennia. Many have since drifted away, saying only that the place is "cursed" and "unclean."

The French settled the region in the early 1600s. The Church was an important part of the initial colonization effort, and the clergy quickly discovered that the area was plagued with aggressive undead. Word filtered back to the Church's Templar allies, who hurried to the colony and put the monsters to rest. Though the battles against the zombies were officially unrecorded, they set the tone for the next few hundred years, during which the Church and the Templars set the rules for the area.

The Templars ruled Montreal from the shadows until the 19th century, when the Illuminati finally turned their attention north from New York. The conflict between the two secret societies was slowly-grinding cold war, but the tide eventually turned against the Templars, who ceded control and disappeared to the edges of society.

HIDDEN POWERS

Today, the Illuminati of Montreal are not concerned with ruling the city so much as shepherding its people toward productivity and contentment. This doesn't necessarily match the philosophy of the other Illuminati, but the results are hard to argue with. Unlike other Illuminati cities, in which the society barely keeps the chaos under control, Montreal (at least to outsiders) appears stable and secure.

The Templars are still here. They're less public (if indeed a secret society can ever be "public"), but they are too thoroughly intertwined with the history and culture of Montreal to simply disappear. They rightly suspect that the leaders of the Illuminati are aware of their presence and

influence in certain circles. But the Illuminati seem willing to ignore them, so long as they restrict themselves to hunting monsters and protecting the city.

As one of the most important industrial centers in Canada, Montreal is infested with Orochi Group subsidiaries. QBL is a huge part of the city's movie and television production industry. Anansi Technologies has its cyber-fingers in every digital pie. The others have their own offices and projects in town; one of the most interesting is the Blackburn Academy, which is something of a joint project between Váli and Zagan.

The WarmingTrends Self-Improvement Group offers literal warming stations during the long winter months. It also offers a source of warmth and belonging for those who feel alone or estranged. The New Age self-help group was founded by Nicolas Bertrand, who brought the seed of the organization back with him from Tokyo, where he was greatly inspired by the Fear Nothing Foundation. Something about that organization's passion and sense of mission infected his mind. It wouldn't stop needling him until he started his own version of the group here in Montreal.

POINTS OF INTEREST

BLACKBURN ACADEMY

For 20 years, this small private boarding school has been known for producing the highest quality graduates. Alumni go on to prestigious colleges and become respected business and community leaders. Admission requirements are high: the school judges students not only on academic merit, but on social intelligence and inherent intuition as well.

The academy was founded by headmistress Greta Blackburn, a gray-haired matron who is obsessed with raising the perfect child. She is unmarried and has no children of her own, but she is proud to be descended from the Sulpician missionaries who promoted academic rigor while helping establish what would become Montreal. While she comes across as a rigid, authoritarian figure, she is actually very flexible in her thinking. She sees herself as a scientist. Every student is an experiment, and every classroom is a laboratory. Every semester is an

opportunity to change up the experiment based on what was previously learned.

Blackburn Academy is heavily sponsored by the Orochi Group. Through a spin-off of the Bachman Institute's recruitment program, the corporation finds student candidates with psychic potential. Harmony Harvest, a Zagan subsidiary, provides the school's cafeteria with food, some of which is experimental. Faust Capital and Anansi Technologies offer specialized textbooks and digital equipment. In exchange for their help, the companies are allowed to closely monitor the students and their test scores. Those with the most potential are offered opportunities within the corporations. Blackburn is beginning to regret her corporate partnership.

The school has about 90 students in grades 6–12 (Greta Blackburn feels that younger children are too unruly to properly mold). The academy facilities occupy a former church building just outside downtown. Its urban location offers plenty of field trips to interesting sites, and older students earn passes to explore on their own on the weekends. The students are generally well treated. Blackburn is strict, but fair. She genuinely wants the kids to be the best they can be.

Administration Office: Various Orochi representatives are often here, collecting information on their investments (as they call the students) and offering Blackburn promises, threats, and bribes to give the company more power over the school. It's also where the headmistress's right hand, the kindly Gary Lamarch, maintains his office. Students prefer to deal with Lamarch rather than his boss; he's more likely to relax the rules, and often falls for their tricks and distractions.

Dormitories: The dorm areas are divided by age and gender, with two to four students assigned to each room. The windows in these areas are suspiciously easy to open, and provide ready access to the neighborhood outside.

Security Office: There are cameras throughout the school, and they are all monitored from this office. The security system also tracks keycard usage and door alarms. Security should be tight, but it tends to go on the fritz at convenient times. The lone security officer is a former Orochi employee. He says little, but is shockingly effective.

- **The Hunter (page 84):** Someone has been stalking the Academy's students. If the stalker isn't found, it's only a matter of time before a student is seriously hurt or killed.

MOUNT ROYAL CEMETERIES

Mount Royal looms over Montreal, giving the city its name and serving as a distinctive landmark. The mountainside is covered in woods, parks, and numerous cemeteries.

Since 1965, the dead buried on Mount Royal have a good chance of coming back to life. No one knows why. Some theories involve necromancers, while others speak of falling radioactive satellites or passing comets. In any case, a mere embalming isn't enough to prevent the process. If the central nervous system is intact, the dead may rise. By default, the undead are brainless, aggressive, and far stronger than any human. They aren't hungry for the flesh of the living (or anything else); they simply seek the living and try to hurt them. Those bitten by the zombies are infected, but by deadly bacteria rather than the curse of undeath.

Sleep Makers: Since the dead started to rise, the local cemetery workers have secretly modified the bodies before putting them in the ground. They gently separate the spinal columns of the interred between the shoulders and the head to ensure they don't come back. If they don't take this precaution, there's a chance the resurrected body will scratch and pound at the inside of its vault until it breaks free. Only those who have proven themselves trustworthy are brought into the order. If people learned that their loved ones weren't resting easy in these graves, it would be a disaster. No one would want to bury their loved ones here, and scientists would be out here digging the place up.

The House of Sleep: The now-standard procedure is for newly interred caskets to be dug up the night after burial, then brought to this large, centrally located utility building. Here the Sleep Makers congregate and ensure that their charges are truly laid to rest. The spinal severing is a solemn, respectful act.

The Shallows: Well beyond the walls of the cemeteries lies a private lot where members of the Void Wisdom Circle cult bury their dead in shallow graves. The cult prepares the bodies so they don't immediately decay and ensures they

come back to life with some intelligence, which they use to pursue their necromantic rites. The plan is to eventually defeat death itself.

- **The Hungry Dead (page 84):** A necromancer's experiment has gone wrong, and a wave of angry zombies is about to descend Mount Royal.

NOTRE-DAME BASILICA

Constructed in the 1820s, this beautiful church is famous for its Gothic architecture and stained-glass windows, but among the Templars, it's known as a bastion of peace and healing.

The Church and the Templars have long worked in partnership in Montreal. Some clergy and lay leaders have even secretly been Templar agents. It's no surprise then that the Basilica has been a Templar stronghold since its founding. During its earliest days, it served as a meeting space and rallying point for the Templars fighting against both the Illuminati and the horrors of the Secret World. As the Templars lost their influence, the Church took an equally important but less militant role.

In the early 20th century, the basilica became an informal Templar infirmary. Templars wounded in battle, or suffering supernatural ailments, could recover here under the watchful eye of medical providers who wouldn't ask questions about claw marks or bullet holes. The healers were always on the lookout for new and innovative ways to get their patients back on their feet. In 1970, they made a breakthrough on Mount Royal.

The healers discovered what the Sleep Makers of Mount Royal already knew: those buried in the mountain's soil could return to life. Using samples of this soil, Templar alchemists created a treatment that could restore not just the dead, but the wounded as well. They had to insert just the right chemicals into the wounded body, then bury it in a prepared plot in a chamber beneath the basilica. It was a painful process, but it could bring back those on the edge of death—or beyond.

OSLER LIBRARY OF THE HISTORY OF MEDICINE

Dr. William Osler was the father of modern medicine. In addition to being a brilliant physician in his own right, he was a writer, professor,

and creator of the modern medical residency program. He was also an unwitting agent of the Illuminati. Under their subtle guidance, he explored the shadowy realms where medicine overlaps with the unnatural.

Upon Osler's death in 1919, his personal library was collected from his office in England and transferred to his alma mater, McGill University in Montreal. Here, the great archive of medical books, journals, and ephemera is open by appointment for public viewing.

Of course, Osler's most sensitive books and research notes are locked away in the restricted part of the library, and are only available for perusal under supervision. Here are some of these items:

Book of Ghouls: This journal details the two years Osler spent lurking in graveyards observing ghouls and learning the details of their condition.

Infectious Oils: Though he does not use the term "Filth," it's clear that Osler was studying those who were infected with the stuff. Most of his patients died horribly, but not all, and he was close to discovering the reason for that when he died.

On Death, Life, and the Unending Hive: A rambling, semi-coherent work suggesting Osler may have been under chemical influence while writing it, this handwritten notebook talks of Bees, the undead, and the cyclical nature of life in the universe. On the last page, in a clear and legible hand, he writes, "This is madness. Burn it."

REDPATH MUSEUM AUXILIARY COLLECTION

For over a hundred years, the museum has collected rare and historical artifacts from across North America. In the 1950s, the Phoenixians turned it into a hub for buying and selling mystical artifacts. They originally dealt only in Native American relics, but eventually expanded to include items of all origins—so long as the price was right. The Illuminati is aware of the museum's side business, and even (grudgingly) makes use of the service itself.

The current head of the operation, Charles Garrison, is a master of identifying potentially mystical artifacts. He will gladly make an offer for any magical item someone brings to him,

no questions asked. He'll likewise sell virtually anything to anyone. The Phoenixians aren't big on background checks. Much to the Illuminati's chagrin, this means that several items have ended up in what they consider the wrong hands. This has led to them sending agents to retrieve the artifacts, and not all of them have come back.

The collection is surrounded by layers of high-tech and supernatural security. Garrison swears that they have never been robbed, and they have the inventory control system to prove it.

- **Special Delivery (page 84):** The heroes are asked to bring an artifact to the museum to sell, but they soon discover that the item is more than it appears.

UNDERGROUND CITY

Winters can be brutally cold in Montreal. To combat this environment, many buildings in the city's downtown extend several stories beneath the ground, and are connected by various hallways and tunnels. It's possible for people to walk for miles beneath the city and never see the sky. Those whose apartment buildings are part of the tunnel network can go all winter without feeling the sun on their skin.

Code Black: The enclosed system in the tunnels is a unique spot for Illuminati experiments. Agent Jean-Marc Black uses a system of subliminal messages, hidden in the underground's music and advertisement system, to create a sort of mind control. Those who spend enough time here become conditioned. When presented with trigger phrases, they go into a zombie-like trance and carry out encoded instructions. The Montreal Illuminati office isn't aware of how successful the project has been, and Jean-Marc isn't sure he wants to share this power he has created.

WarmSpot: At strategic locations, just inside the exterior doors, are cozy nooks offering warm drinks, soft furniture, and a place to warm up and chill out. These locations, each labeled "WarmSpot," are manned by clean-cut, attractive young people. The hosts are welcoming, encouraging—and not at *all* pushy when they tell people how happiness and contentment can be theirs through the WarmingTrends Self-Improvement System. WarmingTrends is, of course, a cover for the Morninglight, which has had some success recruiting people through

this effort. Only two of those people have been overwhelmed with Filth and gone on a killing spree.

Underground Flu: When thousands of people live, work, and walk around in close quarters for weeks or months at a time, there is a high chance of them getting sick. Váli uses this area to test various viral agents to see what effect they have, how long they last, and what treatments are most effective. Most underground commuters are infected by a dozen different experimental diseases each year and don't even know it.

PERSONS OF INTEREST

ALEXANDER RICHLER

A Templar bio-alchemist, Richler has been working out of the Notre-Dame Basilica for decades, where he operates their experimental restoration chamber. He rarely leaves the facility. He is isolated and obsessed with his work, and his colleagues worry that prolonged exposure to the restorative substances have affected his mind. He assures them he's fine. "Furthermore," he says, gesturing at the latest Templar to be saved by his efforts, "you can't argue with success."

CHARLES GARRISON

The head of the Redpath Museum Auxiliary Collection is very old. Behind his back, Garrison's colleagues joke that, judging from his wrinkles, he's older than the artifacts in his collection. They have no idea how right they are. Garrison's true name is Montuhotep. He is a mummy and a member of the Kingdom. As such, he knows far more about supernatural artifacts than anyone else in town. While he enjoys making money brokering deals on behalf of the Kingdom and the Phoenixians, what he loves is helping people understand the mysteries of the occult. He's been known to offer his advice a bit too freely with outsiders, which has raised the eyebrows of not only his own groups, but the Illuminati as well.

GARY LAMARCH

Officially the dean of students at Blackburn Academy, Lamarch is flexible where Greta Blackburn is strict, and he's more likely to overlook students sneaking out or taking risks. What no one at Blackburn suspects is that Lamarch is a highly skilled Orochi operative.

Working for Váli, he ensures that students with psychic abilities or potential just happen to end up in situations where they can develop their powers. He implants Manticore-built micro-transmitters into all his students so he can monitor their locations, conversations, and bio-signs. If a student shows great promise as a psychic asset, he makes arrangements for them to either be hired away upon graduation, or “transferred to a different school” at the end of the semester.

JULIA CARTIER

The head of the Montreal Illuminati has a more maternal approach to her job than other regional managers. She wholeheartedly endorses the party line from New York, of course. Her loyalty will not be questioned. But she prefers to think of the blind, powerless masses as a flock to be protected, rather than a resource to be exploited. To this end, she directs her underlings to undertake missions that increase not only the Illuminati’s power, but the region’s stability and well-being. “A rising tide lifts all boats, yes? And since we control the tide, we should lift our people’s boats when we can.” Agents who ask find that she always has some community project that needs their help.



REGAN CAMERON

The local representative of Anansi Technologies keeps a constant eye on her employer’s investments in Montreal. She’s especially interested in local Anansi-backed companies in the video game, business software, and AI industries. She keeps her influence subtle (“You went *that* way with it? An interesting choice. I’m sure it will be fine.”), but she encourages her charges to constantly push the digital envelope. Cameron is very well connected. She often serves as a fixer for high-tech companies who need to solve strange or illegal problems without involving law enforcement, and she’s been known to recruit Secret Worlders for these “quick jobs.” Cameron communicates exclusively through text, video calls, or email, because she has no physical body. She is a prototype AI construct created by Anansi, which hopes to unleash an army of such constructs in the near future.

MOUNT SHASTA

While it appears to be nothing more than a northern California tourist town, nestled on the slopes of the mountain of the same name, Mount Shasta is a nexus of Secret World activity.

SECRET HISTORY

At the end of the Third Age, when Atlantis and Lemuria were being swallowed by the sea, several hundred Lemurians escaped to what is now known as California. Seeking to hide during the cataclysms to come, they burrowed deep into Mount Shasta, creating vast tunnel systems and eventually their own subterranean city they called Telos. These hidden Lemurians survived into the Fourth Age and became Telosians.

In the early 1800s, as white settlers flooded into the region in search of gold and lumber, the Telosians tried to repel the newcomers, but to no avail. They retreated below ground and secured their mountain tunnels.

In 1863, the farmer Nelson Cash discovered an opening on the side of Mount Shasta while hunting a mysterious creature that was mutilating his livestock. The cave went deeper

than any others on the mountain. Cash and the creature (a ravenous skinwalker) stalked each other through the caves. Cash would have fallen to the beast's claws had the Telosians not intervened, thus revealing themselves to a white person for the first time.

In exchange for saving his life, Cash agreed to keep the Telosians' home a secret. He claimed the cave (later called Pluto's Cave) as his own, and his descendants have served as unofficial guardians of its true depths ever since. While many locals have seen the Telosians, and their home is suspected to lie inside Mount Shasta, the Cash family has kept its secrets.

Today, Mount Shasta is a small tourist town that welcomes tens of thousands yearly. Some seek spiritual enlightenment, others simply enjoy hiking and the wilderness—but others hunt for the Telosians themselves, seeking to delve into secrets they are not meant to know. Visitors are encouraged to fish, hike, spend, and seek illumination, but they are forbidden to enter certain remote trails or parts of the cave system—and for good reason. The caves are being infested with Filth!

HIDDEN POWERS

In the long term, the Illuminati wants control of Telos, even if that means destroying Mount Shasta and the Telosians to get it. In the short term, the society needs to keep the bubbling, Filthy chaos of the region under control before something boils over. The Illuminati's most effective tool is the National Forest Service, which it uses to keep a close eye on the region, and to direct people away from sensitive sites. Its second most effective tool is Sheldon Anderson, the charismatic Illuminati head who, with his team of agents, works directly with the locals to identify and eliminate problems. While some in the faction might balk at his point-blank approach, none of the locals are disturbed by card-carrying Illuminati agents in a town of crystal-toting mystics and New Age dreamers.

In times past, the Telosians enjoyed their occasional, limited interactions with the humans of Mount Shasta. They offered esoteric wisdom and were amused by the people's antics. But as the Filth has begun to permeate the mountain caves, they have retreated deeper into the tunnels. Here they focus on protecting Telos

itself, and trying to contain the Filth infection that is contaminating their own people. They are aware that the Illuminati and others are trying to contact them, but have no interest in working with outsiders.

Once Orochi got word of Filth in the area, its Plethron subsidiary descended on Mount Shasta in force. While the company claims it's simply researching "natural nutritional substances," it's actually trying to capture as many Filth-tainted creatures as it can. Its hope is to create synthetic Filth that its sister company, Manticore, can use as a bioweapon. Though the Illuminati tries to block its efforts, Orochi's researchers are committed to exploring the mountain's forests and caves.

The region's forests have long been the home of a reclusive sasquatch clan. When Sheldon Anderson started his local outreach program, his Illuminati agents contacted the clan and enlisted its help in reporting any unusual new occurrences. The Illuminati has since lost contact with the clan; the agents don't know if it's because the sasquatch have betrayed them, or if they've gone into hiding after whatever discovery they've made.

POINTS OF INTEREST

THE BLACK BEAR DINER

The Black Bear Diner is right off Highway 89. Tourists stop in when they're done with the day's travels and going back down to their hotels or cabins for the day. Known for its real food, real conversation, and being family-owned, the diner is a major stop on the way to hiking trails, the falls, or the mountain caves. Everyone in the area has eaten at the diner at least once, and they always remember the waitress and owners who make the place feel like a home kitchen.

Things have changed recently. The diner's hours are now shorter. It closes right after breakfast is served. The Cardenas family, who own the place, are seen less and less, and only the staff open and close or serve and cook. There are whispers in town about what's caused the change in operations, but nothing concrete.

- **Black Bear Down (page 85):** The diner is in decline, but the Cardenas family has a more important crisis to worry about.

MC CLOUD FALLS

Three magnificent waterfalls on the McCloud River are the centerpieces of numerous hiking trails, and have long attracted tourists. Normally, the falls are used for relaxation and spiritual breakthroughs. Most tourists simply want to walk through and feel connected to nature. Sasquatch and the locals go to the falls to fish or seek moments of peace.

In the last year, the area around the falls has fallen to corruption. Salmon are dying, bears are bloated and sick on the shores, and some elk and wolves are looking mangy and gaunt. Tourists are reporting feeling ill after walking through the falls and taking the trails along the river.

Due to unspecified "safety concerns," the Forest Service has closed the falls to the nonresidents, and even locals only venture to the falls during the daytime.

- **Nature Trail to Hell (page 85):** An obstinate group of tourists has defied orders and gone to the falls. Some are dead. Some are missing. Someone needs to investigate.

PLUTO'S CAVE

Pluto's Cave is a natural cavern that leads to numerous smaller tunnels, many of which were carved by Lemurians. Those who know how to navigate the tunnels and go deep enough can eventually reach the city of Telos.

Since Nelson Cash met the Telosians in 1863, his family and their allies have done their best to keep settlers, miners, and tourists away from the deepest parts of the cave. Working with Telosians, they have constructed false walls, cave-ins, and optical illusions to hide the path to Telos. For over a century, their efforts have been successful.

Now many of the cave's tunnels are dripping with Filth. This makes them dangerous to guard, and even more dangerous for outsiders to explore. The Telosians have done what they can to seal up the corrupted tunnels, but even they don't know where all the Filth lies.

As the Telosians have retreated back toward Telos, the Illuminati, Orochi, and even a few other groups have started investigating the cave. They hope to find the way to the city, but thus far they've only found death, Filth, and corruption.

SHASTA SANCTUARY AND SUITES

This hotel and spa at the edge of town has only been around since the last decade. It closes every winter, but immediately fills every room upon reopening. Guests that stay here are looking for spiritual adventure and conspiracy theories. They have gorged themselves on stories of ancient Lemuria and the city of Telos. They believe the Telosians carry knowledge of ancient origins and can save humanity.

The owner is from out of state and has only visited once, on opening day nine years ago. The manager, Russell Dionne, makes sure guests are properly fed information to keep them hungry enough for more. Playing on the conspiracy-theory angle, the Shasta Sanctuary and Suites previously offered tours through some cave systems. Now that the Forest Service has blocked access to the most interesting caves, the hotel is trying to make up for this lost revenue by selling "authentic" Telosian clothing and artifacts.

Most don't know that the hotel is run by the Phoenixians. The group feels that they have been cut out of the power plays of the other factions for centuries, and they have now infiltrated Mount Shasta in hopes of either contracting the Telosians or simply putting them under their surveillance and influence. The Phoenixians will use any means necessary to reach and eventually control Telos. They are even going so far as to partner with the Orochi in the area. This partnership will not last, but it is mutually beneficial for now. They're also making steady income off desperate people seeking guidance and spiritual breakthroughs. It's a recipe for disaster once the Filth surfaces; their arrogance doesn't let them see the true danger, only the profit.

SHASTA SERENITY SPRINGS

Shasta Serenity Springs is a wellness and rejuvenation center that has been in operation since 1967. The owners have passed the business down for two generations. Harold and Pamela Cash, descendants of the Cash who discovered Pluto Cave, have helped thousands of guests recover their health, mental clarity, and general sense of well-being. They also employ the techniques of ancient Lemuria with the help of Telosians that once freely roamed the center.

Guests at local resorts come to the center for meditation retreats, herbal therapy, and hands-

on healing. Popular and lucrative, the wellness center allows the Cash family to live in a large lodge near the base of the mountain. Few people have access codes to the private roads needed to reach the lodge.

Now, there's a "Closed" sign on the front door. There is no return date. The Cash family has gone into hiding on their property, and blocked the main access roads to the center completely. The local rumor mill is churning, but the only thing anyone knows for certain is that Harold and Pamela filed a missing persons report for their 20-year-old son three months ago.

- **Under Siege (page 85):** Harold and Pamela Cash have a good reason to shut down Serenity Springs, and it may have something to do with their missing son.

SHASTA-TRINITY FOREST

With 460 miles of trails, and a rich history that dates to early tribal days when the land was untouched by settlers, Shasta-Trinity Forest is a sanctuary for animals and people alike. Shasta Forest and Trinity Forest were officially designated as national forests in the early 1900s, and they were combined in 1954 as a nationally safeguarded land.

Sasquatch have lived in the forest for centuries. They're having trouble these days avoiding people that are too curious, and too determined to capture their sounds and images for social media clout. They aren't alone, however. Some Telosians still come to the surface to shield the sasquatch from those prying eyes. Ancient Telosians practiced telepathy, and those who still know the old ways use this ability to protect the sasquatch clans. The occasional hiker who runs into a clan is always turned away, and their memories are hard to access (or missing altogether) when they return to civilization.

Orochi agents are crawling through the forest looking for evidence of the Telosians and their city. They know there is an entrance through Agartha, but they have no access to it, so they seek another way in, hoping that one day Pluto's Cave will become unguarded, or perhaps the guards will be compromised.

The forest is dangerous. As the Filth slowly corrupts the area, it mutates the wildlife into vicious, infectious husks, and makes room for truly horrific creatures such as skinwalkers. More

hikers disappear each year, Orochi is regularly losing agents, and the Illuminati has even called for a meeting with the Templars to discuss issues in the area. The situation is untenable and getting worse.

PERSONS OF INTEREST

LAINY POWELL

A single mother who has helped manage the Black Bear Diner for the last five years, Lainey keeps her head down and her nose clean. She also dabbles in the occult, and is able to mentally manipulate certain people under specific circumstances. It's not something she is proud of, but when it comes to protecting her daughter, Rachel, or her Telosian or sasquatch friends, she doesn't hesitate to use the tools at her disposal.

Lainey isn't easy to question. She hates strangers who talk too much or are too inquisitive, and will refuse service to anyone who is rude or inconsiderate to the locals. She's very aware of the Illuminati (Sheldon Anderson is a regular at the diner) and the existence of other secret societies. She's got no use for any of them. They might say they mean well, but she knows they ultimately only care about their own power.

Nevertheless, Lainey has started to reluctantly work with Anderson's agents to occasionally investigate the local horrors. Filthy creatures are taking over the forests. Some sort of skinwalker is prowling around the mountainside after dark. And now Rachel is starting to manifest abilities of her own. Lainey hates to admit it, but she could use a hand.

RUSSELL DIONNE

As manager of Shasta Sanctuary and Suites and head of the local Phoenicians, Russell Dionne is always looking for new opportunities. In addition to being a confident, muscular young agent, Dionne is a charismatic salesman for both his hotel and his secret society. He has recently set upon a bold new venture with his current partner, the Orochi subsidiary Plethron.

Both organizations are looking for a way into the tunnels beneath Mount Shasta. While Pluto's Cave is the easiest, most direct route to the tunnels, it's also the most watched by both the locals and the Illuminati. Therefore, Plethron and Sanctuary have teamed up to dig their own

entrance into the mountain several miles away. Using Sanctuary's "mystical nature tours" and Plethron's "botanical survey" as cover, they have established a discreet operation to detect natural weak spots in the mountain. Advanced "sonic tunneling" equipment is on its way from Sycoil. Once it's up and running, Dionne figures it's only a matter of time until Orochi has all the Filth it needs and the Phoenicians have secured Telos.

SHELDON ANDERSON

As the local head of the Illuminati, Sheldon Anderson has made a point of getting to know all the locals. He uses his Illuminati influence to help them with government and corporate bureaucracy, and he always greets them with kind words and a smile. In return, they tell him about everything: the Lemurians, Telos, the sasquatch, Orochi ... They fill his ears with local history and lore, as well as any strange current events. They even share secrets learned in confidence, and why not? Sheldon is their friend!

Sheldon actually hates Mount Shasta. He hates the town, the mountain, the idiot tourists, and the shortsighted locals who put up with them. He wants nothing more than to assemble an armored Illuminati strike force to just blast his way into the heart of Telos and be done with it. Now that the Filth has driven the Telosians away from guarding the tunnels, he thinks he might have a chance to see his dream come true.

THE CREATURE

At night a creature prowls the forest, dripping a tar-like substance from its fangs and clawed fingertips. The locals know of skinwalkers. They know to avoid them and to report their existence to local tribes or authorities. This is different. No skinwalker is this tall, this emaciated even after feeding, or this ferocious. No one knows where this beast came from or what animal was used to create the mutated monstrosity.

The creature seems to be the source of midnight screeching from the woods, blood trails in parking lots, and claw marks on windows and cars. It's consuming multiple animals nightly, and people have disappeared. The townspeople never go out after dark. The situation is getting more horrific, and no one has been able to find the creature's lair. If they could find it, perhaps they would be able to finally destroy the abomination.

NEW ORLEANS

Perhaps more than any other American city, New Orleans is tied to the mysterious, the weird, and the supernatural in the minds of the public. It's long been a source of ghost stories, voodoo legends, and local characters who might not have been making deals with the Devil, but who lived their oversized lives as if they had.

Given these factors, someone might expect that the Secret World plays a large part in New Orleans. They would be right.

SECRET HISTORY

The city of New Orleans has had many masters since its founding in 1718: the French, the Spanish, the Confederacy, and the United States. It's likewise gone through a number of secret masters. The Templars arrived with the French but were eventually replaced by the Illuminati, who were largely replaced themselves by massive corporations in the second half of the 20th century.

The Illuminati was in the process of retaking the city when Hurricane Katrina struck in 2005.

A massive disaster for the city, Katrina wiped out entire neighborhoods. Over a million people evacuated the city, and over a thousand died. Even now, the city has not fully recovered, and its population is far below what it was 20 years ago.

There's no evidence that the hurricane was anything but a natural disaster. Still, conspiracy theories cast blame on the Illuminati, who—despite their massive losses—still came out ahead in the end. Illuminati leaders agree that causing or failing to prevent a hurricane is the sort of thing they would do—but they deny doing it in New Orleans in 2005.

HIDDEN POWERS

New Orleans is a chaotic jumble of traditions, ambition, conspiracies, and cultures, all in varying degrees of conflict with each other. Rather than try to control it, the Illuminati embeds itself into the chaos. It goes with the flow: pushing an agenda where it can, pulling back on things where it must. Its regional

director, Colette Reynolds, has her agents give the corporate and government bigwigs all the leeway they need, the better to blackmail them in the years to come. "Watch them. Party with them. Encourage their appetites, and document *everything*."

While Hurricane Katrina was as much a setback for the Orochi Group as it was for other corporations, Orochi has been able to build back faster and stronger than the others. Its biggest subsidiary in the area is Sycoil, which produces tens of thousands of barrels of oil each day. The pollution from Sycoil and Orochi's local manufacturing plants is damaging the environment and the people living in it, but so long as the right palms are greased, production and profits will continue unopposed. The machine is working as intended.

It may seem that vampires have long been part of the fabric of New Orleans, but it's only since the 1980s that they have actually made the city their home. The ones with power are elder vampires, who manipulate the people and organizations around their homes to ensure their privacy and a steady supply of blood. No one will say where the mongrel vampires came from, but they seem have appeared shortly after the hurricane. The mongrels don't wield power except by terrorizing whatever parts of the city they are currently occupying.

The ancient sea god Dagon is seeing something of a resurgence these days, especially around New Orleans and the Gulf Coast. There are rumors of Dagon worshippers congregating in the ocean on abandoned oil rigs. Other worshippers move in high society, recruiting cultists and sacrifices alike. The Illuminati writes off Dagon as just another pretender god, but those in tune with Gaia suspect that the rise in worship means a revival of another kind is looming on the horizon.

POINTS OF INTEREST

BOWER ESTATES

The Bower Estates gated community, nestled in the New Aurora neighborhood, is known as a quiet, safe place for those who can afford its privacy and security. Beneath the surface, however, it's actually a cult compound.

The head of the homeowners' association, Geoffrey Foster, is the cult's founder and high priest. A rich real estate mogul, Foster seized control of the Bower Estates in 2012, when he was "blessed with a dream" and inspired to raise up a white-collar army for the sea god Dagon, who he believes lies sleeping some miles off the coast of Louisiana. "The sleeper will arise," he tells his flock. "And we shall arise with him!" Dagon is a manifestation of a Dreamer, which *does* seek awakening and has driven Foster mad with its mental emanations.

Cult members in good standing receive the benefits of Foster's favor: lucrative contracts, pleasures of the flesh, and near immunity to all legal repercussions. To remain in good standing, they must render up to Dagon (via Foster) much of their wealth, and the occasional blood offering. Each community member is expected to provide a human sacrifice at least once a year. This communal murder pact seals them together in a web of mutual blackmail, and keeps everyone loyal.

Not all members of the community are members of the cult, of course. At least, not at first. They may realize that security is tight, with cameras everywhere, and tall fences and walls. A code of silence hangs over the community. Those who say anything about what they see are shunned, threatened, and if necessary, silenced.

Foster's Mansion: Foster's home is the center of the water-god cult. It gleams with that shine that comes from being professionally cleaned on a regular basis, though most of its rooms are never used. The maids never reach the basement, however, where a large pit has been broken through the floor, exposing ancient river mud. This is where the most sacred ceremonies take place. On high holy days, Foster gathers here with the cult's elect to summon forth a Filth golem that rises from the mud and accepts its human sacrifice.

Banson Park: At the center of the Bower Estates is a large green space with shade trees, a gazebo, and an elaborate wishing well. The well, which is subtly marked with occult runes, reaches deep into the earth and has muddy water at the bottom. Cultists regularly toss small offerings of cash, jewelry, and blood down the well. A creature of mud and Filth occasionally emerges from the well to hunt those who aren't under the

HOA's protection. This blob-like entity envelops and dissolves its prey, then retreats back into the well, leaving nothing but a trail of mud behind. Foster has some limited control over the beast.

Central Office: The central administration building houses the security office, the HOA office, and the office in charge of basic administration. Security officers are mostly off-duty local cops who are paid quadruple their standard salary to keep out undesirables, cover up any incidents here, and ensure that any reports made to the police are misfiled or forgotten. The HOA is incredibly strict. Homeowners who openly defy the code may find themselves outside its protection, and therefore prey for the mud beast.

- **The Escape (page 86):** One of the Dagon cultists has had enough. He needs to get out, and it's up to the heroes to help him escape before the cult pulls him under.

FRENCH QUARTER

This world-renowned neighborhood is packed with tourists year-round. This is great for the local economy (both legal and otherwise), but makes it a difficult place for secretive agents to work from the shadows. Nevertheless, there are a few spots of special interest to members of the Secret World.

Hotel de la Lune: An old-school luxury hotel on the edge of the French Quarter, Hotel de la Lune caters to wealthy tourists who aren't afraid to dabble with illegality. The hotel offers gambling, prostitution, and other vices. With the backing of the local crime syndicate, the hotel doesn't have to worry about law enforcement looking too closely. This is especially true since the Illuminati is also involved. While the mob worries about making profits, the Illuminati concerns itself with creating a pool of rich, influential blackmail victims.

Morts Vivantes: This vampire-themed bar and eatery leans heavily into its Gothic motif, even going so far as to hint that actual vampires sometimes frequent the establishment. Crowds of black-clothed visitors can be found partying here every night until after midnight. While there's no evidence that vampires have ever visited the place, several missing persons have been traced to the bar. The owners don't mind the notoriety. They say it adds to the bar's mystique.

Voodoo Secrets: New Orleans is forever linked with voodoo in pop culture. The tawdry and dubiously named Voodoo Secrets retail shop preys on this connection by offering tourists "authentic voodoo tarot readings" and selling them bags of random bones. True voodoo practitioners are disgusted by the shop's blatantly incorrect portrayals of their beliefs, and have been trying to shut the place down. But the site does have power. The owners are worshippers of Dagon, and they try to infect those who visit their shop with Filthy thoughts that inspire them to seek and honor the sea god.

- **Lestat's Revenge (page 86):** Too many tourists have disappeared from the French Quarter, and signs point to Morts Vivantes as the link connecting them. Is it vampires? The heroes need to find out.

METAIRIE CEMETERY

For over a century, Metairie Cemetery has been collecting the dead of New Orleans. Its marble tombs, fantastic sculptures, and moody ambiance have long attracted people who enjoy the Gothic and the macabre. It looks like the sort of place a person would go to get bitten by a vampire—and it is.

At the heart of the cemetery, far from the eyes of casual passersby, lies a complex of elaborate crypts and buildings whose walls are filled with the dead. When the moon is high, vampires and humans converge here to luxuriate in the night, dance to music both ancient and modern, and maybe share in the bounty of the blood. The vampires claim to appreciate the life they can no longer have, while the humans enjoy the thrill of being so close to danger.

The vampires of Metairie are elders. They have great control over their bloodlust, but they remain manipulative, seductive killers. They consider the cemetery mixers great fun, and an opportunity to find future victims.

OIL PLATFORMS

New Orleans serves as the launch point for dozens of oil rigs in the Gulf of Mexico. These multimillion-dollar structures are huge investments for many energy corporations, including Sycoil. An active oil platform can house dozens of employees, who live on the platform for weeks or months at a time. Such isolation can make people crazy. Some report hearing voices

calling to them from the deep. Other see things, like humanoid shadows, or feel nameless urges pushing them to hurt others. More than one oil rigger has reported seeing an entire city floating on the horizon.

Ares Oil Platform: The latest platform built for Sycoil, Ares is positioned to start drilling into a fresh new deposit of oil. It's close enough to shore that the company's scientists are surprised no one has noticed it before. They've started drilling exploratory holes. The sea seems to resist them here; there have been more storms than normal, and rust sets in faster than usual. Still, the manager of the operation is determined to penetrate the ground and bring up the sleeping resources inside. "We must press on," he says, a manic look in his eye. "The sleeper will arise."

Cloverfield Oil Platform: When an oil site is tapped out, it is capped off, and its drilling platform is shut down. That's exactly what's happened here. The platform is all but abandoned, but a group of outsiders have apparently taken it over. Squatters are extremely rare in the Gulf, and no boats were seen in the area. The oil company wonders if the invaders somehow came up from beneath the waves. So far, most of the investigators they've sent have found evidence of occupation, but no actual suspects. The others haven't returned at all.

Papyrus Oil Platform: An ancient platform that barely produces anything, Papyrus would have been shut down years ago, except that Sycoil rents it out to Manticore. The company uses it as a secret base to test its underwater drones, mini submarines, and torpedoes. If those top-secret prototypes happen to go haywire and attack rival oil production facilities, that's certainly not Sycoil's fault. Of course, if one of those drones were to accidentally attack a Coast Guard ship, that would be another matter altogether.

ST. LOUIS NEIGHBORHOOD

The St. Louis neighborhood was never known for its wealth or stability, but Hurricane Katrina turned it into an urban wasteland. Armies of contractors and volunteers have done their best to restore the neighborhood, but many parts of it have still not recovered, even 20 years later.

Abandoned homes and buildings are common. Stores are few and locked away behind barred windows. The folks who live here are resilient

and doing their best to scrape by, but the economy offers little opportunity outside of crime.

St. Louis is home to several nests of mongrel vampires. They tend to hole up in the basements and crawl spaces of abandoned buildings, then burst out at nightfall to hunt. These are not the sophisticated vampires of Metairie Cemetery, but near-feral bloodsuckers who live only to feed. The locals know where these beasts like to hunt, and avoid such places after dark.

As if the vampires weren't bad enough, ghouls are also known to haunt the neighborhood. They feast on those who fall victim to violence or who simply die alone in their dilapidated homes. The ghouls may be a blessing in disguise; such corpses, if left on their own, sometimes rise again as zombies.

Of course, where there are monsters, there are hunters. The local Canal Street Boys are the self-appointed protectors of St. Louis. They defend the locals against other gangs, while also fighting back against the bloodsuckers, flesh-eaters, and undead. Their leader, Earl Williams, is thought by some Secret Worlders to be associated with the Templars (though his high-tech weaponry suggests a Manticore connection).

- **New Blood (page 86):** Vampires have been a regular threat in New Orleans for years, but the creature that's stalking the back alleys is somehow different, and more dangerous.

THE SINGING OAK

A massive, 100-year-old oak tree stretches its limbs proudly over City Park next to Big Lake. In 2013, a local artist hid numerous wind chimes in the tree's branches. The chimes range from a few inches to up to 14 feet long. They are tuned to play notes within the same pentatonic scale, which is connected to the city's musical traditions. When the wind blows, the tree sings with the ringing of the chimes.

In 2015, an anonymous Bee added their own touches to the musical sculpture. They inserted several additional, enchanted chimes into the tree that ring at a frequency that can't be heard by human ears but repels certain supernatural creatures. Creatures of Filth suffer pain when they hear the chimes, and are loath to approach the tree. Other monsters, such as vampires and ghouls, aren't as strongly affected but have learned to avoid this area of the park.

PERSONS OF INTEREST

DOUG MARSH

Boatman Doug Marsh is something of a legend in New Orleans. For 50 years, the old sailor's been kicking around the coast, working first one boat and then another. He's served on fishing boats, oil boats, tourist boats, and everything in between. He's mostly retired these days, but locals (and those in the locals' favor) still seek him out for his wisdom and advice. Old Marsh knows just about everything about the business and boats of the Gulf Coast.

EARL WILLIAMS

The leader of the Canal Street Boys, Earl Williams has a head for tactics, a love of his people, and the ability to get into the heads of the creatures his gang is hunting. He's seen too many people destroyed by monsters and poverty to stand by and let it keep happening. His secret weapon is Alma Dufour, a seasoned vampire hunter who has secretly taken the young man under her wing. Dufour hints at her past, but Williams has no idea she's actually a Templar.

GEOFFREY FOSTER

The leader of the Dagon cult is feeling his faith waver, even as it strengthens. The closer he grows to his beloved sea god, the more he begins to suspect that Dagon is much more than it has previously revealed—that Dagon is more than a local spirit, but something even older and more powerful than Foster ever dreamed. He knows greater things are coming, and he has a role to play in ushering them into the world.

KENT SUTTON

The local Sycoil executive overseeing the region is officially worth millions, and secretly worth billions, but it will never be enough. For decades Kent Sutton has been expanding Sycoil's operations across the American South and into the Gulf of Mexico. Money isn't everything for Sutton; it's the *only* thing. He pushes his exploratory crews to find oil wherever they can, cut what corners they can, and do whatever it takes (legal or not) to make the line go up each quarter. He's aware that his actions have ruined lives, but he simply does not care. If his

battered conscience ever begins to trouble him, he smothers it in the luxury of his Lakewood mansion.

OLIVIA KHAN

While Olivia Khan isn't a very high-ranking Illuminati agent, she is nevertheless highly regarded in the New Orleans office. She is the ocean guru. She's an expert in oceanography, geology, and biology. So much of the region's wealth comes from the water, and she knows all about it. She's also an expert diver and undersea explorer. She can't help but be a bit of an ecologist, and she isn't pleased by how the exploitation of the ocean is damaging the undersea and coastal environments. Khan is intrigued by the Ares oil platform, and how the oil being sought there seems to have been missed by every other survey team.

NEW YORK

New York is one of the most important cities in the world. Its influence on commerce and culture is felt on a global scale. This makes it the perfect location for the headquarters of the Illuminati. New York is also a thriving center for Secret World activity. While some might say it's for this reason that the Illuminati set up shop here, the Illuminati say it's because *they're* in New York that everyone else wants to be here too.

SECRET HISTORY

After securing its foothold in the United States in the 1700s, the Illuminati slowly consolidated its power in the nation's most powerful city. By the mid-1800s, the society had driven out any serious competition, and claimed New York as its territory and base of operations.

The Illuminati's power over the city has only grown since that time. But it's more subtle now. While it used to rely on crude, strong-armed methods, today's Illuminati prefers to stick to the shadows, manipulating people in ways that they can't detect or prove. Its leaders use mass surveillance and algorithmic tweaks to drive the change they want to see in the world. This quiet control has caused some of their enemies to let

down their guard. Those enemies are destroyed before they know what's happening.

HIDDEN POWERS

The Illuminati rules New York. While the other factions have a presence here, and various cults and corporations operate their own schemes, most of them do so with the Illuminati's knowledge and occasional intervention. (Some of these schemes are noted in *The Secret World* core book.)

Rather than directly oppose the groups that might challenge them, the Illuminati seeds discord and conflict for them. If those groups are divided and fighting among themselves, they're much less of a threat. In the minds of the Illuminati's leaders, they have a global conspiracy to run; they don't have time to babysit the squabbling crooks and delusional millionaires in their own backyard.

POINTS OF INTEREST

BALZOR BUILDING

In the 1700s, a cult worshipping the demon Balzor built a temple on a Manhattan side street, which they disguised as a church dedicated to a European offshoot of mainstream Christianity. In the 1800s, the cult built an office building on top of and around the temple, which allowed them to pay for their location with rents. Since then, the building has been rebuilt and remodeled numerous times, and most of the people who work here have no idea of its origins or true purpose.

Today the cult still owns the building, which continues to serve as its temple. The temple itself is in the subbasement, and it retains the basic shape from its original incarnation. A schism has divided the cult; some feel it needs to expand its operation nationwide, using the money from the business to do so. Others fear the perils of exposure; they've dedicated too much to risk throwing it away for unnecessary expansion. Both sides are willing to shed blood for their cause.

Arcane energies swirl around the building. People here are caught up in the work for days and forget to eat, forget their families, forget

everything else. Some people keep coming in even after they die.

- **Icon of Balzor (page 87):** The cult's most prized artifact, the Icon of Balzor, has disappeared from the temple. The two sides of the schism blame each other, and the resulting battle is spilling out into the mundane world.

BLACKSTONE DETECTIVE AGENCY

Since 1923, the Blackstone Detective Agency has quietly served the people of New York by finding missing persons, following cheating spouses, and digging into the private lives of public figures. It's also a front. The agency actually represents a band of oni who offer their services as mercenaries and bounty hunters.

The Illuminati have occasionally worked with the oni of Blackstone for decades, and often refer work that's beneath them to the bounty hunters. The agency, in turn, sometimes reaches out to other Secret Worlders when they need an expert, or if they're simply overbooked.

THE BODEGA NETWORK

The bodega is an iconic, essential part of life in New York. One part convenience store, one part fast food restaurant, and one part community center, bodegas offer essentials to the people in their neighborhoods, often 24 hours a day. Including all the corner stores that aren't *technically* bodegas but might as well be, there are hundreds of these shops throughout the city. And most of them are part of what some Secret Worlders call "the network."

Network shops have certain subtle occult markings above their outer doors, and over the doorways leading into the cramped storage areas in the back. Those who know the proper incantations can say them while entering the back room of one bodega in order to emerge from the back room of another. The managers are generally aware of the network. They don't understand it, and they don't interfere with those using it so long as they aren't causing trouble. Still, it's rude to use a shop's network access without buying something, or at least giving the proprietor a tip.

The Illuminati claims to have created the network. It has a map that supposedly shows all the nodes on the network (including some in



other cities). But if pressed, the Illuminati can't say who truly set up the network, when, or how.

- **Passengers (page 87):** Secret Worlders are being haunted by strange spirits, but the only connection between the people is that they've all used the bodega network recently.

GRAND CENTRAL TERMINAL

Formerly known as Grand Central Station, the terminal has long been synonymous with high-traffic areas for a reason. For generations, it's stood as a hub of subway, bus, and train travel, a monument to the city's success. A million people pass through here every day. And every one of them is touched by the Secret World.

Substation Alpha: The Illuminati has its own micro-office here to track the people coming and going. The society's advanced facial recognition software means that virtually anyone who passes through the station's doors is identified, tracked, and added to the system's database. Agents secretly coordinate with local government and law enforcement offices to ensure the tightest security possible, even on the supernatural end of things. They have prevented numerous terrorist attacks, and at least one attempted low-scale Filth bomb attack. There are always zealots, both mundane and supernatural, trying to disrupt or destroy this iconic location.

The Watchers: The Dragon has its own team working the terminal. Though the Illuminati has tried to chase them off, agents of the Dragon keep slipping back in. They don't seem to be causing trouble; they're just watching. The watchers use rituals to analyze the chaotic movements of travelers passing through the system. From that chaos, patterns emerge. Those patterns tell of things to come. One agent, Lucien, can read those patterns and predict parts of the future. He shares this information with some people, but not with others, according to the pattern only he knows.

Sunless Gate: If a person were to go through the proper "Employees Only" door, descend a certain set of stairs, unlock an ancient door, and go down three more sets of stairs, they would eventually emerge in a city beneath New York, where the sunless clans dwell. Here the clans fight for territory, worship dark gods, and grow

strange crops that need no more sunlight than they do. They eat the fungal crops themselves and sell the excess of their harvest to the surface dwellers, with whom they rendezvous in Grand Central Terminal.

HART ISLAND

On the western end of Long Island Sound lies an island that few New Yorkers like to think or talk about. Hart Island is the potter's field of New York: a place full of mass graves, many unmarked, that has been collecting the dead since the 1800s. More than a million people are buried here, and more are added every year. If a New Yorker dies without a name, or without a family with the means to dispose of their body, they end up on Hart Island.

The island does not welcome outsiders. It's officially accessible only by a ferry, which runs only a few times each month. It doesn't have electricity. A pall hangs over the place, even on the warmest, sunniest days.

In addition to its use as a graveyard, Hart Island has been home to a prison, an insane asylum, a POW camp, and an infection ward. The place has seen so much misery and suffering, it's no surprise that it's also home to ghosts and similar entities.

It's also no surprise that it's home to a thriving ghoulish population. They feast on the oldest corpses and burrow between the grave pits. The gravediggers suspect that something is disturbing the graves, but thus far haven't had the courage or incentive to investigate. They just want to bury the dead and get off the island before nightfall.

The ghouls have competition for the bodies of the unclaimed dead. A cult of necromancers known as the Void Wisdom Circle has been using the island as its own private reserve for decades. Members of the cult prefer fresh corpses, which they use in their undead experiments, which include raising zombies and creating flesh golems. While the ghouls aren't as interested in the recently buried, the elders fear that the necromancers' midnight boat visits will raise the alarm with the authorities, leading to an increase in security—or worse, the city will stop using the island as its dumping ground for the dead.

LABERGE PENTHOUSE

On Park Avenue, at the top of the Manhattan Arms building, is a penthouse suite owned by billionaire financier Angelo Laberge. Laberge hosts regular parties here for the rich and powerful. Each party guest is expected to bring a guest of their own. At the end of the night, Laberge chooses one pair of guests to visit a sealed room at the center of the penthouse. No one will say what happens in that room. Only the original guests emerges from it: pale, shaken, and sometimes spattered with blood. That guest soon makes certain investments or other choices that increase their wealth and power. The missing guest is never mentioned again.

The Illuminati is aware of Angelo Laberge and the thing in his penthouse. While the Illuminati's leaders burn with curiosity about what's in that room, they content themselves for now with tracking Laberge's guests and monitoring their activities. If nothing else, the missing persons give them blackmail opportunities.

THE MET ARMS AND ARMOR DEPARTMENT

The famous Metropolitan Museum of Art is home to its less famous Arms and Armor Department. Officially, the department is a collection of highly decorated weapons and armor from the past thousand years. Unofficially, it's a storehouse for enchanted weapons and a workshop for developing new kinds of enhanced armaments. While the department isn't technically controlled by the Illuminati, the secret society is its number one client, and most of its employees are connected to it in one way or another.

In recent years, conflict has fractured the once-sedate department. Some members of the department strongly advocate that the arms and armor they store should be made available for others to use. Not all of it, of course. But the minor items—the gun that curves bullets, or the dagger that drinks blood—could be loaned out in exchange for money, and collect rent rather than dust. More traditional members are horrified. Theirs is a sacred calling: to study these items, to keep them safe, and to protect the world from them. To let them out of their sight is a risk. To actively hand them off to others? It's blasphemy!

- **Magic Bullets (page 87):** The museum has lost one of its most dangerous weapons, and it's up to the heroes to get it back.

NEW YORK PUBLIC LIBRARY

The pride of the Illuminati, the New York Public Library contains nearly infinite knowledge. In addition to the broad but mundane resources available to all visitors, the library boasts an incredible hoard of arcane expertise. The top librarians are Illuminati agents. While they keep the truth about reality out of the hands of the public, they are thrilled to share it with fellow Illuminati members. (Some librarians are equally thrilled to share it even with members of other factions, though it's forbidden. They figure as long as the information isn't about the Illuminati itself, the mysteries of the Secret World should be open to all who live in it.)

After hours, a demonic beast stalks the library. The hulking creature cannot abide noise, and it charges on silent feet toward anyone making a sound when the library is closed. Those caught by the demon are never seen again.

RED BIRD SUPPER CLUB

Founded a mile west of Central Park as a speakeasy in 1924, the Red Bird Supper Club established itself as a place where the rich could eat and drink in opulent splendor without giving a second thought to the law. When Prohibition ended, the Red Bird opened its doors to the public. Now anyone could enjoy the club's decadent menu, exquisite drinks, and live music.

While much has changed in the century since its founding, the Red Bird remains a bastion of sophistication and wealth. It has an exacting dress code, and those who don't belong in polite society are made to feel unwelcome. It's a place to see and be seen, where the rich and powerful come to rub elbows with others of their kind.

While the Red Bird has opened its main dining room to the well-heeled masses, it remains a private club. It offers certain amenities only to its members, who are chosen not only for their wealth, but for their connections. No one's allowed to even pay the initiation fee unless a current member vouches for them.

Private Lounge: One of the club's amenities is an entire second floor of fine dining. Here, the truly influential members of New York society—the politicians, the mobsters, the CEOs, and members of the Illuminati—can network without worrying about being judged or overheard by their lessers. Only members and their guests are

allowed upstairs; even the waitstaff are subjected to thorough background checks, and they know enough to avoid intimate conversations.

Secret Menu: Upstairs diners eat delicacies that mere mortals can only dream of: rare fruits, nearly extinct birds, nearly toxic fish, cryptids thought to be myths—all prepared with the utmost skill by the world's finest chefs. The food tastes all the better for being seasoned with the perverse, utterly shameless decadence of the very rich. This is especially true for the rare cuts of *long pig* the restaurant offers. While no one explicitly *says* that they serve human flesh, and would deny it if asked, it is nevertheless on the menu.

Huntsmen Society: The long pig is provided by a cabal of wealthy club members who meet monthly to hunt the city's most dangerous game. They wear masks, and use code names, and play at being anonymous, but they all move in very exclusive circles; they know who each other are. Some fashion themselves as aristocratic big-game hunters of yesteryear. Others are simple, bloody-minded psychopaths. About once a month, they drive to the outer boroughs in an unmarked van, then spread out with silenced, short-barreled rifles in their hands. They typically seek out the homeless, or people they think no one will miss. The hunters often establish rules for each hunt to keep things fresh. For example, they may be restricted to certain ages, ethnicities, or body types. This can lead to a small rash of missing persons cases in which victims who vanished on the same night all have a trait in common. Some police detectives suspect there may be a pattern to these incidents, but they are encouraged to focus on more important, higher-profile cases. No one in City Hall cares if a street person disappears before ending up on Hart Island.

PERSONS OF INTEREST

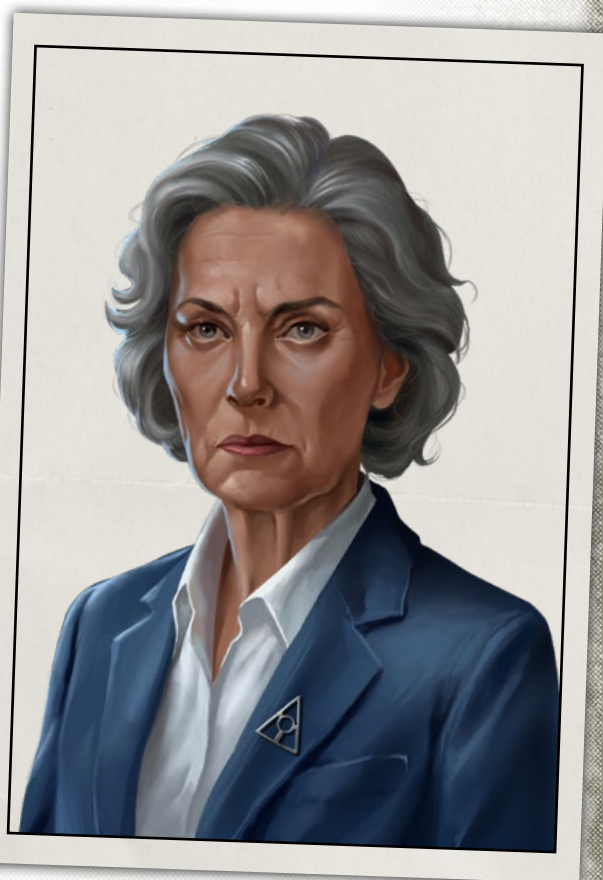
AMBER IRVINE

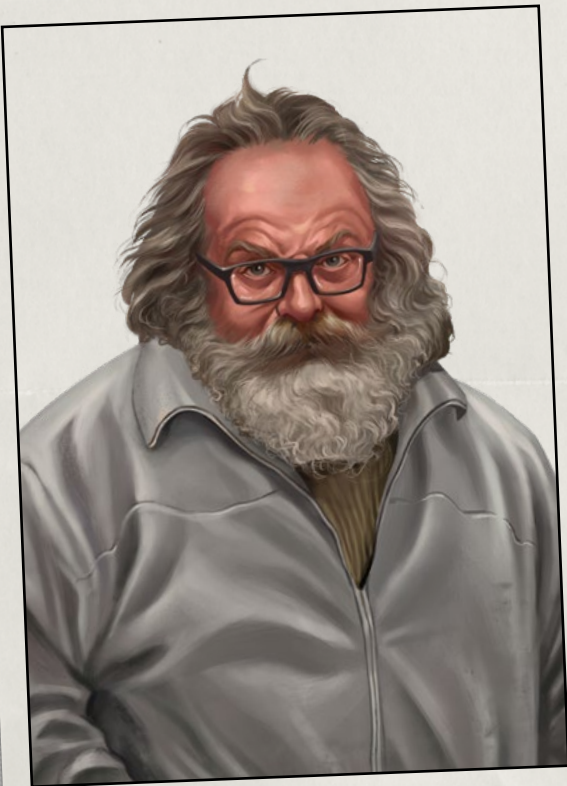
Amber Irvine is a millionaire socialite with inherited wealth and no marketable skills. What she does have is an overwhelming curiosity about the truth of the world around her. When she met a member of the Illuminati, she literally bought her way into the Secret World. Now she's a collector of rare, often supernatural artifacts. She trades favors and secrets with the Illuminati

in order to expand her collection. It's not unusual for operatives to take on side jobs at Irvine's request. These jobs are usually the sorts of things the Illuminati would have the operatives do anyway, and so long as she gets her prizes, Irvine pays very well.

CHANEL MALONE

When the Illuminati have a problem they need fixed quickly and discreetly, they bring in Chanel Malone. She's a senior agent and a fourth-generation New Yorker who knows all the local movers and shakers. Crime bosses? Crazy rich people? Weird cultists and gurus? She knows them all, and they all owe her favors. While Malone isn't a Bee, some folks suspect she's got some sort of supernatural protection going on. She's skilled, but no amount of skill—or luck—should be able to let her escape some of the dangerous situations she's rumored to have been in. Clearly, she has some sort of secret weapon keeping her safe. What is it? She's not saying.





DERRICK GRANT

Derrick Grant, the self-proclaimed “prophet of the streets” knows everything about what’s going on in New York. It’s not that he’s particularly well connected (he has acolytes, but no real friends); it’s that, as he says, the city speaks to him. It’s a constant burble of voices. If he focuses, he can hear specific words about important places and events. Sometimes the most important things (a tragedy, a mass celebration) just cut through the noise. Some Bees have suggested that Grant has some kind of connection to the Buzzing. He lives in his car, and his acolytes bring him food and drink. He is often drunk. He has been known to ask the city questions on behalf of others if they bring him high-quality whiskey. Sometimes the city makes demands, and he passes those demands along to other, more capable Secret Worlders.

EDGAR WELLS

As one of New York’s countless would-be professional actors, Edgar Wells spent his twenties swinging between the ecstasy of the stage and the agony of poverty. He fell into drug abuse. He lost his apartment, his friends, and

any shot he may have had as a performer. He was living on the streets when a drug company rep offered him a hundred bucks to show up at a certain warehouse to help test an upcoming flu vaccine. When Wells arrived, he was stripped, shaved, showered, and strapped onto a test bed where he spent the next nine months, surrounded by hundreds of other test subjects. His captors poured countless chemicals into his veins. He screamed. They took notes. When one of those chemicals boosted his strength and speed, Wells escaped. Few believed his ravings. The warehouse where he was allegedly held was found empty and suspiciously clean. Nevertheless, Wells remains dedicated to taking down the company that almost killed him.

NORMAN BYRNE

Norman Byrne was an investigative reporter before being recruited by the Templars. Reporting is still his day job (though his newspaper’s been sold twice, and his official paycheck comes from a local online scandal sheet). He takes particular pleasure in exposing the dangerous secret societies of New York. He doesn’t touch the real societies, of course—there’s no sense in stirring up trouble with the Illuminati—but cults, conspiracies, and covert political organizations are all fair game. If the heroes are looking for answers, or help against one of these groups, Norman Byrne is the man to call. He considers his investigations a crusade, and the truth his calling.

SEATTLE

An essential transportation center and the largest city in the Pacific Northwest, Seattle has a diverse population and a booming economy. The corporations doing the booming, however, owe at least some of their success to the influence of the Illuminati.

SECRET HISTORY

American settlers arrived late in Seattle. It wasn’t until the 1850s that they established the original town in the territory of the Duwamish and Suquamish indigenous tribes. The early city

relied on logging to get by, but the forests didn't give up their bounty easily. Wood spirits and other denizens of that arboreal realm made life difficult—and short—for loggers who delved too deeply.

Under the Illuminati's growing influence, the city pivoted to building ships, and eventually aircraft. When Anansi Technologies established a headquarters here in 1984, it spurred a technological gold rush that has barely slowed down today.

Beyond Seattle's manufacturing sector, it remains an essential port city for commercial shipping and for the local fishing industry. The port is where the Illuminati has most often had to fight with other factions (usually the Dragon) to maintain its rule over the city.

HIDDEN POWERS

Seattle is a city known for its tech start-ups, brash innovators, and corporate disruptors. The Illuminati in Seattle has thoroughly embraced this mindset. Under the leadership of Kathryn Reed, the society is using its wealth to invest in key companies, and its influence to ensure those companies succeed. Some might question the wisdom of tying the Illuminati too closely to the entities it should be controlling from behind the scenes, but Reed's supporters say that after three centuries in North America, the playbook could use a good shake-up.

The Orochi Group knows it has a rich, powerful patron in Seattle, but it doesn't know who. The executives have their suspicions, but they don't want to mess up a good thing by investigating too closely. Anansi Technologies has its headquarters here, and wields a great deal of influence. Manticore Research Group brings in staggering profits as well, while it collects fat government contracts to deliver high-tech killing machines.

The Dragon once claimed Seattle as a stronghold. As the Illuminati tightened its grip on the region in the late 19th century, the Dragon apparently gave up its claim to the city. That's not true, of course. Seattle remains an important hub of Dragon activities, but the society is much more subtle about it now. If the Dragon has a permanent headquarters here, outsiders don't know about it.

POINTS OF INTEREST

ARCADE BAR NONE

This former warehouse in the Fremont neighborhood has been converted into a massive, modern arcade. The front part of the arcade has cutting-edge video game consoles from around the world, while the back contains classics going all the way back to the 1970s.

Arcade Bar None regularly hosts high-profile events for corporations and government organizations. It's a relatively cheap venue, but it offers unique experiences that even stodgy government officials can't help but enjoy. The place offers a full bar and a deep, exotic menu.

Security is surprisingly tight. Cameras and microphones subtly cover the entire area. Doors and windows are equipped with high-tech locks. Employees are thoroughly screened, and they're given only limited access to the inner workings of the facility. Those who ask are informed that it's because of corporate espionage: they host prototype machines here, and rival companies are trying to get access to them.

Arcade Bar None is owned by a small start-up called ABN LLC, whose members often speak of expanding into other markets. In truth, the company is controlled by Anansi Technologies, and it has no intentions of leaving this site.

Phone Bank: Wall-mounted payphones were once ubiquitous in Seattle, but now there are only a few dozen left—and most of them are in the back of the arcade. The phones are largely used as a novelty ("Dude, guess where I'm calling from?"), but a few of them are wired so that they are completely untraceable. Others are said to be haunted. Those who answer the phones after dark may end up speaking with otherworldly beings—or the Buzzing.

Polybius: One of the ancient machines lurking in the back of the arcade is the classic CIA mind-control console. It's an abstract game that reacts on a near-telepathic level to the player's subconscious. Players can't explain the game or how to play it, but find that its odd shapes, colors, and sounds start to permeate their lives. Those who play it every day find the game overlaying the real world. Though the effect fades with time, players can become obsessed with the game and the messages they feel it's trying to send them.

Virtual Reality: The arcade's most popular attractions are its VR game pods. Each pod is a cylinder roughly 10 feet tall and 10 feet across, with a door that slides open on one side. The player steps inside and is sealed into the virtual world. They strap on a lightweight but effective headset. Then they are immersed in a fantasy adventure, which they act out. Sensors inside the pod track the player's movements, allowing them to walk, jump, and fight as if they were really in the game. What players don't know is that the machine also scans their body and brain patterns. Using this information, it can create a cybernetic replica of the person. While the data for most players is regularly purged, the information for any VIPs who visit the pods is stored for when a duplicate is needed.

ANANSI TECHNOLOGIES CORPORATE CAMPUS

Anansi Technologies is a key player in computers and electronics throughout the world. Its North American headquarters is located in the suburbs of Seattle. It's a broad, open space with lush lawns, coffee carts, cheery offices with sunlit workspaces, and ambitious workers with a cultlike zeal and progress at any price.

The entire campus is surrounded by tasteful fencing that is topped with cameras. Inside the fence, access is restricted with personalized keycards, as well as more cameras to track everyone's movements. No one goes anywhere without security knowing about it.

Employees here are encouraged to act boldly, throw caution to the wind, and do whatever is required of them for the sake of the company. No law can touch them but the laws of physics, and even those can be bent with the application of enough power. The campus is dotted with dozens of buildings. These are the most important:

Advanced Projects Laboratory: This is where the magic happens. Researchers and engineers use the most cutting-edge tools to create ever-more-fabulous devices and software programs. They are pushing the envelope of what's possible with AI and robotics, and their computers are virtually sentient. No one speaks of the high burnout rate, and how often the people here suffer mental breakdowns. They speak in whispers about how the computers talk to them, and encourage them to do awful things.

Business Office: At the heart of the campus stands the five-story building where executives meet to decide the fate of the company in North America. The top two floors are filled with luxurious conference rooms. The basement is where they hunt interns for fun. The executives are all compromised; none of them dares speak out against the company lest his own sins come to light.

Safety and Security Building: This facility serves not only as the brain for the campus security network, but as a garage for its vehicles and an armory for its weapons. In addition to standard firearms and collapsible batons, campus security employees carry prototype weapons from the Advanced Projects Laboratory, which they are encouraged to test out on any unauthorized visitors.

Training Center: Anansi employees who show sufficient aptitude are invited here for advanced lectures, mentoring, and hands-on training. If the classes look like cult indoctrination sessions, that's just a coincidence. The center also includes an Olympic-quality fitness center, complete with a massive swimming pool. Equipment here can remotely measure an employee's heart rate, breathing, metabolism, and more.

- **Robot Rampage (page 88):** A strange robotic creature is terrorizing Seattle. Not only is it crushing innocent people, it also seems to be growing!

MANTICORE AEROSPACE LABS

Seattle is home to multiple aerospace manufacturing plants. One of the most automated—and most secretive—belongs to the Manticore Research Group. Here, the Orochi subsidiary develops parts for military aircraft and missile systems. These are top-secret designs, so the company offers a highly automated manufacturing process to reduce the number of people who are in the know and can be compromised. This adds significantly to the cost of the process, but since the people making the purchasing decisions all benefit financially from the company's success, they're willing to make this investment in security.

The factory's biggest product right now is a series of weaponized flying drones. They range in size from not much larger than palm-sized civilian drones to huge bomber drones that can

cross hundreds of miles under satellite control. Some drones slip into the black market with their serial numbers scraped off, and fall into the hands of various Secret World organizations. These contraband drones are marked so that the company can track how well their experimental designs do out in the field.

What the factory doesn't reveal is that the automation isn't truly automated. Rather than program the hundreds of machines to handle the thousands of operations necessary to build one of these drones, they trained low-level employees, then implanted those employees' brains into the central computer systems. The employees are effectively just brains in jars. Their consciousnesses are asleep. No one knows what would happen if they awakened.

PORT OF SEATTLE

Seattle's harbor is one of the busiest in the world. Ships and cargo arrive from all parts of the globe, and veteran dockworkers are no longer surprised by what they may see. Fish people lurking beside certain boats? Ancient black ships on the horizon? Ghost ships that emerge from the fog, only to disappear when hailed? Entire shipping containers transforming from one shape, size, or color to another when your back is turned? They've seen it all. And as long as they get paid, they don't care.

REDMARSH ISLAND

Miles offshore from Seattle, just west of Samish Bay, lies a small, isolated island known for its small fishing fleet and self-sufficient processing facility. Those familiar with the place recommend avoiding it: there's no regular ferry, it's got nothing that can't be found more cheaply and easily on the mainland, and the locals are downright hostile to outsiders. The only outsiders who regularly visit Redmarsh are the businesspeople who work with the fish facility, and even they don't stay any longer than they have to. "Those people don't look right," they say. "They've been interbreeding too long. They've all got the same sort of odd *look* to them."

When the humanoid fish-frog creatures known as the deep ones breed with humans, it results in deep one hybrids. Hybrids appear human, but they retain a certain fishlike aspect. Hybrids can breed with humans, producing more hybrids.

They can also breed with each other, and often do.

Redmarsh Island is populated almost entirely by deep one hybrids. They used to take humans from the mainland to breed with (and still do around certain high holy days) but have since found a more efficient way to spread their seed: fish.

In 1997, the villagers started their own fish-processing company and built a facility for this purpose. The facility now cuts, freezes, and otherwise prepares the fish to be sold in various forms throughout the United States. The fish are marketed under the brand "Mrs. Marsh's Quality Seafood." The company justifies its higher prices by emphasizing that the fish are caught and processed by a small, tight-knit community using traditional methods. Some of its methods, however, aren't at all traditional—for humans.

Mrs. Marsh's Production Facility: In most ways, the Redmarsh plant is like a normal fish-processing facility, with one major exception. For most fish products, there is a stage during which tiny, pearl-like deep one eggs are implanted in the fish themselves. Those who eat the eggs have a chance of either becoming a deep one or giving birth to one (even if they weren't pregnant before). Those who become deep ones are filled with an overwhelming urge to go to the ocean, and to visit the island.

Pride of Dagon: The largest ship in the island's fishing fleet, the *Pride of Dagon* regularly sails well into the ocean, hitting spots far from other commercial fishing boats. These spots aren't known to be profitable. Nevertheless, the ship comes back fully loaded with fish—including some that have no business swimming in those waters. This may have something to do with the fishermen communicating with deep ones in the ocean, and certain rituals performed beneath the half-moon.

Temple of Dagon: The center of village life is the old First Baptist Church that was built in 1902, then converted to the locals' esoteric religion in 1924. It's here that priests of Dagon preach the word of conversion and conquest. The time is soon coming, they say, when the deep ones shall rise up and seize their rightful place as the rulers of the land as well as the sea—and the hybrids will play a key role in the war effort.

SEATAC PRISON COMMERCIAL ANNEX

Between Seattle and the nearby city of Tacoma towers a sturdy, plain-looking building that houses the SeaTac Federal Prison. In the prison's commercial annex, prisoners earn a little bit of money each week by making phone calls for various telemarketing companies. Working the job is a privilege, and the prisoners are paid on commission. Most just want to keep their heads down and get the job done; they try not to think about the weird clicking and hissing sounds in the background of each call they make.

Those clicks and hisses are subliminal orders being given to those on the other end. Most folks are immune to the sounds, but some are receptive, and obey the orders without question. The victims are instructed to hurt others and themselves, to burn, to destroy, and to spread the word to all that the Black Signal is coming. (Saying the words aloud is rarely as effective as speaking them into a microphone, or typing them into a digital device.)

If asked about the Black Signal, the victims can only smile and say, "His light is darkness, and it is about to dawn."

SEATTLE STAR COFFEE

Seattle has long been known for its quality coffee roasters, wholesalers, and retailers. A small but growing coffee company is Seattle Star, which imports specialty beans, roasts them according to its own secret formula, then sells the brew through a regional chain of boutique coffee shops. Its regular customers joke that they are addicted to the stuff, and that they've never felt more alive than when the Star Coffee is running through their systems. They point out that the company is making good on its motto: "We'll make a star out of you!"

- **A Star is Born (page 87):** The heroes learn that Seattle Star's coffee isn't just addictive—it's magical, and most definitely not ethically sourced.

SPACE NEEDLE

The world-famous Space Needle is more than a landmark. It's also the heart of the Illuminati's west coast weather-control machine. Using its trademark spire as a transmitter, the tower blasts the skies with certain occult vibrations that help

attract warm fronts and drive off oceanic storms. Some mystics suggest that when the Space Needle is struck by lightning, it's actually some sort of retribution from the nature spirits in the clouds.

- **Cloudy with a Chance of Disaster (page 88):** The Space Needle has been taken over by terrorists who have no idea the damage they could do by interfering with the weather machine ... Or do they?

TUNNEL TOWN

Seattle locals all know about the tunnels beneath the city's streets. They know that in the 1800s, the city built up the streets to combat flooding, turning the sidewalks and first floors of those streetside buildings into man-made tunnels and caverns. What they may not know is that the network of tunnels tourists can visit today is just a fraction of the labyrinth spiraling beneath their feet.

A vast maze of tunnels runs for miles beneath the streets of Seattle. These tunnels are full of steam conduits, electrical cables, communication lines, and sewers. They also allow Secret Worlders (especially those sensitive to sunlight) to slip undetected from one part of town to another. Of course, the Secret World is rife with conflict, so travel through the tunnels isn't necessarily safe. Deep ones have been known to hunt in the lower levels that are sometimes flooded, Dreamer cults chant in the forgotten shadows, and the Orochi companies that use the tunnels to transport secret items between their facilities have been ambushed more than once.

PERSONS OF INTEREST

ALLISON MILES

The head of security at the Anansi Technologies campus, Allison Miles takes her job very seriously. That job is to protect the company's secrets, the executives, and the other employees—in that order. She has killed for the company. She will gladly do so again. She's buried more bodies than she can easily count, and her bosses know that *she* knows where they're all buried. Not that she would ever betray them, of course. Unlike her predecessor Daniel Griffin, she is a true believer in the greatness that is Anansi Technologies.

DANIEL GRIFFIN

Daniel Griffin was formerly the head of security at the Anansi Technologies campus. He resigned when he discovered the unethical and dangerous projects the company was pursuing. When he tried to blow the whistle on its malfeasance, law enforcement ignored him and Anansi tried to kill him. Realizing the danger he was in, Griffin went into hiding. Today he lives in the tunnels; from there, he recruits others to his cause of taking down Anansi, Manticore, and the rest of Orochi by any means necessary.

JOSÉ FISHER

For 32 years José Fisher has been working on the Seattle docks. He started out hauling crates and driving the lift, but he's since worked himself up into the harbormaster's office. In that time, he's seen a lot of weird stuff. He's learned to ignore it when he can. When he can't (like when members of his crew start mutating, or cargo vanishes from directly in front of him), he turns to his friends for help. Those friends have Secret World contacts. He doesn't ask where they come from or how they know what they know; he just says what he's seen, and tells 'em what he needs. If they can help, great. If not, they can hopefully put in a word with someone who can.

KATHRYN REED

As one of the Illuminati's youngest regional directors, Kathryn Reed believes in moving fast and breaking things. She cares little for tradition. She often ignores the rules just on principle. If an established procedure is no longer the most efficient way to do something, she throws it out and starts over. Her office is deeply invested in the success of the local Orochi Group. As a result, it's also one of the most profitable offices in North America. Some other Illuminati leaders grumble at her reckless methods; others assume she's being given enough rope to fill the local coffers, then hang herself with it when she finally stumbles.

RALPH MCPHERSON

Ralph McPherson is proud to be a Seattle taxi driver. It's more than a job for him; it's a calling. As taxis have been overshadowed by rideshare companies in Seattle, he's transitioned to driving for them, too. It's unclear if he even has a home, or if he just sleeps in his car. It's clean enough,



but it does smell a bit funky. Funky car aside, McPherson is frighteningly loyal to his paying passengers. Once you're in his back seat, you're family. He'll lie for you, fight for you, and do absolutely whatever it takes to get you where you need to be. Just don't ask him to turn down the radio when the game is on.

SPRINGTON

This quiet Midwestern town goes out of its way to appear bland and unassuming. It's a college town. It's a farming town. But beneath it all, it's an Orochi town.

SECRET HISTORY

Springton, Ohio, was founded in 1832 as a nexus of farm roads and railroad tracks—but its true history begins in Europe.

Cornelius Wilkins was a dark sorcerer whose magic was fueled by unholy rites and bloody sacrifice. In 1840, Wilkins and his family fled their home in England when the authorities got too curious about the unmarked graves on their estate. They ended up in Springton.

In the decades that followed, the Wilkins's power and riches grew. Although Cornelius told his family that his occult studies were behind him, he never truly gave them up. Instead he adopted the name Aroxis and, while wearing a mask, attracted a cult following. At his direction, his cultists carried out horrific rituals that gained them all wealth and influence. Over time, the bodies stacked up. Fear grew. Rumors flew. People whispered the name "Aroxis."

The Fellowship of the Golden Lodge, an arcane society styled after the Freemasons, set out to put an end to Aroxis. What followed was a yearlong battle of spells, gunshots, and arson. The war came to an end during the incident the locals still refer to as the Great Fire of 1871. Officially, Cornelius Wilkins was dead. Unofficially, there was more to the story: his ashes were thrown into the river according to rituals in the Fellowship's prized Book of Knowledge, breaking his magical hold over Springton forever.

Or so the Fellows hoped.

As a consequence of the arcane war, the barrier between the physical and the mystical realm is thin in Springton. Weird things happen. Magic is more powerful. Supernatural entities are drawn to the place.

Perhaps that's what unconsciously attracted Orochi to use Springton as a living laboratory. Or perhaps the company just saw a place it could exploit and abuse forever, so long as it paid off the right officials. It's not a large city. The Illuminati doesn't seem to care what happens here.

HIDDEN POWERS

While the Illuminati doesn't *officially* care about Springton, its agent Nettie Brandt is nevertheless doing her best to monitor Orochi's activities here. This isn't her assignment, but it's something of a passion project for her.

Orochi doesn't publicize it, but it is *everywhere* in town. Its most active subsidiary is Váli, which has its hands in the local university, hospital, and retirement community. Zagan has a food-processing plant here, and Plethron controls most of the local farms. QBL Media runs the only radio station in town, and Manticore is pleased to supply the local police with all the latest guns and armor.

The Fellowship of the Golden Lodge isn't as powerful as it was a century ago, but its aging membership still wields considerable influence from behind the scenes. Likewise, the Wilkins family has diminished with time, but Cornelius's wealthy descendants command a certain amount of respect in town. Most of them don't know the truth of where their money originally came from, or anything about Aroxis.

Aroxis's cult did not die with him. A small circle of true believers have passed down the rituals of the old sorcerer, and they hope to someday resurrect him.

POINTS OF INTEREST

FELLOWSHIP OF THE GOLDEN LODGE

Since the 1800s, this semisecret society has been a powerful force in Springton, spearheading community projects and influencing public policy. While those policies aren't always to the

benefit of the common people, they are generally in the interests of peace and stability.

The group started out as a secretive organization for intellectuals and occultists. Its prized possession was the Book of Knowledge, an ancient tome of mystic rituals, including the one it used to trap the sorcerer Aroxis. It gained power in the region through blackmail, bribery, and extorting its enemies with whispered threats of magical retribution.

In the century since its pinnacle, the Fellowship has drifted away from its arcane roots. Most members (and there are far fewer of them these days) dismiss the group's rituals as empty traditions; they focus instead on community projects, fundraisers, and lucrative backroom deals. They don't realize the role they play in keeping the city safe from threats like Aroxis. They're more concerned with how corporate interests are suddenly displacing them as the key decision-makers in town. It's to the point where Mayor Gaines won't even return their calls!

Now the Book of Knowledge has disappeared from the Lodge's secure library. Jason Blaese, the head of the Fellowship, is one of only a few Golden Fellows who knows the true power the book holds, and he fears what it could do in the wrong hands.

GREENFIELD VILLAGE

As part of his recent push to boost and diversify the local economy, Mayor Gaines worked with Evergreen Inc. (a subsidiary of Váli) to bring Greenfield Village to Springton. Billing itself as a "full-service senior living facility," the Village is one part sprawling luxury condo complex and one part nursing home. It offers everything from spacious apartments to single-bed "care modules," and it provides both housekeeping and nursing staff for those who need it. It's no secret that the best accommodations go to those who can most afford them. There was a scandal a few years ago when it came to light that low-income, high-needs residents were being neglected. The people responsible have been fired, of course, and the Village now volunteers for regular government inspections—which it always passes.

Still the rumors persist: Residents undergo psychotic breaks and need to be locked away for their own safety. Others suffer sudden

dementia, forgetting their identities. Still others are allegedly subjected to experimental medical procedures. But the inspections have never found any truth to these rumors.

- **Great Minds (page 89):** A suspicious number of the residents here are aged members of the Secret World. As their bodies fade, their minds wander. Who knows what secrets they may reveal?

HARMONY HARVEST

The primary processing plant for Harmony Harvest, a Zagan subsidiary, is located just outside Springton. This large industrial facility employs a good number of local residents, and has received awards from the city council for being a good steward of local resources and a responsible member of the community.

The plant's main purpose is to process local crops into packaged foods for sale into either mass markets or institutions like schools and prisons. Its secondary purpose is to develop new, experimental foods. Harmony Harvest's products allegedly increase energy, boost brainpower, or help fight off certain diseases. Many of these products are available at a discount in Springton's grocery stores. The more experimental items are secretly tested on the residents of Greenfield Village. The results aren't always good, and the side effects can be surprising.

NOBLE FARMS

Springton is surrounded by farmland. Much of it belongs to Noble Farms.

Under the guidance of fourth-generation farmer Milo Noble, Noble Farms has taken over hundreds of acres of land in the past couple of decades. Some takeovers were amicable and fair. Others weren't. A few ended in lawsuits. A few of those lawsuits were dropped when the plaintiffs or their loved ones suffered accidents.

Noble Farms grows a wide range of crops, including soybeans, corn, oats, and pumpkins. Many of these crops are grown in conjunction with the farm's corporate partner, Plethron, which provides the genetically modified seeds. Plethron also purchases much of the farm's harvest. It's a very lucrative arrangement—lucrative enough to allow Milo Noble to buy out so many of the other farms nearby.

Mystery Crops: Some “special” fields are planted far from any road, and protected by ominous-looking scarecrows. No one will say what’s harvested there. The crop grows on tall stalks like corn, but the ears are bulbous and mushroomlike. A sickly sweet smell wafts from the fields on breezy days. Milo has a special mixture of fertilizer and pesticide from Plethron that he sprays on the fields every few weeks. He doesn’t know what’s in it, but he’s seen what it does to human flesh. The special fields aren’t fenced off, but they are marked with signs warning trespassers that they will be prosecuted.

Farmhouse: When Milo bought up the Edwards farm, he didn’t notice the old, dilapidated house sitting in the middle of the field. His employees didn’t notice it either as they planted and harvested around it. He’s starting to suspect there’s something in that field—he can glimpse it out of the corner of his eye sometimes—but he forgets it almost as soon as he sees it. An odd sound is coming from the field now, and someone needs to check it out.

Livestock: While Noble Farm is primarily concerned with growing crops, it does maintain a number of small barns of cows, pigs, and chickens. Those driving by at night report hearing almost human-sounding noises from these barns. A local high school student reported driving past one of the barns at night and nearly hitting what appeared to be an escaped pig—though its face looked like that of a man. One of Noble’s farmhands was chasing after it, a shotgun in his hands. Of course, Springton is a town full of rumors. The legendary “pig-man” is just one more that no one really believes.

- **The Reaping (page 89):** Half a world away from Springton, a people living in the shadow of a Plethron production plant are suffering from a lethal, fast-growing cancer. There is a cure, but it lies within Milo Noble’s special fields.

SPRINGTON HERALD

Once a bastion of truth and print advertising, the once daily newspaper now comes out once a week, and is mostly full of puff pieces, syndicated opinion columns, and letters to the editor. But one member of its staff remains dedicated to the truth. Naomi Graves, the paper’s only full-time reporter, is persuasive and relentless. She’s the one who broke the story of abusive neglect at

Greenfield Village. Between covering bake sales and high school sporting events, she’s trying to piece together the connection between Wilkins University and Noble Farms.

SPRINGTON POLICE DEPARTMENT

The police do a great job breaking up rowdy college parties, handing out traffic tickets, and assuring the citizens of Springton that everything is perfectly fine. They’ll be glad to take a report. They’ll look into the incident. But they haven’t done a real investigation since they received \$20 million in vehicles, equipment, and training scholarships from the Manticore Research Group. What’s there to investigate? Everything in Springton is perfectly fine.

While the police are reluctant to look into missing persons, political corruption, or reports of bloody altars in the woods, they’re quick to shut down any sort of public protest or disturbance. They’re here to keep the peace, after all. And it would be a shame to let all this new gear go unused.

SPRINGTON REGIONAL HOSPITAL

The largest hospital in the area, Springton Regional brings in patients from up to a hundred miles away. Its most common patients are residents of Greenfield Village who need emergency services or require help beyond what that facility can provide. While the hospital is funded by a mixture of public and corporate money, a large portion of its funding comes from the Váli corporation. In exchange, the corporation implants its own people (who prioritize profits over patient health) among the staff. This arrangement is ripe for fraud, which is why the hospital pays the city government additional administrative fees each year to keep the auditors away.

The top floor of the hospital is labeled “Ward Z.” The walls are decorated in deep-green symbols that local historians may recognize as the “Eye of Aroxis.” Many of those working in the ward have tattoos of the abstract symbol hidden on their bodies. Virtually every patient that comes into the ward, no matter how old, sickly, or injured, leaves in perfect health. Virtually every patient that leaves bears a green tattoo hidden somewhere on their body.

- **Cutting Edge (page 88):** The doctors and nurses hired by Váli sometimes prescribe and administer experimental pharmaceuticals and therapies. Sometimes these treatments are successful. Sometimes they have side effects.

WILKINS UNIVERSITY

Founded with the help of the Wilkins family in 1860, the private university boasts small class sizes and advanced research programs. While agricultural science is the school's most well-known focus of study, its business, liberal arts, and other science offerings are among the best in the region as well. Wilkins graduates regularly end up leaders in their fields. Its students are ambitious, well connected, and often wealthy.

The campus sprawls across an acre of land on the edge of town. While the exteriors of its buildings proclaim its classic, 19th-century heritage, the interiors are updated and remodeled every few decades. The public is welcome on campus, and the school often hosts community events in its spaces.

Thomas Memorial Library: The university library contains the Wilkins Collection—the personal library of university founder Conrad Wilkins, donated upon his death. According to rumor, the founder's descendants have been trying to reclaim the books and other documents, saying they were given away by mistake. The university refuses to return them, and insists that those items are now part of the library's heritage. No one will say what's in them, and they're kept locked away in the most secure part of the library.

Meadowbrook Science Lab: The lab was established with help from an endowment from Plethron, which is very interested in advancing agricultural science. In exchange for the company's generosity, the university gives Plethron first pick of graduates to hire, and lets it influence what sorts of research the lab pursues.

Delta Tau Society: The university has several fraternities and sororities on campus, of which Delta Tau is the most exclusive. Among Secret Worlders, the fraternity is known for being where the rich and powerful mingle as young people, and establish their connections to the power brokers who have come before. At Wilkins University, that fraternity is centered

around a 100-year-old stone frat house. Here, its members perform secret rituals and commit secret crimes that they use to blackmail each other into silence and service. The frat wraps itself in occult trappings, but only a handful of its members truly seek arcane knowledge. Those who do have learned the history of Aroxis. One of them has stolen the Book of Knowledge from the Golden Lodge in hopes of tapping into the old wizard's power.

PERSONS OF INTEREST

CASSANDRA WILKINS

The 92-year-old matriarch of the Wilkins family knows the true history of the town, and much of what's happening in the shadows. As a Wilkins, she's kept her secrets all her life, but now ... Cassandra knows she doesn't have much time left. Even the doctors on the top floor of the hospital confirmed it. Every bill eventually comes due. She's keeping this a secret as well, but she wonders if she could do more for the town by sharing her secrets with those who could understand their importance, and help keep the darkness at bay a little bit longer.

JASON BLAESE

Jason Blaese is scared. He's no stranger to rituals and mysteries. He's spent most of his 60 years serving and leading the Fellowship of the Golden Lodge. He knows the truth of his organization, and its role in keeping the town safe. He also knows that new, strange forces are at work here. Since his wife died, Blaese has spent most of his time on Lodge business, pulling strings to keep his allies in power and the town on track. Sometimes he needs help. Like now. With the Book of Knowledge missing, he feels like he's in over his head. He needs assistance from folks who know how to get things done and how to keep a secret.

MILO NOBLE

Milo watched his grandfather work himself to death on the farm, only to just barely scrape by with each harvest. But the old man never gave up. Never sold out. And when the time was right, he passed the farm on to his son, Milo's father ... who did better, but not much. Milo swore that he would do right by his father and grandfather,

and turn the farm into a success, no matter the cost. Now the farm is more successful than he could have dreamed, but the cost to his soul makes him wonder if it was actually worth it.

NETTIE BRANDT

A recent Illuminati recruit, Nettie Brandt sees Orochi hard at work in Springton and wants to get a piece of that action. She isn't actually assigned to the town, but she went to college here, and she knows that there are mysteries to be uncovered and money to be made. All she has to go on right now are rumors. She believes most of them, but needs help sorting fact from fiction.

TOBIAS GAINES

Tobias Gaines has been mayor of Springton for over 20 years. During most of that time, he's been more interested in stability than growth. In the past few years, however, he's become much more ambitious, and open to working with outside companies for the betterment of Springton. He occasionally relapses into his former self, canceling contracts and decrying the "degradation" of his beloved town. Some are worried about his confusing behavior and wonder if it's a sign of mental decline. The truth is that Gaines is only in charge part of the time. He is usually under the control of Rocco Irwin, a Váli operative whose consciousness was transferred into the mayor's body. The procedure wasn't a complete success, and Gaines's mind sometimes reasserts itself.

TAMPA

Home of the largest port in the state of Florida, Tampa has long served as a bridge between the mainland, Cuba and elsewhere south. That bridge is beginning to weaken from disrepair, but it remains an important source of income and influence for the Illuminati and its allies.

SECRET HISTORY

When the United States took over Florida in the 19th century, the government established the Fort Brooke military base on the site that would eventually become Tampa. Working from this

base, the Illuminati established ties between the US and Cuba, solidifying its power infrastructure along the Atlantic coast.

The Illuminati strengthened this connection in the late 1800s, when it turned Tampa into a cigar-manufacturing center, transforming Cuban tobacco into American profit. The city boomed for the next century and a half, and continues to do so today. At each stage of success, the Illuminati and its criminal allies have been there to collect their due.

Among today's Secret Worlders, Tampa is regarded as territory that's tightly under Illuminati control. This isn't entirely true. While it's certainly no battlefield, with factions openly fighting for control, portions of the region have quietly slipped through the fingers of its Illuminati overlords, who are blind to how the region is changing around them.

HIDDEN POWERS

With the steady (if aged) hand of regional head George Sarcotti at the wheel, the Illuminati maintains its traditional grip on politics, crime, and commerce in the area. Sarcotti prides himself on keeping the long-term relationships going strong: he works consistently and efficiently with his counterparts in Cuba, New York, and other points up and down the coast. Major criminals and established corporations know better than to initiate new operations in town without Sarcotti's blessing. Those that don't play ball end up feeding the fish in the bay.

Organized crime is a longtime player in the area. From the earliest gambling rings of the 1920s to the networked drug trafficking of the 1990s, Tampa's mob has been tied to the criminal networks of New York and Cuba. While high-profile criminal prosecutions allegedly broke up these networks in the latter part of the 20th century, these proceedings only served as cover. The groups' rivals went to prison, while the Illuminati-backed power players continued their operations from deeper underground. Today, the mob is generally considered a relic of the past, but it secretly handles most of the Illuminati's criminal enterprises in the area.

The Orochi Group is represented in Tampa by a number of Váli-associated health care facilities as well as finance and insurance companies

owned by Faust Capital. It has quietly seized control of Port Tampa Bay through a web of bribery and blackmail. The Illuminati is aware of a power shift around its most valuable asset, but so long as the money keeps rolling in, Sarcotti isn't interested in the specifics.

The Akers are a local family that has likewise steadily grown in wealth and influence over the past few decades. Its members have numerous investments in the region, the most famous of which is Pirate Stadium. Rumors surround the family's great success, and Secret Worliders suspect their fortune might have less to do with business acumen and more to do with supernatural assistance—which may be related to all the missing persons reports coming out of the neighborhood around the stadium.

POINTS OF INTEREST

Tampa's residents are rightly proud of the city's historical, multicultural neighborhoods and prestigious landmarks. The Illuminati is more concerned with the local sites that provide wealth and influence—or threaten those assets with instability. Below are some of the most important of these sites.

APHRODITE REJUVENATION CENTER

ARC is a high-end cosmetic surgery clinic in downtown Tampa. Its skilled doctors use advanced techniques to mold their patients' flesh, subtly exaggerating their favorite features while reducing signs of aging or imperfection. The clinic provides private on-site recovery suites and prides itself on its discretion. No one walks out of ARC with stitches or bruising.

For those with the desire (and money), the clinic offers an experimental "body-shaping solution." Before the procedure begins, patients choose how they want their bodies shaped: broader shoulders, more muscular limbs, and modified facial features are all options. These choices are programmed into a mixture of fats, proteins, and nanobots, which is then slowly injected into the patients' flesh. The solution swells and churns beneath their skin, reshaping their bodies to match the programmed choices. The process takes up to 48 excruciating hours, but the results are amazing. Some patients have completely redesigned their bodies, allowing them to take up entirely new lives.

The center is secretly run by Váli. The company is using the clinic as a test bed for these experimental procedures, which it hopes to spread into broader use.

Like all cutting-edge science, the clinic has had its setbacks. Most dramatically, a number of patients who underwent the body-shaping procedure later suffered injuries or death as the body-shaping beneath their skin took on a crude life of its own. In some cases, the nanite-infused flesh slurry worked its way out of its host and set out in search of sustenance.

After a few of these "flesh golems" carved bloody paths through Florida's wealthiest communities, Váli developed a "maintenance cream" that, when used daily, should keep the substance placated. The company also has a surveillance and control team that checks in on high-risk clients now and then.

- **Flesh of my Flesh (page 89):** An expensive "anti-aging cream" has appeared in wealthy social circles. Those who use it see amazing results, but are plagued by nightmares—or worse.

BLACKROCK BEACH

A private stretch of sand on the shores of Tampa Bay, Blackrock Beach is an exclusive playground for the rich and influential.

The beach is hidden behind trees and walls, and dotted with strategically placed tents and umbrellas to break up lines of sight. At the top of the beach is a large, luxurious mansion with ample parking and a six-mile driveway to the nearest public road. The entire property is fenced and gated, and it's protected by armed security personnel in tailored suits.

It's all owned by Obsidian Holdings, a financial services company whose primary executive is the billionaire Reginald Conroy. Only the most *important* people are invited to Reggie's *exclusive* parties at Blackrock Beach. But what these guests don't know is that Reginald Conroy works for the Illuminati.

It's Conroy's job to seek out the most powerful people in the country, weasel his way into their lives, earn their trust, then lure them to one of his secret party sites for a weekend of debauchery. He encourages his guests to indulge in their basest, cruelest desires. Nothing's off-limits at

a Reggie party. "No one can see," he tells them. "No one will ever know."

But the Illuminati sees. And now it has blackmail material on a whole new set of politicians, businesspeople, and entertainers.

Sufficiently stealthy visitors to Blackrock Beach can gather their own blackmail material, though they risk making an enemy of the Illuminati if they get caught. Those exploring the grounds may discover the graves of the party guests' victims. They may also discover that the dead don't rest easy when they seek revenge.

EMERALD GARDENS

The largest jungle-themed amusement park in North America, Emerald Gardens features dozens of rides, music venues, and restaurants, as well as a zoo full of jungle animals. The place is a tourist hot spot. It hosts thousands of guests a day and is a great place to vanish into a crowd—whether you want to or not.

Emerald Gardens was established in 1960 by Joseph Bacram, an amateur zoologist who wanted to display his collection of exotic animals. The Tampa mafia, at the suggestion of the Illuminati, bought into the struggling park as a way to launder its money. As the park grew in size and popularity, it gained another investor: the Orochi Group. Through its shell organization the Wildlife Preservation Foundation, Orochi used the site to set up an experimental breeding program in hopes of creating profitable animal hybrids.

While the Illuminati continues to monitor and manipulate Emerald Gardens, the amusement park is just one small node in the conspiracy's vast network of assets, so it operates mostly outside the view of the all-seeing eye.

The Park: Emerald Gardens is mostly what it seems: an overpriced, family-friendly, chaotic jumble of thrill rides, animal shows, junk food, and entertainment. The park's surveillance and security apparatus lets it identify and remove anyone causing a disturbance—or anyone that management simply wants removed. Petty crimes (such as pickpocketing and robbery) are met with decisive, sometimes deadly force. Major crimes (such as kidnapping) are carried out with great precision by authorized park staff. The park offers numerous "private exhibition" spaces where influential Secret Worlders can

meet, then vanish into the crowds outside. Most of the park's management infrastructure is concealed in a labyrinth of tunnels and chambers hidden underground.

The Preserve: Beyond the publicly accessible portion of Emerald Gardens is a 100-acre region of low-profile buildings and fenced-in wilderness known as "the preserve." It's here that the Wildlife Preservation Foundation keeps its most exotic animals, and treats those from the park's zoo that are ill or injured. The foundation performs experiments in crossbreeding and mutation. These experiments are often unpleasant, and their results horrific. Some involve involuntary human subjects. It's a price the foundation is willing to pay for progress: its goal is to create new medicines, replacement organs, nutrition sources, and other advances in biotech.

The Hunting Grounds: Wild lions, tigers, and other dangerous animals roam freely throughout the preserve. While they're occasionally fed, they typically hunt for their meals—most often, people who've made themselves enemies of the mafia, the Orochi Group, or the Illuminati. These enemies are dumped into the wilderness and told that if they survive 48 hours, they can go free. While this is a lie, few of them make it past hour 12 anyway. Some Secret Worlders take bets on how long the prey will survive. Once a year, the hunting grounds are opened up to Secret Worlders who want to test themselves against each other and the modified beasts of the preserve. The lone survivor of this battle royale wins an enormous cash prize, a clean criminal record, and 12 months of legal immunity.

The Zookeepers: Savage, mutated creatures escape from the preserve unnervingly often. So far, the park has been able to cover up the carnage they've caused, but it requires constant vigilance. The preserve's "zookeepers" are armed with high-tech equipment they use to track down and secure the rogue beasts by any means necessary. These capture teams hate to call in outside help, but do so if the situation requires it.

GALLERIA DEL SOUL

This chic art gallery features up-and-coming visual artists with distinctive styles. The proprietor, Raul Duncan, is just a stylishly dressed middleman. He doesn't know where the art comes from. If asked, he graciously says

it is “sourced by our esteemed collector, Ms. Hernandez, who has an impeccable eye for such things.”

Those who wander into the gallery are likely to leave with a beloved piece of art in hand. If they leave without making a purchase, the images they saw will haunt them until they do. Each piece of art seems to *call* to its future owner, proclaiming its inevitability ... as if it were the visitor's *destiny* to own it.

The enigmatic Ms. Hernandez is, in fact, a Dragon agent. And the art she brings into the gallery is destined to be owned by certain people at certain times. The artwork inspires and guides. It pushes its owners to make the cosmically *correct* decisions—or at least, those decisions that the Dragon deems to be correct.

Six months ago, the gallery suffered a midnight break-in, and several dozen pieces were stolen. Since then, they have appeared in the hands of collectors throughout the region and beyond. More often than not, these collectors are found dead. While the authorities haven't made the connection between the art and the deaths, the Illuminati have. They've opened their own investigation into the gallery and realize the Dragon is involved, but haven't been able to figure out who stole the artwork or why.

- **Portrait of a Thief (page 89):** The heroes are recruited to learn the truth behind the artworks taken from the gallery and, if possible, to return the stolen items before more art collectors are killed.

PIRATE STADIUM

In 1950, an ambitious but broke young entrepreneur name Harland Akers sold his soul to the demon Zoloch in exchange for wealth and power. In the decades that followed, Akers became one of the richest, most influential businessmen in Tampa. He kept Zoloch from collecting on his debt by sacrificing others' lives and souls as payment. It was crude and bloody work, but Akers was as ruthless as he was enterprising.

After years of occult research, Akers found a more permanent solution. In 1998, he successfully bound Zoloch in a subterranean vault beneath Tampa, and built a massive sports arena over the site. The arena is filled with mystical shapes

and symbols that bleed energy off those within it to fuel the enchantment keeping Zoloch bound.

Now as the crowds cheer for their favorite teams, their passion empowers the demon's bindings. The official chants are even seeded with occult words and sounds that weave the bindings tighter. The arena is both a battery and a beacon. As it pulses with supernatural power, outside forces are drawn to it in hopes of securing that power for themselves.

Akers died suddenly in 2012. His three adult children, Toby, Martha, and Glenn, banded together to jointly seize control of his assets from his second wife, Susanna. Though they can't stand each other, they hate Susanna even more. Susanna has sued to retake the stadium, and is doing her best to drive a wedge between the siblings.

The Halls: A labyrinth of corridors and tunnels connects the various parts of the stadium. Locked doors block off public access, but far too many people have keys to those doors and know where the security cameras stop working. Many of these people appear to be cultists of Zoloch, though the Akers siblings don't know how the demon is contacting them. Unwary visitors who wander into the tunnels may be confused by the occult symbols painted on the walls, and disturbed by how that paint is blistered and peeling. Those who wander deeply enough may never return.

Pirate Center: The streets around the stadium, informally known as “Pirate Center,” are often filled with fun-seekers, many of whom are from out of town. Even if there's no game, the neighborhood bars and restaurants can see raucous crowds on the weekend or during spring break. These visitors often fall prey to the cultists, vampires, and other supernatural predators drawn to Zoloch's unholy aura.

Zoloch's Vault: Several secured stories beneath the earth lies a room with 13 walls, none of which are parallel. It's roughly 100 feet in diameter, and its concrete walls, floor, and ceiling are etched in silver runic binding sigils. It has no door. Those who approach the vault can hear the voice of its lone occupant, the demon Zoloch, in their mind. He offers power and blessings in exchange for sacrifices of body or soul. He offers even more in exchange for his freedom.

WEATHER WALL

While the rest of the region has suffered terrible hurricanes over the years, Tampa has escaped the worst of such weather. This is no coincidence, and it hasn't always been the case.

Up until a few hundred years ago, the area was regularly ravaged by storms that wiped out entire settlements with wind and flooding. The native shamans sought the help of certain local elemental spirits, who agreed to keep the storms away in exchange for the proper sacrifices and rituals. The shamans established seven sacred sites on the islands and shoreline of what became western Florida. So long as the proper rites were maintained each year, the spirits would protect the western shore from the ocean's fury.

Over the centuries, knowledge of the rituals has been lost. Today, only a handful of people—mostly descendants of the original tribes and their European allies—are even aware of the legend of the weather wall. They know of only three sacred sites (two on uninhabited Tampa Bay islands, a third in the heart of a gated shoreline

community), and they aren't positive that the rites they half remember are being performed correctly.

If the last of the spirit keepers or sacred sites should fall, Tampa would lose its protection. The Illuminati is aware of the situation, but hasn't decided whether or how to interfere. While the local Illuminati are interested in finding the lost sites and rebuilding the wall, those in New York are considering how a massive loss of Floridian life and property might be beneficial to their wealth and power.

- **Treasure Map (page 90):** A scholar has discovered a map that allegedly leads to one of the lost sacred sites. Whoever controls the site can wield terrible power over the region's deadly storms.

PERSONS OF INTEREST

ANSEL CONNORS

Connors was a biologist working for the Wildlife Preservation Foundation until he was fired for performing unauthorized experiments inside the Emerald Gardens preserve. He was genetically combining ak'ab from Boston with a stock of captive ghouls he'd somehow smuggled in from Atlanta. It wasn't that his crossbreeding programs were unethical (the foundation doesn't care about such things). The problem was that although the resulting abominations were great at digging, they served no benefit to the company. They were destroyed, along with Connors's research. Cut off from the foundation, Connors is allegedly pursuing legitimate biology, but he has secretly secured a new sponsor for his mad science.

GEORGE SARCOTTI

The head of the Tampa Illuminati looks like an old-school mafioso—because that's precisely what he is. The heavysset, cigar-smoking man in the tailored suits is one of the secret society's oldest leaders, and was in fact the head of the local mafia until the 1980s. Sarcotti believes in doing things the old-fashioned way: bribery, blackmail, implied threats, and violence shocking enough to serve as a warning to everyone else. The Illuminati's current leadership doesn't



care for his methods, but can't argue with his results. Besides, he knows where all the bodies are buried. Sarcotti likes to keep an active hand in what he considers "his territory" and often directs Illuminati operations here personally.

REGINALD CONROY

Reginald Conroy does not exist. The financier playboy is a role that has been played by a series of Illuminati agents. They are chosen carefully for this delicate position, and traded out every few years. Partially to hide the transition, Conroy has many associates but no close friends. He only has clients and victims. Unless he's personally overseeing a bacchanalia in the privacy of his beachfront mansion, Conroy is never without at least one security guard.

SCOTT RICIMAIL

The so-called "prophet of the beach" spends his days swimming in the ocean off Davis Beach. His long, dark hair seems to always be wet, even hours after leaving the water, and he's constantly muttering to himself. Though he's been arrested multiple times for vagrancy and disturbing the peace, the locals know him to be mostly harmless. They leave him food and fresh water at the dilapidated seaside shack where he sleeps. In return, he sometimes offers words of prophetic wisdom. No one knows where Scott gets his information. Some Secret Worlders are curious, but most would rather use him to help predict the future than risk the asset by discovering how he does it.

VANESSA SANTIAGO

A tough, former undercover cop, Santiago now works as a private detective specializing in missing persons cases in the Tampa Bay region. She spends most of her time looking for runaways and elderly folks with memory issues and rich relatives. Recently, she's been hired by a wealthy client to look for a missing man—a mundane office drone who vanished during a football game at Pirate Stadium. While she hasn't found the subject yet, she has found a pattern of disappearances in the neighborhood. She's decided to call in some friends and start digging deeper.

VANCOUVER

Vancouver is Canada's most densely populated, culturally diverse city. It's a gleaming, modern metropolis on the edge of a dark, primeval forest. Vancouver has long thrived in the balance between high-tech ambitions and respect for traditions and the environment. But if things continue the way they are going, that balance is about to be disrupted.

SECRET HISTORY

The indigenous inhabitants of the Vancouver area knew to fear and respect the forest. They whispered stories of monsters lurking in the woods, and passed these tales from one tribe to another, and from one generation to the next. Most natives stuck to the coastlines, where the fishing was good and the ground was fertile. Those who set out into the dense trees were rarely seen again.

In the mid-1800s, Europeans began to descend upon Vancouver en masse. They sought their fortune in gold mining and lumber. Many of them found it. The Illuminati appeared in the area shortly after the first settlers struck it rich. If there was money to be made here, the Illuminati wanted to be part of it. To that end, the secret society helped develop the city's port and turn the place into a transportation hub.

Over the next century, business boomed. In time, the Illuminati learned that if people tried to push into the forest too far or too fast, bad things happened. Something dangerous lurked behind those trees. The Illuminati couldn't tell exactly what it was, but so long as there was money to be made elsewhere, it was willing to let it go, and to influence the rest of Vancouver to do likewise.

Now Vancouver's businesses are fat with success and are eagerly looking for new places to develop. The Illuminati has thus far directed those businesses away from the darkest woods, but their dam may not be enough to withstand the tidal wave of investment pouring into the city.

HIDDEN POWERS

While the Illuminati is by far the most influential faction in Vancouver, it is not unified in its vision for the future. The current leaders steadily maintain the traditional line: they encourage exploitation, so long as it doesn't stray too deeply into the forest. The new generation of Illuminati aren't convinced the old ways are still needed. They point out that they have satellites, drones, flamethrowers, and machine guns. There's nothing in the woods that should frighten them away from maximizing profits.

Orochi and its subsidiaries are definitely on board with the idea of expanding into the woods. While logging is always a lucrative pursuit, the corporation is actually more interested in the rare fungi found in the Pacific Northwest. Its scientists are also curious about the surprising amount of Zero-Point Pathogen they've found, and they're wondering about its profitable uses.

For its part, the forest has started to fight back. The nature spirits and other entities that call it home are willing to kill to preserve their territory. Some, like the Black Tongue werewolf pack, are looking for any excuse to slaughter those who would invade their sacred spaces.

POINTS OF INTEREST

DREAM MARKET

In one of the rougher parts of Vancouver's Downtown Eastside neighborhood, this boarded-up former retail store offers unusual, highly illegal drugs to those who can afford them. The interior of this drug den is much more hygienic than its exterior would suggest. Clean couches and chairs line the walls, and quiet music drifts in from recessed speakers. The windows are walled off, and every corner contains a hidden camera.

This place, known as the dream market, is a Váli project. The company uses it to test new pharmaceuticals in the wild. While the laboratory isn't a very controlled environment, it comes with countless test subjects—and few will investigate if those subjects go missing. Company doctors drift in among the users, taking blood samples and recording the results of their trials.

The locals don't know or care who's behind the operation. So long as the drug users stay in the market and don't cause problems on the streets, not even the police are going to look into it.

Below are some of the dream market's most popular products.

Dreamstuff: Those who ingest this drug experience a shared hallucination. They see a vast prairie dotted with hundreds of freestanding doors, and faceless giants who cry out to them in symbols they can't understand. They also see each other. Some even report seeing dead loved ones when under the influence of dreamstuff.

Hyperdyne: For those who don't want to sleep, hyperdyne is the drug of choice. Users under its influence create art: sculpting, drawing, writing poetry, or even crafting manifestos. It's not always coherent, but it's fast and impassioned.

Fluff: Users say it's like being a cloud. Fluff kills all pain (both physical and emotional) while leaving the rest of the user's senses intact. Váli hopes to use it as an anesthetic eventually. It would be worth a fortune on the street, except that outside of clinical control, a single dose will kill.

THE FOREST

The vast, ancient forests surrounding Vancouver make it the lumber capital of Canada. The city was founded on forestry, and it officially remains committed to the responsible use of this natural resource. Everyone knows that working in the forest can be dangerous, but not everyone knows why. Those who work here know. They know when the woods are turning against them, and when it's time to pack it in for the day. Newcomers might call them superstitious, but once they see the horrors of the forest, they come around—or they might not come back at all.

Fungal Valleys: In the shadowed, wooded valleys, ancient fungi grow. Loggers know to avoid these places. They recognize the bone-colored mushroom caps and know the spores can cause long-lasting lung damage; they don't know it can turn them into fungal zombies. Both professional and amateur explorers come here seeking new types of fungus; some carry authorization, while some carry weapons. Not all of them make it back. Zagan wants to turn the fungi into cheap foodstuffs. Váli wants to turn them into pharmaceuticals. Both have had some

success growing them in special Filth-infested gardens, but always with terrible side effects.

Howling Glade: Werewolves calling themselves the Black Tongues form a large pack that has claimed the remotest reaches of the forest as its territory. The creatures have been here since the early 1900s, and they mostly want to be left in peace. While the youngest members of the pack seethe with bloodlust, the elders try to keep them in check and steer them toward natural prey—which includes the occasional poacher. Some youths refuse to be constrained, and stalk the edges of the forest looking for loggers, mushroom hunters, and real estate developers. The werewolves know many secrets of the forest. They are violently suspicious of those who knowingly encroach on their domain, but they might be convinced to help those who share a common enemy.

Druid Grove: Most of the forest is owned by the government, which leases the logging rights to various companies. Several hundred acres of woodland are owned outright, however, by the McBride family, who have held the land for generations. The remote site contains a rambling, three-story house, as well as numerous outbuildings. The McBride clan and their friends here claim to be druids. They worship the ancient gods of the forest with rituals and blood sacrifices. They set traps around the property and attack loggers or hunters who trespass. Though the government isn't interested in selling, the McBrides are forever trying to buy up more of the surrounding forest. The land, they say, is calling to them.

- **Wood Song (page 90):** The voice of Gaia is strangely strong in British Columbia's wooded wilderness, but only the Bees can truly understand what she's saying.

GASTOWN

Before Vancouver even bore that name, the city's heart was Gastown. That tiny village has grown into one of the finest cities in North America, but the Gastown neighborhood persists. It retains the charms of cobblestone streets and classic architecture, and it is a popular district for both tourists and locals to explore. There's always something new and trendy on the streets of Gastown—and something dark and terrible beneath them.

Steam Clock: Though it looks like a relic from the 1800s, the iconic clock was installed in 1977 and is connected to the city's subterranean steam tunnels. Officially, the clock's creator built similar devices in Japan, the United States, and elsewhere in Canada. Unofficially, copies of these clocks have appeared in France, Russia, Egypt, and Australia. There is no evidence that the clocks are connected through some sort of space-time transport network. The stories that strange-looking people have stepped out of the Gastown clock in the middle of the night are merely rumors.

Brain Food: This trendy restaurant is known as the hangout of high-rolling tech entrepreneurs. These start-up gurus come here for exotic dishes unlike anything else in the area. The heart of these dishes is the locally grown mushrooms. While the restaurant claims the fungi come from an expensive private garden just outside town, they're actually grown in the Zagan labs. Those who consume the mushrooms open their minds to the Dreamers. Some mushroom lovers are inspired to cut roads into the forest and open it up to development. Others are slowly turning into something no longer human.

- **Sprouts (page 90):** Fungal zombies are rare in urban environments, so when the third one shows up in Gastown, it's time to investigate.

NATURAL THERAPEUTICS

Natural Therapeutics is a chain of spas throughout the Vancouver metro area. The spas offer a secret treatment using "all-natural herbs" that enhance the mind while soothing the body. Those who immerse themselves in the herbal tubs are filled with euphoria and report hearing soothing voices.

What they don't report is that late at night, those same voices urge them to harm others. The voices point out how *miserable* everyone is, and how people just make each other *more miserable*, and how the world would be *less miserable* with fewer people in it. Really, it would be an act of compassion to reduce the population. To kill would be to love.

PORT MOODY MYSTERY HOUSE

In the suburb of Port Moody, on a quiet residential street, a bright-yellow house gleams like new though it's been uninhabited for years.

Sometimes, at sunset, the front door opens and an inviting glow pours out onto the sidewalk.

Some say the house is haunted. Some say it's cursed. Everyone in the neighborhood has heard a tale of someone entering the house and coming back with a different language, a different face, or a different personality. Sometimes they don't come back at all.

Those who investigate the mystery house may discover that it's owned by Wagner Holdings, an American real estate investment firm in which Faust Capital holds a significant stake. The firm owns hundreds of uninhabited residential properties throughout North America. There have been accusations that Wagner is using these investments to launder money or illegally manipulate market prices. None of these accusations have held up in court.

VANCOUVER POLICE DEPARTMENT DOWNTOWN DIVISION

The VPD substation for the downtown division is the test site for the CyberPal law enforcement drone program.

CyberPal is the first generation of artificially intelligent drones produced by Odin Eye Concepts, a subsidiary of Anansi Technologies. The company provides the drone program to the VPD at no charge, so long as it is allowed to embed its own engineers and researchers into the department.

Drone Pals: These automated robotic machines patrol neighborhoods, watching with their dead machine eyes across all light and heat spectrums, listening for gunshots, and issuing warnings from their speakers. Some travel on four feet like dogs, some fly, and one actually walks like a human. Experienced operators are supposed to monitor the drones at all times and manually take over if a problem arises, but the machines are so well trained, the operators wander off sometimes.

Advanced Drones: Like their basic counterparts, the advanced drones have sensors that allow them to learn about their designated environments. Unlike them, they are armed. These drones are sent into dangerous conditions like hostage or terrorist situations. While the VPD assures the public that the machines pose no more threat than an average cop, the department was recently sued when a drone killed a child

holding a stick that its AI brain perceived as a gun.

Cyber Cops: In addition to its drones, Odin Eye offers the police a wide array of experimental gear to test in the field. This includes everything from x-ray goggles to stun batons to full-blown suits of tactical armor. The rumors of these devices driving their users power-mad have never been proven, but there are some officers who refuse to use them.

- **Cyber Spree (page 90):** The drones have been acting strangely lately and seem to be poking into Illuminati business. The heroes need to put a stop to it before it causes a serious problem.

PERSONS OF INTEREST

ALEXIS RASMUSSEN

For over a decade, Alexis Rasmussen has been watching the manholes and sewer grates on the streets of Gastown. She knows what she saw. Others might think she's paranoid, and maybe she is, but after that monstrosity took her friends, she has every right to be paranoid. There is a horror beneath the streets, but no one believes her.

IVAN HALL

A recent transplant from Seattle, Illuminati agent Ivan Hall is frustrated by what he sees as money left on the table in Vancouver. There are so many resources here to be exploited! So many people to blackmail and companies to corrupt! He's a divisive figure in local Illuminati politics. On the one hand, his bold vision for maximum payout has led to an increase in money (and power) recently. On the other, his recklessness could easily upset the balance the faction currently holds in the region, giving up long-term stability for short-term profits. Still, some of the locals really like what he's saying, and are encouraging him to try to move into a higher position.

JUNIOR RUST

Jonathan "Junior" Rust isn't what you'd call a community-minded individual. Nevertheless, as a drug dealer, he's concerned about the well-being of the part of the community that's comprised of his clients—and the dream market

is not good for them. Too many of his customers (and friends) have vanished after visiting the dream market. Junior's been at this game a while. He knows how so-called drug dens work. But this is something different. This is professional. He assumes it's cartels. He's started poking at it himself, trying to see what's going on (where are they getting their drugs?), and coordinating with like-minded criminals to see about pushing out or eliminating this newcomer.

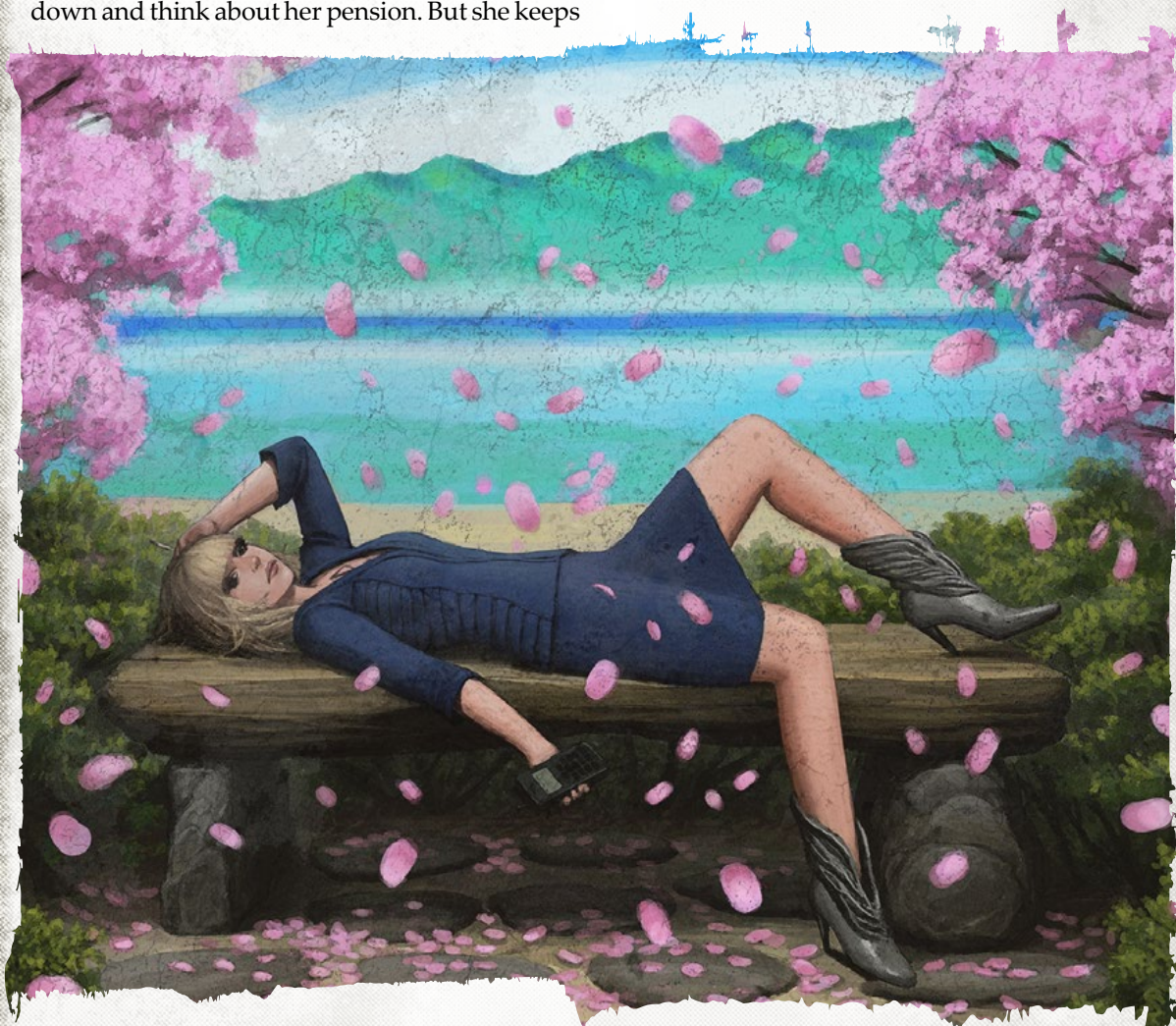
KAREN WATTS

Detective Watts has been working the streets of Vancouver for 20 years, and she's learned to trust her gut. Her gut tells her that the CyberPal program is rotten. She's seen the incident reports about drones harassing and attacking innocent civilians. She's never seen the follow-up reports. When she asks questions about funding and the ultimate goal for the program, she's told to pipe down and think about her pension. But she keeps

pushing, and now she's getting threatening texts from anonymous sources. She knows she's onto something, but she might need help to get to the bottom of it.

LEWIS BARKER

Lewis Barker has worked for every pharmaceutical company in Canada at one time or another. He's a master of chemistry, biology, and the legal limits of meddling with both of them. For the past five years, he's been consulting with all the drug companies in Vancouver, offering them tips, hints, and the occasional breakthrough. If anyone wants to know what's going on in the industry, they could do a lot worse than talking with Barker. Of course, as a Dragon agent, Barker's advice and information are part of his mission from Seoul. What exactly that means, no one knows, other than that he's trying to popularize fungus-based medicines.





CHAPTER THREE: HEROES OF NORTH AMERICA

This chapter presents new options for creating characters for the Secret World roleplaying game. While these new types of characters have their origins in North America, they can be found anywhere in the world.

None of the new character types are Bees. One of them doesn't have any supernatural abilities whatsoever. Players who wish to introduce non-Bee characters into an all-Bee campaign should talk with their GM and the other players to make sure everyone is pleased with the arrangement. There's a big difference between an immortal, superpowered Bee and an all-too-mortal agent with a gun, a knife, and some powerful friends on speed dial.

The three new character types are as follows:

Boston Witch: These magic wielders can boost their spells by performing elaborate rituals. They can also implant their spells into mundane objects, creating temporary magical items.

Illuminati Operative: While these operatives have no spells or powers of their own, they are skilled warriors who know how to wield both the Illuminati's weapons and its influence.

Mystic: These Secret Worlders speak with the spirits, who give them power, wisdom, and knowledge in exchange for their favors. It's not always clear who is serving whom.

MAKING NON-BEE CHARACTERS

The Secret World core book details how to create a Bee hero. Below are rules for creating characters who are not Bees, but are nevertheless powerful agents of both Gaia and their chosen factions.

Creating non-Bee characters follows the rules found in *Savage Worlds* and *The Secret World*, except that you choose a non-Bee archetype during Step 2: Archetype, and you may not choose Bee-specific Edges during Step 8: Edges.

NEW ARCHETYPES

While Bees may be personally chosen by Gaia to be transformed and defend the earth on her behalf, the Secret World is full of other heroes who have seen the chaos around them and stepped up to bring order, peace, and justice where they can.

Below are archetypes for three such heroes that are commonly found in North America.

As with Bee characters, these archetypes include starting attributes, skills, Edges, and gear. These elements help define the character's role, both in combat and in the cabal. As with Bees, characters' archetypes are merely starting points; your character can grow and change as you see fit over the course of the campaign.



WITCH



BOSTON WITCH

For those who know how to tap it, the earth is a boundless fount of magical energy. None can say for certain whether this bounty is a direct blessing of Gaia, a side effect of her other manifestations, or something completely unrelated. Occultists have long argued over the true source of the mystical energy, but they agree that it can be channeled, stored, and released by workers of earth magic—such as the Boston witches.

Boston witches aren't limited to Boston, of course, but they trace the origins of their practice in North America to that city. According to tradition (and limited written records), early European settlers combined their rituals and folk magic with the mysticism of the indigenous people to create a new system of magic. Some called it witchcraft. For lack of a better term, the name stuck.

Because they draw their power from the earth, Boston witches are very aware of the natural world around them. Many work in conservation. They are particularly keen on preserving natural places of power, where earth energy is most accessible. Though earth energy is constantly replenished, it can be temporarily depleted, corrupted, or even choked off if the land is plowed under, built on, or otherwise destroyed.

Covens of witches work together to protect and maintain sites of power. Covens are typically cordial with each other, but have been known to feud over control of powerful locations. Supernatural entities are sometimes drawn to these places as well. When they are, the witches usually rise up to fight them off—but they occasionally join forces with these entities as fellow defenders of the earth's magical gifts.

For Boston witches, spellcasting is a ritualistic affair. Their spells can also be embedded into physical objects through the use of runes. Such objects eventually lose their power, and need to be recharged through rituals that conduct energy from the earth to the enchanted item.

Unlike Bees, Boston witches don't simply wake up with supernatural powers. No one is born a witch, but some are born with a natural instinct for witchcraft. Possible Boston witch origins may include the following:

- While growing up in the country, the girl felt the flow of energy around her. No one believed her but her grandmother, and now *she's* the grandmother sharing her wisdom and magic with others.
- An anthropology student in grad school discovered a friendly coven of witches. At first he studied their ways academically, but now that he has realized their power, he has adopted those ways as his own.
- A troubled young woman discovered a coven regularly gathering in the forest near her home. When she investigated, she was welcomed and is now part of a large, strange family.
- A fourth-generation witch grew up surrounded by old money and old magic. While the young man technically has a job, he's never seen the office, and he spends his time maintaining his family's coven.

WHERE THEY FIT IN THE SECRET WORLD

There have always been places of power such as hidden valleys, sacred groves, and ley line junctions. These places have always attracted those who would utilize such power, for good or ill. This remains true today, in Boston and beyond.

In the Secret World, Boston witches offer versatility that Bees often can't. While they don't have the raw power (or immortality) of Bees, witches wield a wider array of powers than most Bees, and those powers aren't limited to the tools they're currently holding.

WHY THE SECRET SOCIETIES WANT TO RECRUIT THEM

In addition to their supernatural versatility, Boston witches have the rare ability to share their mystical gifts with their allies. Through the power of enchantment, a single witch can turn a mundane containment crew into a magical hit squad.

Starting Attributes: Smarts d8, Spirit d6

Starting Skills: Occult d8, Spellcasting d8

Starting Edges: Arcane Background (Boston Witchcraft), Sanctum

Starting Gear: Cell phone, ritual dagger (Str+d4), leather jacket (+2), \$300

ILLUMINATI OPERATIVE



ILLUMINATI OPERATIVE

There are two sides to an effective operative for the Illuminati.

On one side, the operative is a brutally efficient combatant, capable of taking down the faction's enemies—human or otherwise—with overwhelming firepower, a well-placed knife, or even his bare hands.

On the other, the operative is a master of tactical logistics. He can analyze a situation and determine what resources or information he needs to accomplish his mission. Sometimes bullets aren't the answer, but bribery is. Sometimes the shortest path to victory is through a government database. And sometimes the best solution is a truckload of high explosives, delivered by sundown tonight.

Illuminati operatives are painfully aware that they are only human. They have to balance their courage with caution. They have no spells. No powers. No cosmic entities looking out for them or bringing them back to life if they happen to get in the way of a stray bullet.

What they do have is the support of an ancient, world-spanning conspiracy with vast resources and a vested interest in their secrecy and success. With that, their training, and a little luck, Illuminati operatives can carve out a role for themselves in the Secret World.

Operatives come from countless different backgrounds and origins. Here are some of them:

- An investigator with a federal law enforcement agency found some open cases that were mistakenly labeled as closed. Digging into it, he discovered a terrifying, powerful conspiracy. When it offered to recruit him, he accepted.
- The grad student was studying high-level economics and politics when the people in suits approached her. They offered her full tuition, job placement, and access to more research data than she could have dreamed, with one small catch: she may have to kill for them. She readily agreed. Murder was better than student loans.
- When hounded by secret society assassins (whom he later discovered to be Templars), the young man turned to their enemies, the

Illuminati, for help. Five years later, he has joined their ranks.

- A conspiracy theorist obsessed with finding the truth uncovered evidence of the Illuminati. He demanded they let him join so he can uncover even more truth.
- A low-ranking Illuminati analyst was almost killed in a monster attack. She transferred departments, and has been building up her combat skills ever since. Next time, she'll be ready.

WHERE THEY FIT IN THE SECRET WORLD

The Illuminati often sends its operatives along with its Bees on whatever side mission Zuberi has them on. The operatives' role is to keep tabs on the Bees, report back what the other factions are up to, and ensure the success of the Illuminati's agenda, even if it conflicts with Gaia's.

That's the theory. In reality, once an operative sees what's on the line in the fight against the Dreamers, he's likely to embrace Gaia over his faction as quickly as any Bee.

WHY THE SECRET SOCIETIES WANT TO RECRUIT THEM

In the secret war between the Illuminati and anyone else who would threaten their power, operatives are commandos, working far behind enemy lines with few allies at their sides. They are highly trusted by their leaders—and they know that fates worse than death await them if they betray that trust. Their loyalty (and their skills) are well rewarded. When not on duty, many live very comfortable lives.

Starting Attributes: Agility d6, Smarts d6, Spirit d6

Starting Skills: Shooting d6, Fighting d6, Intimidation d6

Starting Edges: Badge of Authority, Illuminati String Puller

Starting Gear: Assault rifle (Range 24/48/96, Damage 2d8+1, RoF 3, AP 2), gas mask, Kevlar vest (+2), pistol (Range 12/24/48, Damage 2d6+1, RoF 1, AP 1)

MYSTIC



MYSTIC

As long as there have been humans, there have been those who are aware that the world is much more than we can know with our physical senses. They know that there are other, spiritual realms parallel to our own, and that they are populated by other, spiritual entities. They can communicate with these entities and negotiate with them for favors and power. These people have gone by many names—shaman, witch doctor, medicine man—but today they are commonly known as mystics.

Like all magical practitioners in the Secret World, mystics have many different traditions and practices. Some specialize in speaking with nature spirits, others with elementals or even the spirits of the dead. Still others mock such ideas as too limiting. There are no such spirits, they claim; these “extraplanar entities” simply take on whatever form the mystics expect.

Nevertheless, mystics agree on the basics of how their powers work: they call upon the spirits for wisdom, knowledge, and power, and the spirits supply these things in exchange for minor acts of service. Spirits often bind themselves to the mystic, transforming their system of transactional exchanges into something closer to a permanent relationship. The spirits don’t judge the mystic. They don’t care how their gifts are used, so long as the mystic fulfills their end of the bargain.

Mystics are at once communal and solitary. Elder mystics often take newcomers under their wing to teach them the “true” way of the spirits. Some even maintain a number of “acolytes” who serve as their assistants while being trained. But each mystic must ultimately choose their own path, with their own collection of spirits to which they are bound.

Most mystics are simply born with an inherent sense for the spirit realm. Some ignore or deny their gifts. Others embrace them and find themselves part of the Secret World, possibly with one of the origins below:

- The boy grew up hearing voices. They told him things about the past, about the people around him and secrets of a world unseen. His family had him locked away, but now

that he realizes the truth, he’s back and trying to make up for lost time.

- She always used drugs and alcohol to muffle the mutterings only she could hear. But when she tried a new cocktail from a friend of a friend, those entities at the edges of her perception came into sharp relief, and spoke to her clearly for the first time.
- An artisan didn’t realize the source of his inspiration until someone recognized his work as matching that of another craftsman from 200 years ago. When he investigates, he discovers that the spirits have much greater things in mind for him.
- After a near-death experience, they awakens with the ability to sense the spirits around her, and dedicates herself to their service.
- The man had no reason to believe in spirits until one of them possessed his body and helped protect someone that he loved.

WHERE THEY FIT IN THE SECRET WORLD

Mystics have traditionally served as conduits between the people and the spirits of their societies. With the spirits’ wisdom, they helped guide their communities into safety and prosperity. Some mystics try to fulfill this traditional role, but the world has changed, and the mystics’ role in it has changed as well.

In the Secret World, mystics bring secret knowledge and inherent powers that are as reliable as they are versatile.

WHY THE SECRET SOCIETIES WANT TO RECRUIT THEM

The secret societies seek power above all. Knowledge is power. Through their magic, mystics are an amazing font of knowledge. When the cabal needs to know “what is this thing?” or “which way did the cultist go?” the mystic can give them the answers they need.

Starting Attributes: Smarts d6, Spirit d8

Starting Skills: Occult d6, Persuasion d6, Faith d8

Starting Edges: Arcane Background (Mystic), Spirit Ally

Starting Gear: Cell phone, ritual dagger (Str+d4), leather jacket (+2), \$300

NEW EDGES

The Edges that follow are by no means exclusive to North America, though many are restricted to specific factions and archetypes.

BACKGROUND EDGES

Wielding power in the Secret World doesn't come easily. Even those who are born to it must spend years honing their abilities.

ARCANE BACKGROUND (BOSTON WITCHCRAFT)

The Secret World is home to countless different types of magic, many of which are labeled "witchcraft." The witchcraft associated with the Boston covens draws its mystical energy from the earth itself, and channels it via ritual into elaborate spells or enchanted items.

- **Requirements:** Smarts d6+
- **Arcane Skill:** Spellcasting (Smarts)
- **Starting Powers:** Three chosen from the list below.
- **Power Points:** 10
- **Available Powers:** *Arcane protection, banish, barrier, beast friend, blind, boost/lower Trait, burrow, confusion, damage field, darksight, deflection, detect/conceal arcana, disguise, dispel, drain Power*

Points, elemental manipulation, empathy, entangle, environmental protection, farsight, fear, fly, growth/shrink, havoc, healing, illusion, invisibility, light/darkness, mind link, mind reading, mind wipe, object reading, protection, puppet, relief, shape change, sloth/speed, slumber, smite, sound/silence, speak language, summon ally, telekinesis, teleport, wall walker, warrior's gift.

- **Magic:** Witches may take Edges that require Arcane Background (Magic), but they cannot take the Power Surge or Rapid Recharge Edges.
- **Enchantments:** Boston witches can embed their spells into physical objects through the use of rune markings. To reflect this, witches can take the Artificer Edge at Novice Rank, which works as described in *Savage Worlds*, except that enchanted items slowly lose their potency. After 4 hours, any unused Power Points return from the item to the witch who created it, leaving the item powerless.
- **Slow Soul of the Earth:** Drawing power from the earth requires patience. Witches recover 3 Power Points per hour. Furthermore, they only recover Power Points over time while outdoors and within reach of soil or living plants. They recover 5 points for a Benny per usual.



BOSTON WITCHCRAFT EDGES

RITUALIST

- **Requirements:** Seasoned, Arcane Background (Boston Witchcraft)

Boston witches can cast their spells through rituals. Doing so takes more time, but fewer Power Points. To cast a ritual spell, the witch first determines the “base cost” of the power, which equals its Power Point cost, including modifiers. She spends half that number of Power Points (round up), then performs a single person Dramatic Task using her Spellcasting skill. While there is no time limit on this Task, she must collect a number of Task Tokens equal to the power’s “base cost.” Any Task Tokens she earns beyond this minimum count toward raises on her power roll. Critical Failure reduces her Tokens by one. Only other characters with the Spellcasting skill and the Arcane Background (Boston Witch) can Support the witch’s roll.

***Example:** A witch wants to ritually cast barrier (2 Power Points) with the Shaped modifier (+2 Power Points), which gives it a base cost of 4. To complete the ritual, she spends 2 Power Points, and must generate 4 Task Tokens.*

When ritually casting a spell, the witch may include any modifiers listed in *Savage Worlds*, as well as any of the modifiers listed below:

- **Increased Area of Effect (+1 per four yards):** If the power has an area of effect, the witch may expand it. For each Power Point she spends on this modifier, she extends the radius of the effect 2" (four yards). (Note that four yards transforms a Small Blast Template into a Medium, or a Medium into a Large.)
- **Increased Duration (+5):** If the power has a Duration listed in rounds, its Duration is that many minutes instead. If it has a Duration in minutes, its Duration is that many hours. This modifier can’t be used on powers with the Instant Duration.
- **Stronger (+3):** If the power has an optional Strong modifier, the witch may apply that modifier a second time.

SANCTUM

- **Requirements:** Novice, Arcane Background (Boston Witchcraft)

• **The witch has secured access to a natural site of power.** The specifics of the site are determined by the player and GM, but it’s likely outdoors, and hidden or defensible. After enchanting an item (page 68) inside her Sanctum, the witch may make a single Spellcasting roll. For each success and raise, the item gains a Power Point that doesn’t come from the witch’s pool. It can be spent normally, but is not recovered after being spent. Failure means the enchantment is ruined; she must spend the time and Power Points to try it again. Critical Failure means the physical item is destroyed as well.

TEAM COVEN

- **Requirements:** Veteran, Ritualist

The witch can guide even the untrained in helping her perform her rituals. Any character may Support the witch’s Spellcasting roll when she’s performing a ritual (i.e., casting a spell as a Dramatic Task). Supporting characters may use any skill the GM deems appropriate, per the normal Support rules. Those with Arcane Background (Boston Witch) using the Spellcasting skill add +2 to their Support rolls.

ARCANE BACKGROUND (MYSTIC)

Mystics seek answers beyond the world of flesh. They explore the realms of spirit, and request the entities they find there for answers, aid, and power. In return, the spirits demand favors and homage. Their assistance never comes without a price.

- **Requirements:** Spirit d6+
- **Arcane Skill:** Faith (Spirit)
- **Starting Powers:** *Detect/conceal arcana*, and two other powers chosen from the list below.
- **Power Points:** 10
- **Available Powers:** *Arcane protection, banish, barrier, beast friend, blast, blind, bolt, boost/lower Trait, burrow, burst, confusion, damage field, darksight, deflection, disguise, dispel, elemental manipulation, empathy, entangle, environmental protection, farsight, fear, fly, growth/shrink, havoc, healing, illusion, invisibility, light/darkness, mind link, mind reading, mind wipe, object reading, protection, puppet, relief, shape change, sloth/speed, slumber, smite, sound/silence, speak language, stun, summon ally, telekinesis, teleport, wall walker, warrior’s gift.*

- **Magic:** Mystics may take Edges that require Arcane Background (Miracles).

- **Spirit Sense:** Mystics are highly sensitive to the spiritual energies around them. Once per hour, they may cast *detect/conceal arcana* (*detect only*) at no cost.

- **Guiding Whispers:** The spirits have skills and knowledge they may be willing to share. Once per hour as an action, the mystic can make a Faith roll. With a success, he gains a d4 in a chosen skill he doesn't have, or a d6 with a raise. The skill lasts for five minutes, during which time the mystic can hear the spirit's wisdom and feel it partly possessing him.

- **Honoring the Spirits:** Each of a mystic's powers represents a spirit who has agreed to aid him when asked. In return, the spirit demands the mystic adopt a simple (if odd) practice, such as always wearing a certain scent, repeating certain phrases at certain times, or greeting the sun by name each dawn. For each power a mystic has, he must choose a Quirk Hindrance.

MYSTIC EDGES

SPIRIT ALLY

- **Requirements:** Novice, Arcane Background (Mystic)

A spirit has allied itself with the mystic. It is invisible, intangible, speaks telepathically, and can't be more than 100 yards from the mystic. With a successful Faith roll, the mystic can ask the spirit for a favor—which often includes going somewhere the mystic can't and reporting what it sees. If he also spends a Benny, the mystic can give the spirit a Strength of d4 for five minutes; it can't attack, but it can move inanimate objects.

SPIRIT BOND

- **Requirements:** Seasoned, Arcane Background (Mystic), Faith d8+

A spirit associated with one of the mystic's powers has bound itself to the mystic. When taking this Edge, the mystic chooses one of his powers. He ignores up to 2 points of penalties when using this power.

SPIRIT MADE FLESH

- **Requirements:** Seasoned, Arcane Background (Mystic), Faith d8+

In times of crisis, the mystic's most loyal spirits can infuse his essence with their own power, allowing him to shrug off trauma that might otherwise take him out of the fight. After making a Soak roll, the mystic may spend any number of Power Points, and add +1 to the roll for each Power Point he spends.

SOCIAL EDGES

BADGE OF AUTHORITY

- **Requirements:** Novice, Illuminati member

The operative appears to be part of a law enforcement or other government agency, and has the badge and paperwork to back it up. At the start of each mission, the operative can choose what agency she wants to represent, and the Illuminati implants a suitable false identity for her into all the right databases. When speaking as a member of that agency, the operative adds +2 to Persuasion and Intimidation rolls when appropriate.

ILLUMINATI STRING PULLER

- **Requirements:** Novice, Illuminati member

The operative can "pull strings" by making a Favor roll and using his influence with the Illuminati to help him find the answers he needs, as detailed below. When pulling strings, the operative's Favor die does not decrease per the usual Favor rules (see **Factions and Favors** in *The Secret World*), but each subsequent use within 24 hours reduces the roll by 2. Each request takes 48 hours to fulfill, but this time is halved with each raise on the Favor roll. (One raise drops the time to 24 hours; two raises drop it to 12, etc.)

- **Back Channels:** The operative can pull strings to acquire information, such as licenses or criminal records, from any government database. If the information is classified, the roll is made at -2.

- **ID Check:** By supplying the Illuminati with the image of a person and pulling strings, the operative can learn the person's name, occupation, and contact information.

- **Trace:** By pulling strings, the operative can learn the location of any person, vehicle, or other large specific item (at the GM's discretion) that he can thoroughly identify.

INSIDE CONNECTION

- **Requirements:** Novice, Illuminati String Puller

The operative has an ally inside the Illuminati helping pull strings on her behalf. All string-pulling requests now take 24 hours to fulfill by default, rather than 48. In addition, the operative can roll her Favor die along with her Wild Die when making Networking or Research rolls, and take the highest roll as usual.

WEAKEST LINK

- **Requirements:** Novice, Illuminati String Puller

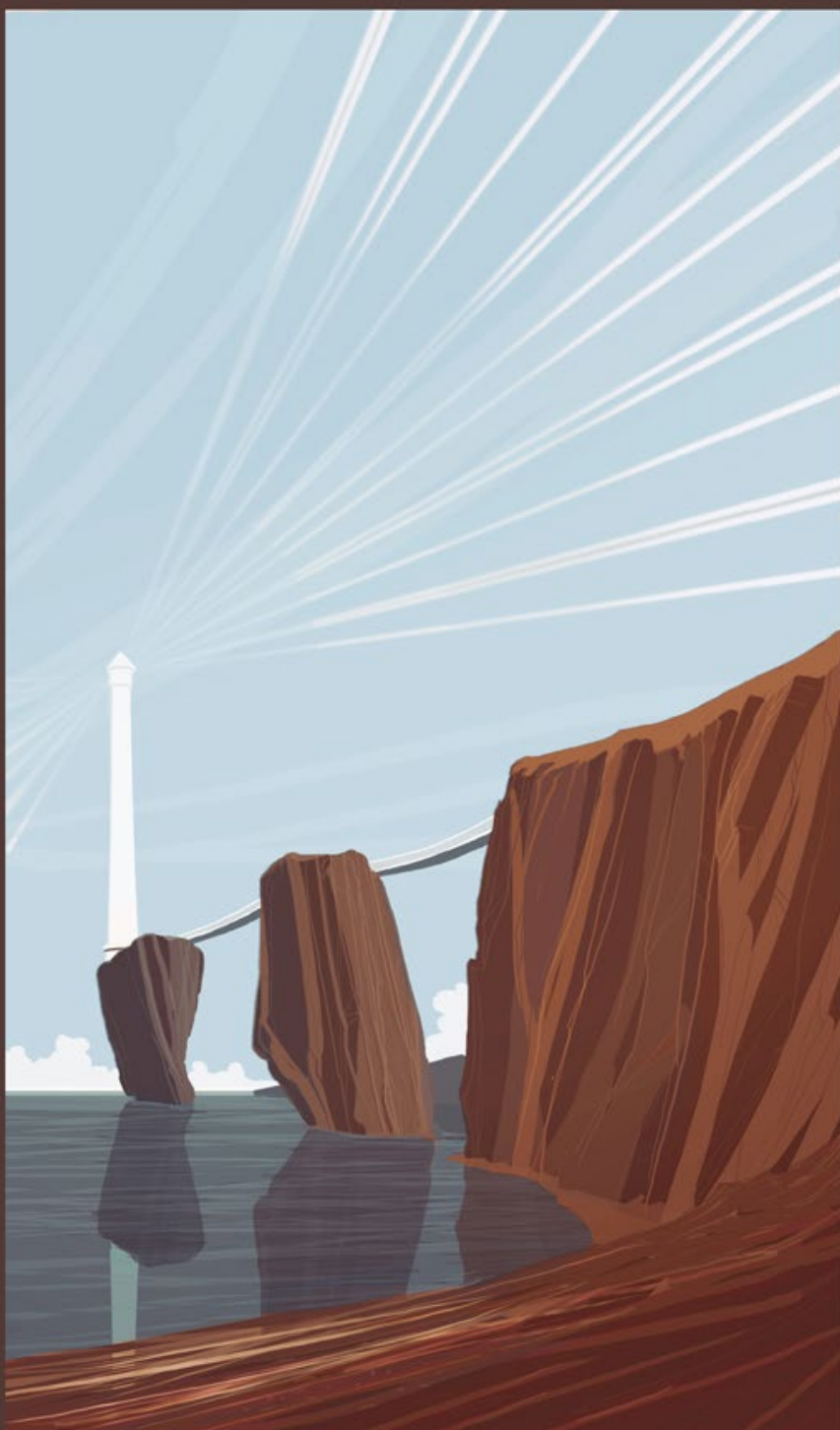
The weakest links in any system are its people. If the operative can identify a person to the Illuminati, he can pull strings to have the conspiracy force that person to cooperate with him for four hours per success and raise. The GM can modify the Favor roll based on the target (some people are harder to corrupt than others), and secretly rolls 2d6 to see how cooperative the victim is (2: traitorous, 3–5: grudging and slow, 6–8: amenable, 9–11: eager to help, 12: recruitable).



NEW GEAR

Agents and allies of the Illuminati have access to high-tech devices to help make their jobs easier. These are not standard issue. They are by request or pay *at least* the listed price to a black-market tech dealer to acquire them.

NEW GEAR		
Item	Weight	Price
EMP Transmitter	10	\$10K
<i>Notes:</i> This 12" tall, handheld cylinder can shut down all non-shielded electrical and electronic devices within 50 feet for 1d10 × 10 minutes. If the effect lasts 100 minutes, it's permanent. The device can be used once, then needs to be recharged.		
Memory Scrambler	1	\$50K
<i>Notes:</i> When this palm-sized disk is touched to a person's head, it makes them forget the previous few minutes if they fail a Spirit roll. The user can set how far back the target's memory is scrambled, up to 30 minutes. Repeated use may damage the target's brain.		
Signal Jammer	1	\$2K
<i>Notes:</i> This handheld device can block transmissions from radios, cell phones, Wi-Fi, and other wireless devices within a room for an hour, a building for 30 minutes, or a city block for 5 minutes before it needs to recharge.		
Tracker	1/10 or 1	\$1K
<i>Notes:</i> Trackers constantly transmit their locations via scrambled radio signals readable by the agents' enhanced smart phones. They come in two basic models: small (the size of a penny, with a 10-mile range and a 10-day battery) and large (brick sized, with a 100-mile range and a 30-day battery).		
Truth Serum	1/10	\$500
<i>Notes:</i> A dose of this Illuminati-crafted drug renders its victim semiconscious, and incapable of remaining silent or knowingly lying when asked a question. The effect lasts five minutes. The victim can avoid directly answering the question with a successful Spirit roll at -4.		
Video Bug	1/10	\$10K
<i>Notes:</i> No bigger than a pencil eraser, this device captures both audio and video. It can either record up to 24 hours of surveillance on its internal drive, or transmit to an external receiver within a mile. Its battery lasts up to a week.		



DISCOVER THE WONDERS OF THE
KINGSMOUTH COAST

PROPERTY OF THE FRANKLIN FOUNDATION MINING MUSEUM

CHAPTER FOUR: ADVENTURES IN NORTH AMERICA

In the Secret World, North America offers players a unique mix of geography, culture, traditions, and threats. It's a vast land, full of contradictions and contradictory people, built on both horror and hope.

The following chapter explores these ideas and offers detailed suggestions on how to run a Secret World campaign set in North America. This chapter (and indeed the rest of the book) is intended to be read only by the Game Master. If you plan to explore North America as a player, you should read no further.

The information that follows is divided into several sections:

Secret North America details the various themes that make the continent an exciting and unique setting for your campaign.

Running the Illuminati suggests how to use the Illuminati as your players' ally, enemy, or ever-present part of the North American landscape.

The Road Trip Campaign explores how to run a campaign focused on travel, exploration, and wandering the back roads of the continent.

Roadside Horrors presents a wide array of dangers, mysteries, and other trouble your players may encounter while on the road.

Adventure Seeds showcases over two dozen adventure ideas, each tied to one of the points of interest detailed previously in this book.

Let's explore the Secret World of North America.

SECRET NORTH AMERICA

North America is a land large enough to contain many contradictions. It's a place where, like the Secret World itself, everything is true. Below are a few important themes and tropes to keep in mind while running a campaign.

A VAST LAND

The continent covers a staggering amount of land, divided into prairies, deserts, forests, mountains, canyons, jungles, and other biomes. Every region has its own ecosystem of wildlife, both natural and supernatural. The sheer size and diversity of the geography means that there are countless niches in which to find strange creatures or hidden treasures.

The size of the land also means that North America contains a lot of wilderness. While there are areas of dense population, there are many more regions where one could drive the highway for hours and not see another human being. Wide prairies, sweeping deserts, and dense forests remind visitors of how insignificant humans truly are in the grand scheme of things. It's in these places that the Secret World of spirits, cryptids, and other supernatural creatures seems the closest to the mundane world.

MELTING POTS

Most North Americans are descended from immigrants from other continents, and they carry some of their ancestors' cultures with them. Over the years, these cultures have combined with each other (and with indigenous cultures) to create an amalgam of beliefs, traditions ... and monsters. It's not unreasonable to encounter an African hyena-man in the same city as a Russian kikumora house spirit.

This mixing of cultures has also created pockets of unique local customs in isolated locales. People here have their own ways of looking at things and understanding the universe, and those ways often open them up to the Secret World. Witches and psychics and even Bees are more likely to pop up in these remote spots.

OLDER THAN IT LOOKS

Because the dominant North American cultures have only been present for the past few centuries, it's easy to forget that people have actually lived here for many thousands of years. While those ancient people may be gone, their legacy lives on in the architecture, stories, and imagery that persist. These remnants, along with archaeology, connect today's Secret World to that of millennia past—and maybe even the Third Age.

INDEPENDENT

While the United States has adopted the concept of “independence” as a core part of its identity, modern Canada and Mexico were born of the same independent streak. Originally, the nations' cry for independence meant freedom from European rule. But since then, the idea has evolved into that of *personal* independence. North Americans consider themselves free thinkers who make their own decisions based on evidence and reason. They aren't bound by stodgy, outdated tradition, or fickle royal mandates. They may acknowledge the benefits of laws and government, but they generally don't like being told what to do.

While this fiercely independent streak might seem to make the populous less controllable, the Illuminati hasn't found this to be the case. The challenge is in the messaging: if a conspiracy can make the people believe that carrying out its orders is their *own* idea, they will fight for their right to serve their masters. Furthermore, these independent free thinkers generally fall into line same as anyone when offered the right threats and rewards. What is more independent than selling out one's beliefs in order to get rich?

Perhaps ironically, the Illuminati likewise pride themselves on their independence, and likewise eagerly trade it away in exchange for wealth or power.

RUNNING THE ILLUMINATI

No one disputes that, of the Big Three factions, the Illuminati dominates North America. But what it means to “dominate” varies by region, by faction, and by how much one is willing to take the Illuminati at its word.

ABSOLUTE POWER

The Illuminati's complete control of North America is an illusion. The secret society's resources are vast, but they are finite. The faction needs to focus on major, important issues affecting the world on a national or global scale. While it could easily squash an upstart cult or an investigative website, such small matters are beneath its notice. Its constant flood of misinformation and demands for conformity typically crush such troublemakers before they can cause any real problems. The system runs itself with little direct Illuminati control.

Nevertheless, the Illuminati does try to keep an eye on the Dragon and the Templars in North America. If either faction starts wielding too much influence, the Illuminati shuts them down by cutting off their resources, undermining their work, and (if necessary) eliminating their agents. So long as they keep to themselves, the Illuminati doesn't do more than monitor them. As Kirsten Geary says, “We let them splash around in the kiddie pool, chasing monsters or butterflies or whatever. We have real work to do.”

UNITY BENEATH THE EYE

Members of the Illuminati share a singular vision: power over *everything*. Beyond this common goal, however, any display of faction-wide unity is temporary at best, and often an outright lie.

Illuminati agents and leaders who get results are rewarded more than those who simply fall into line or mindlessly go along with faction protocols. Furthermore, those who fail to produce—even if they're otherwise loyal, dependable members—are left to languish, demoted, or even removed from the organization. Competition can be fierce. If one agent's success can only come at another's

expense, that's a price most agents are willing to pay.

As a result, each regional Illuminati office is run a little bit differently from the others. So long as they're successful, the executives of these offices are free to run things as they see fit. The moment they start to slip, however, there are dozens of junior executives eager to take their places.

ILLUMINATI ALLIES

The heroes' cabal may include Illuminati members, but it likely has agents from other factions as well. Even if the cabal has no Illuminati, the faction is still willing to assist one of Zuberi's Bee-centric task forces, so long as the heroes' agenda essentially aligns with its own. The society sees the cabal's Gaia-focused missions as some of those "small matters" beneath their notice. Its leaders appreciate someone else looking into these minor problems so the Illuminati doesn't have to.

That said, the faction isn't keen on supporting Dragon or Templar agents for free. Its members often demand some sort of payment for their assistance. Money and valuables are rarely sufficient, but they gladly accept secrets and favors. Some favors are called in immediately; the cabal could end up on a series of side quests to earn what it needs from an Illuminati agent. Other favors are to be named later. Illuminati agents love it when powerful people owe them favors.

ILLUMINATI ENEMIES

If the heroes are to act directly against the Illuminati, they would be well advised to remain inconspicuous as long as possible. So long as they are considered a small matter not worth noticing, they will be ignored. But once the Illuminati feels they are of interest, the game changes.

Once the cabal is on the Illuminati's radar, it's nearly impossible to drop off it again. The faction's vast resources are now being used to track, research, and monitor the potential threat. Illuminati agents can tap any surveillance camera, cell phone, computer, database, or other information system they wish. Given enough time, they can know the heroes better than they

know themselves, and can predict not only their next moves, but what countermoves will be most effective against them.

When the Illuminati is stalking the cabal, it's only a matter of time before it moves in to deal with them as it sees fit. To avoid this, the cabal has two main options.

The first is to draw on allies of their own. The Dragon and Templar have been fighting the Illuminati for millennia. For that matter, so have the Phoenicians and the Council of Venice. With these factions' help, the heroes can defend themselves against the Illuminati or even disappear once more into obscurity.

The second option is to make sure they have something the Illuminati wants. The faction is always looking for an edge, and will gladly let an enemy escape—or turn that enemy into an ally—if that enemy is more valuable alive.

THE ROAD TRIP CAMPAIGN

One of North America's cultural touchstones is the idea of a road trip. The wide-open spaces of the continent are crisscrossed with high-speed freeways, regional highways, and dusty back roads. These iconic paths pass through wide-open spaces, connecting major cities and winding through smaller towns. Those who drive these roads are answering a classic call to adventure; Secret Worlders on the road may find more danger and horror than they would if they stayed in one place.

In the road trip campaign, the heroes travel from one point of interest to another, facing the forces of darkness at every stop along the way. Such a campaign might be very episodic: every stop is its own adventure, unconnected to any others. It might be serialized, with each stop building on the one before. It could be a full campaign, taking months of real time to resolve, or it could be just a couple of sessions detailing the heroes' journey from one major city to another.

Some road trip campaign ideas include the following:

- **Clue Quest:** To solve a major mystery, the heroes must uncover a sequence of clues spread across hundreds of miles. Each clue reveals a little bit more of the mystery, and suggests where the next clue may be found.
- **Hit List:** An enemy group has infested numerous locations with its cells and agents. Each is working independently to carry out the enemy's fiendish agenda, while conspiring to pull off a much larger plan. The heroes must root out these dangerous miscreants wherever they can be found.
- **Hot Pursuit:** In this campaign, the heroes are either chasing an enemy from one stop to the next, or being chased. This could be combined with another campaign. For example, the cabal might be hunting for a series of Third Age talismans while being hunted by the descendants of the angelic half-breeds who first created them.
- **Task Force:** While the cabal drives the car, Zuberi or another quest giver is the one telling them where to go and what to do when they get there. Every stop is a surprise, every mission is different, and every assignment starts with the words, "Since you're already in the area ..."
- **Treasure Hunt:** The heroes are collecting important items that have been scattered throughout the region. The items may be stolen relics, magical art objects, evidence of the Secret World, or even Secret Worlders themselves.
- **Vacation Time:** The heroes aren't looking for Secret World adventures. They just want to do some leisurely driving and exploring. Nevertheless, they stumble onto a dangerous mystery to solve at every stop. No matter what they do, they can't avoid it. It's almost like it's some sort of conspiracy.

TRAVEL

A key ingredient in a road trip campaign is traveling from one point of interest to another. Here are some tips for making it fun and interesting.

YOUR CHARIOT AWAITS

Every road trip needs a communal vehicle. A classic sports car is always great, but it may not have the capacity the heroes need. An RV has plenty of room, and makes a great portable headquarters, but it isn't fast or maneuverable. A tour bus is extravagant, but it might perfectly suit the heroes' needs. Any vehicle may turn out to be haunted, cursed, or secretly carrying something that dangerous people will kill to acquire.

PLOTTING A COURSE

The first step of taking a road trip is figuring out a destination. Even if the heroes are just wandering aimlessly, they should arbitrarily choose where they'd like to end up.

The second step is finding a route. Just like in the real world, Secret Worlders have maps, cell phones, and GPS. To find a route, you (or better yet, your players) should use these modern conveniences to map out where they're going and how long it should take to get there. Even if their destination doesn't technically exist in the real world (like Springton, Ohio, for instance), you can pick out a similar location (say, Bowling Green, Ohio) and have them use it for making travel plans.

SETTING THE SCENE

Once the heroes pile into their vehicle and set out for their destination, it's up to you to describe the journey itself. Pick out a few details of the landscape to point out along the way that help set the mood you're going for. ("The ancient mountains loom over you, casting long, purple shadows across the road." or "Fields of wildflowers run alongside the road. Every few miles, you can make out the rusted ruins of a car overgrown with flowers.")

ROAD ENCOUNTERS

Modern highway travel is relatively safe. It's entirely possible the cabal simply gets to its destination without incident. But if you want to spice things up, you may wish to choose (or have the dice choose) one of the following events:

Changing Weather: Rain, snow, high winds, or other weather makes travel slow and possibly dangerous. It might be a minor inconvenience that sets the tone, or it might be a prelude to a supernatural attack.

Little Bee Lost: Despite maps, cell phones, and GPS, the heroes somehow end up lost. They can eventually find their way back to the path, but it costs them time, and might involve a side adventure.

Mechanical Issues: The cabal’s vehicle gets a flat tire, runs out of gas, or develops some sort of engine trouble. The heroes need to make an unscheduled stop for repairs—and adventure!

Obstacles and Hazards: The bridge is out. Construction blocks the highway. A serious car accident has closed the road. Problems can cost time—or wreck the heroes’ vehicle if they don’t see the danger soon enough.

Roadside Horrors: There’s something weird alongside the road up ahead. It looks mysterious and dangerous. The heroes should really stop and check it out. (See **Roadside Horrors** below.)

NEXT STOP: ADVENTURE

During a road trip, the real adventure begins when the cabal reaches its destination.

While the tables below don’t necessarily dictate what sort of adventure awaits the heroes at each stop, they can help you, the GM, determine the place’s mood, conflicts, and secrets. These things can add flavor and context to the adventure, whatever it may be.

If the stop is a real location, research it a little bit and mine its real-life lore for Secret World inspiration. What’s it famous for? What’s its main industry? Any scandals? How old is it? Look for what makes the town unique, and how it might tie into the various factions and conspiracies of the Secret World. Then use the tables below to make the place stranger and darker than its real-life counterpart. (Remember, the Secret World is not the real world; be inspired by reality, but not constrained by it.)

If the stop is completely fictional, you may either research a similar place to use as a template, or start from scratch and go straight to the tables. It’s up to you.

HIDDEN POWERS

The first step is to determine what conspiracies are really in charge here. Roll once on the Hidden Power Table to find out what group calls the shots, then roll on the Hidden Goal Table to determine

their objective. To make things interesting, roll once more on each table to create two rival powers with their own agendas. These agendas should oppose each other, creating conflict.

HIDDEN POWER TABLE	
D100	HIDDEN POWER
1--3	Anansi Technologies
4--6	Dragon
7--11	Faust Capital
12--15	Illuminati
16--24	Local Corporation
25--36	Local Cult
37--48	Local Family
49--60	Local Monsters
61--65	Manticore Research Group
66--69	Organized Crime
70--72	Phoenicians
73--76	Plethron
77--80	QBL Media
81--84	Sycoil
85--88	Templars
89--92	The Morninglight
93--96	ValiVáli
97--100	Zagan

HIDDEN GOAL TABLE	
D6	HIDDEN GOAL
1	Acquisition: The power wants to own something specific: land, business, certain people, or local resources, or artifacts.
2	Control: The power craves control over a local resource, group, or location. To what end? What does it intend to use it for?
3	Destruction: The power needs to destroy something: a location, an organization, a family, a landmark. Why?
4	Development: The power dreams of growth. Bigger, stronger, faster, smarter. Is it physical growth, economic, or political growth?
5	Investigation: The power must know more about a local mystery, no matter the cost.
6	Profit: The power ignores laws, ethics, safety—everything but short-term profits.

ATMOSPHERE

Every spot has its own unique feeling. To generate this location's particular tone, roll on the **Atmosphere Table**. To make the place truly unique, roll twice and combine both descriptors.

ATMOSPHERE TABLE	
D20	ATMOSPHERE
1	Bustling
2	Cultured
3	Dangerous
4	Desolate
5	Dreary
6	Dying
7	Fanatical
8	Filthy
9	Frightened
10	Historical
11	Intelligent
12	Mysterious
13	Quiet
14	Sickly
15	Slow Moving
16	Spotless
17	Touristy
18	Uptight
19	Welcoming
20	Xenophobic

DEEP SECRETS

Every place has its secrets. These may be past incidents that few remember, current events that no one talks about, or a looming threat that everyone ignores. The most interesting secrets are the ones that quietly shape the place and its people in ways that outsiders might not notice right away. Generate as many secrets as you'd like by rolling any number of times on the **Secret Table**.

SECRET TABLE	
D20	SECRET
1	Addiction: A secret scourge permeates the town, quietly addicting people and destroying their lives.
2	Besieged: Monsters lurk outside the town, kept at bay by unspoken wards and rituals.
3	Corruption: Politicians, courts, and police are drunk on power and bribes. Say nothing or end up in jail.
4	Crime: Organized criminals are more influential, or crime is more prevalent, than meets the eye.
5	Cuisine: Locals eat what outsiders may consider vile or disturbing.
6	Cursed: A curse lies over the town for a wrong it did long ago. To speak of it makes it worse.
7	Dark Rituals: On a repeating cycle, the locals do what must be done, then speak of it no more.



8	Family: Most people here are all related, and more closely than it appears.
9	Forbidden: Some otherwise ubiquitous thing is not allowed here: pets, birds, children, bicycles, etc.
10	Infestation: Unnatural insects, rodents, or other pests roam freely. Locals dare not interfere.
11	Infiltrated: There are monsters here, living among mundane folks who pretend otherwise.
12	Murder: A high-profile murder rocked the town. The killer escaped.
13	Natural Disaster: The place was devastated by a past disaster. Someone may be to blame.
14	Power Unchanging: The same people have ruled this place for over a century. No one seems to notice.
15	Rebuilt: This place is built on the ashes of a previous place. There's evidence, but it's never spoken of.
16	Sanctum: A building or landmark is a place of supernatural power and danger. Locals avoid and ignore it.
17	Toxic: To live here is to welcome sickness: cancer, asthma, blindness, or worse.
18	Tragedy: A past tragedy killed many and changed how things are done. The cause may be unknown.
19	Traitors: The locals were on the wrong side an important conflict. Their grudge is a bitter burden.
20	Vanishing: A group of people simply vanished. No one will say why or how, though some might know.

ROADSIDE HORRORS

The highways and back roads of North America are veins of horror, pumping nightmare fuel from one end of the continent to the other. As the heroes travel along these bloody trails, there is no telling what monstrous discoveries await.

What follows is a number of brief encounter ideas that the cabal might run into while on the road, divided into four categories (creatures, events, objects, and locations). To generate an encounter on the fly, roll 1d4 to determine the category, then 1d10 to discover the encounter within that category.

1. CREATURES	
D10	CREATURE ENCOUNTER
1	As the heroes stop for gas, a swarm of Filthy creatures emerges from the shadows and attacks. It's an ambush, but how did their attackers know where to find them?
2	A vehicle is stopped up ahead. Its engine is running and its doors are all open. A massive figure runs into the trees, carrying a person under each arm.
3	A row of scarecrows stands alongside the road. They turn their heads to watch the cabal's vehicle drive by.
4	The secret door has a red eye on it. Opening it reveals a glowering, red-eyed beast. It pulls back, but hisses and flashes its fangs.
5	An armored SUV pulls alongside the heroes' vehicle and tries to run it off the road. Two more trucks are speeding up from behind. Are these the cabal's enemies catching up to them? Or are they enemies they haven't met yet?
6	Gunmen burst into where the cabal is refueling. They are shouting, sweating, and aggressive. They have matching occult tattoos, which are all starting to bleed. They want money, yes, but also something called the "sphinx."
7	A pair of young twin girls in matching coats accompany a shaggy white goat. They speak to the goat, and it apparently speaks to them, giving them wisdom and instructions, even if they can't quite pronounce the words it wants them to say.
8	A frozen dead man walks. He wears a jogging outfit. His eyes are unfocused and unseeing; his skin is cold. The locals honor him with handmade necklaces adorned with stones and shells, and won't say where he's going.
9	An old woman starts to vomit up a truly alarming amount of protoplasm. Those standing near her look annoyed as the substance slides around on the floor and starts to take on a more defined shape. "Here we go again," they say. The old woman tries and fails to catch her breath.
10	What appears to be a panhandler approaches the heroes, but bursts into flame before he can say anything. The flame smells of incense, not burned flesh. He howls, but not in pain. Others nearby likewise catch fire.

2. EVENTS

D10	EVENT ENCOUNTER
1	One of the heroes hears a psychic shout for help from an old, officially shuttered mental asylum. There are still patients here, and they are being experimented on.
2	Lighting strikes a spot up ahead, then strikes it again and again. Perhaps it's a magic spell that's killed its caster. Perhaps it's something a bit more scientific. In any case, the lighting is growing stronger with every passing minute.
3	The cabal's vehicle hits a strange creature that darted out onto the road ahead of them. It seems to have come from that tree-covered island, where the sounds of power tools can be heard.
4	The third time the heroes pass the same landmark, they realized they're caught in a loop. Everything is fine until they try to leave the area. Then time resets and they reenter the area from the point where they originally entered.
5	A car is broken down on the side of the road, and its occupants flag down the cabal for help. There are photos of the heroes on the floor of the car, and muffled grunts from the trunk. A second look reveals that there are more people here than could comfortably fit in the car.
6	An unmarked black van suddenly turns off the road and vanishes. There is no exit. There is no van. There is a clearing that looks big enough to hold a large industrial facility that doesn't appear on any maps, but there's no sign of such a thing.
7	The road is blocked off ahead by police. A dozen squad cars, a SWAT truck, and almost 50 cops with guns out surround a small, beat-up old car. The car's stereo is loud enough to hear from a quarter mile away.
8	With a mighty groan, something big throws a boulder onto the road. Other boulders follow, though the tosser remains hidden.
9	The locals show off the fish they just caught in a local fishing hole. The creatures are swollen and discolored, mutated, with spines and mouths and eyes where they should not be.
10	A siren begins to wail from somewhere. The ground swells and buckles. Tentacles burst up from the earth.

3. LOCATIONS

D10	LOCATION ENCOUNTER
1	A sprawling antique shop is having a massive sale. Hand-painted signs declare "90% off" and "Everything must go!" Its goods are scattered near the road. The heroes recognize them as items from their childhoods.
2	A small shop features a folk art gallery of unsettling paintings and sculptures from a commune of local artists. Three of them in the back are covered in black cloth. One of them looks to be a person.
3	An industrial warehouse bears a giant radio antenna on its roof. It might be why the local radio blares static on certain frequencies, along with regular beeps and drones, shouts in foreign tongues, and occasionally, the heroes' words back at them like an electronic echo.
4	A small, traditional-looking church is being defended by a surly man with a shotgun. He says he's protecting the place against the "giant birds" that "drip black tar."
5	Outside a ramshackle convenience store combined with a gas station, a set of wind chimes marked with runes tinkles off-key. The distinct and odd-sounding chimes repel the ghouls that are attracted to the bodies in the store's basement.
6	The smoke-filled dive bar caters to a mixed crowd of bikers, lawyers, and real estate moguls. They're all here for the local specialty drink, and the mysterious bartender who makes it.
7	By all appearances, the old diner is abandoned. But even though the windows are broken out and it's largely overgrown, the parking lot is full, and the smell of cooked meat wafts from the collapsing kitchen.
8	Despite being at least 50 years past its prime, the motel gleams as if new. Its neon sign glows high and bright, visible from the road and declaring its amenities and reasonable rates. There are no signs of people outside, but numerous old cars are rusting out back.
9	The local jail has a police car out front and a crude sign hanging out a second-story window reading "HELP US." Smoke seeps from the building. Graffiti on the outside is large enough to be seen from the road.

10	A vast field of deep-purple grain runs along either side of the road. Glowing eyes glare from between the 10-foot-tall rippling rows. The tainted crop warps the wild animals that nibble on it, making them aggressive and cunning, and giving them extra organs and a limited hive mind. People have disappeared in the field. They only wish they were dead.
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4. OBJECTS

D10	OBJECT ENCOUNTER
1	A 50-foot-tall wicker man looms above the trees. Something writhes inside its wicker-cage skin. It might be a mass of humans. It might be something else. Shouts and roars echo from nearby.
2	A silvery, metallic orb the size of a school bus drifts over the road. It smells of lavender. It belches fog from its sides. When the fog is too thick to see through, the orb vanishes, along with any creatures also in the fog.
3	An enormous tree grows nearby, its limbs just barely reaching over the top of the road. A path leading to it is lined with suspiciously grave-like mounds of earth on either side. Chittering and hissing can be heard from up in the canopy.
4	A dull white arch stretches over the road. It's made of bones: some human, some not. Jagged bones protrude like fangs. The locals say it's art but can't say who created it or when. Those who suspend themselves from the bone fangs overnight see visions and understand true mysteries.
5	A road sign is covered in flowers and photos. It's a makeshift shrine for a beloved young woman who died here in a terrible hit-and-run car accident just a year ago. Hundreds of people are here to commemorate her death. It's too many people, too close to the road. Some of them notice that the vehicle that killed her looked a lot like the heroes' vehicle. Looked exactly like it, in fact.
6	Seven 15-foot-tall stone obelisks are streaked with mud, suggesting they have recently emerged from the ground. One of them turns to face the heroes. Tracks reveal that lots of people were here. The standing stones project a growing magnetic field.

7	An underpass is covered with graffiti of unsettling symbols. Those who pass through it smell an eye-watering stench of ammonia, and lose one of their memories. In its place is a snippet of a pop song they've never heard before.
8	Over a dozen vehicles protrude from a mudhole, perpendicular to the ground. The mud is temperamentally gooey; merely slick in some spots, grossly adhesive in others. Bones litter the stickier spots.
9	Once a retail store, now an elaborate, dome-roofed temple, the so-called "Church of Eternal Love" is as gaudy as any Las Vegas casino. Its neon sign flashes between the words "Worship" and "Enter." Inside are believers, acolytes, and a succubus.
10	Bodies in nooses hang from a billboard displaying a bodybuilder and advertising a local gym with "results guaranteed." One of the bodies is twitching vigorously.



DARK DESIGNS

These encounter ideas are intentionally broad, so you can work them into your road trip campaign no matter which roads your players are exploring. If you'd like a suggestion as to who or what is behind a particular roadside horror, note that you can roll on the **Hidden Powers Table** in the **Next Stop: Adventure** section.

REWARDS

Your players may need an incentive to interact with the strangeness on the road. If they do, you may wish to roll on the **Roadside Reward Table** for an idea of what to give them.

ROADSIDE REWARD TABLE	
D6	REWARD
1	Allies.: Helping people is a good way to make friends, and the heroes need all the friends they can get.
2	Artifacts.: Magical items, such as talismans, are always useful. Even if the heroes can't figure it out what an item is or utilize it themselves, they can earn improve their standing by turning it over to someone who can.
3	Faction Favor.: If investigating these incidental horrors advances their factions' agendas, the heroes may earn those factions' the favor of those factions, which can be more valuable than gold.
4	Righteousness.: Sometimes fighting the darkness is its own reward. They are heroes, after all.
5	Secrets.: Information is power. It may be also be a clue to help the heroes solve some other mystery, or a hint at how to overcome a challenge yet to come.
6	Treasure.: While the cabal doesn't have much need for money, it can come in handy. Even handier are weapons, gear, and other mundane items that might come in handybe useful during the rest of the adventure.



ADVENTURE SEEDS

Below are over two dozen adventure seeds tied to Secret World hot spots in North America. While these aren't full-fledged adventures, they provide enough details to help you bring these places to life with danger and horror for your players.

ATLANTA

HARVEST TIME

"Nightblood" is the nickname of an exotic flower with miraculous medicinal properties that only blooms for a few days per year, and only in Alexander Park.

The heroes are sent to retrieve the blossoms of a blooming nightblood. Unbeknownst to them, a local gang, Rolling Nines, is also on the hunt for the flower's deep-purple blossoms.

The head of the gang is a former CDC chemist. He realized that there was much more money to be made in the private sector—and even more money in the criminal sector. Now a high-rolling drug lord calling himself Doctor Nine, the chemist has sent in a dozen of his most trusted thugs to collect the weird opiate and kill anyone who gets in their way.

A rival gang, the Boxer Boyz, has just rolled into Alexander Park as well. They know that Doctor Nine's chemistry is the key to his gang's success and suspect it has something to do with Alexander Park, so they've decided to follow their rivals there. They're not leaving until they get some answers.

ON ICE

No one should show any interest in the CDC's Prometheus warehouse. While it is a secure facility for keeping monstrous creatures in stasis for scientific experimentation, the facts of the warehouse are top secret. As far as anyone outside the Secret World knows, it's just a boring bureaucratic warehouse full of old paperwork.

And yet there is a small but growing online community that's increasingly obsessed with the place. Urban explorers—who see breaking

into forbidden sites as a fun challenge—are particularly curious and have started discussing methods of sneaking inside. When the third person is caught snooping around the place, the heroes are called in to investigate.

The anonymous ringleader of these discussions is a terminally online victim of the Black Signal. Under that Filth creature's influence, he is building up a small army to raid the warehouse and release everything they find there. The chaos will be extraordinary! More importantly, the draug they will release could then resume their task of infecting the world with more Filth.

THE WESTSIDE SLASHER

A mysterious creature has been attacking, killing, and partially eating people late at night on the streets of West Midtown.

The so-called "Westside Slasher" is a shapeshifting abomination spawned in the depths of the CDC's Project Prometheus. The mutant crossbreed killed the mad scientist who created it, smashed out a window, and fled into the night. It established a lair in an abandoned West Midtown attic and has been living and hunting here ever since.

Finding the creature is harder than it should be. It appears quite normal while stalking its prey. It even acts human. But those who pay attention can discern that it only *mimics* human speech and behavior; it doesn't know what it's doing or why. Despite speaking fluent English, the creature barely understands the language.

When it attacks, it assumes one of several monstrous forms, each twice the size of a normal person. Some have tentacles, others horns and claws. Once it's fed, it reverts to its human size and shape and becomes hard to find once more.

If the heroes track the creature to its lair, they find evidence there that it came from the CDC, including an ID badge of the scientist who created it.

The Illuminati's top priority for the slasher is to keep the creature and its attacks quiet. Some members want the heroes to stop the slasher before the Templars do, thus ensuring their faction's supremacy. The Templars are also torn. While David Ennis has been asked to destroy the killer, some of his allies would prefer the beast be captured for study—and they have dispatched a hunter of their own to do just that.

There are plenty of sides for the players' cabal to take in this conflict. But if they stop to play politics, the slasher may strike again.

MEXICO CITY

HEXED

Imelda Barron is a 23-year-old party girl who likes to dance a little too close to the edge. In the past month, she has transformed into a shriveled, dried-out husk who grows weaker by the day. She can't remember how she became this way, but she knows she was at Velos Negros before it happened. "It's foggy, like a dream," she says. "But I know there was an old woman. I think she gave me a tattoo."

Imelda's tattoo is an indecipherable symbol resembling a character in ancient Zapotec script. It's on her shoulder, and fresh enough that it still sometimes bleeds.

The "old woman" is a practitioner of local magics known only as Ariana. She isn't old right now. She looks about 23, and her body is covered in tattoos similar to the one on Imelda's shoulder. No one knows Ariana's true age. When she starts to feel old, she tricks or forces a younger woman to get a matching tattoo with her, then quickly drains her victim's vitality through the mystic connection.

Regulars at Velos Negros can point the heroes toward Ariana, but they are terrified of her. Her magic is powerful, and her nature is vindictive. If the heroes remove the tattoo matching Imelda's from Ariana's skin, the curse is broken.

IDOL HANDS

Ciro Diaz wasn't a very good thief. When he stole an artifact from an archaeological site on the edge of Mexico City, he just grabbed the first shiny thing he saw. And it killed him.

The artifact is a skull-sized idol that may represent Xipe Totec, the god of agricultural renewal and death. Once removed from its temple, the idol was intended to be ceremonially buried in a field after harvest, where it would promote healthy decomposition, decay, and the feeding of the soil. Sitting on Ciro's shelf, however, the idol rotted the thief's body from the inside out. When the authorities arrived at the

thief's house, they could barely identify him, but they could see that he himself had been robbed.

Ciro Diaz wasn't a very good gambler, either. He owed a lot of money to the local syndicate, who took everything of value to pay off his debts. The syndicate boss likes the look of the idol. He has it prominently displayed where dozens of underlings can see it daily.

The heroes aren't the only ones looking for the idol. Ciro had arranged to sell it to a wealthy collector, who has dispatched her own team of thugs to retrieve it by any means necessary.

TRAPPED IN LUXURY

Teodulo Melendez, an independent reporter with a massive social media following, was investigating a crime cartel figure when he followed the criminal into the El Internacional hotel. It's been a week, and he hasn't emerged. His followers are starting to get too curious. If their curiosity brings them to the hotel, it could lead to a situation that could be expensive and messy to cover up. It would be better for the heroes to go in and retrieve Melendez.

While the Illuminati uses the hotel, it doesn't truly control it. The hive-minded demon that runs the place has complete freedom to do as it wishes with those guests not under the Illuminati's protection. Melendez snuck in. He's not under anyone's protection. He's running and hiding inside the hotel, unable to escape, and slowly losing his mind due to the time loop. The demon is playing with him, and intends to eventually kill him.

The Illuminati can get the heroes into the hotel but can't guarantee their safety once inside. Since they aren't official captives, the demonic staff may see them as intruders, and try to destroy them.

MONTREAL

THE HUNGRY DEAD

A pair of aggressive zombies staggers down Mount Royal, endangering both the people of Montreal and their false sense of security.

After dealing with the zombies, the heroes track the creatures back to a private lot outside the walls of the various mountain cemeteries.

Here they find more, equally aggressive undead, and a second wave of zombies actively digging their way out of their shallow graves.

Amid the torn-up ground lies the body of the man who was overseeing the zombie resurrection. It's possible to connect him to his cult, the Void Wisdom Circle, and the secret temple where they performed their necromantic rites. It's here that the heroes may discover that the cult murdered those whom they brought back as zombies, and that part of preparing the bodies for resurrection involved infusing them with Filth.

The Void Wisdom Circle had a Filthy human locked up, and were harvesting its essence for their experiments. If the heroes are fast enough, they can eliminate the Filth at its source. If not, the cult takes its captive with them as it scurries into the shadows.

SPECIAL DELIVERY

The heroes are recruited to bring an artifact to the Redpath Museum in order to sell it.

The artifact is a crystal cube, roughly the size of a softball, called the "Heart of Haron." En route to the museum, the Heart starts to telepathically communicate with the nearest hero. It explains that it is actually sentient, and contains the souls of at least 12 generations of shamans. The Heart does not want to go into the darkness of the museum, where it will be forced to offer up its wisdom to the unworthy. It longs to be free, and to share its mystical insights with those it judges to be worthy—such as the heroes.

The Heart is a lie. It's actually one half of a matched pair of such cubes; anyone holding one cube can telepathically communicate with the holder of the other. Right now, the other cube is in the hands of a Dragon agent who is having a great laugh at the heroes' expense.

THE HUNTER

A shadowy figure has taken an unhealthy interest in the students at Blackburn Academy. It has chased them through the streets at night, causing at least one to fall and hurt himself. When it displays superhuman physical abilities, the heroes are called in to investigate before any students are seriously harmed.

The stalker is Serge Larocque, a Templar who was killed in action a few months ago and brought back by Alexander Richler at the Notre-Dame

Basilica. Larocque came back *wrong*. He seemed fine at first, but his mind seethes with rage and vengeance. He now ignores his colleagues. He hunts not just monsters, but any who display abilities beyond what nature provides. Before his death at the hands of a Void Wisdom cultist, the Templar learned about the psychic teenagers at Blackburn Academy. Since then, he's been obsessed with rooting out the gifted kids. "Got to keep the city *pure*," he growls to himself.

MOUNT SHASTA

BLACK BEAR DOWN

The Cardenas family, who run the Black Bear Diner, don't have time to oversee their business like they once did. They are spending most of their time at home with Ernest Cardenas, the elderly patriarch of the family, who has apparently taken quite ill.

The local sheriff brought "Grandpa Ernie" home one night a few weeks ago, incoherent and wandering through the woods with bloody hands and wounds he couldn't explain. Since then, he's been mostly bedridden and spends much of his time asleep. When he wakes, his eyes burn with a feverish intensity, and a malicious grin warps his face. "Good family," he mutters to himself. "So caring. So tasty."

The old man's teenage grandchildren want to take him to the doctor, but their mother, his daughter Natalia, forbids it. "Papa's just having an episode. He'll be better soon," she says. Natalia's husband, Timothy, says nothing. He's been missing for three days. No one in his home seems to notice.

Ernest Cardenas is dead. The thing gleefully wearing his skin is a skinwalker that's been infected with Filth. A being of pure evil, the creature is amusing itself by impersonating the old man and using his family to serve it by day so it can hunt at night. It uses its telepathic powers to keep the family under control. It devoured Timothy days ago, then erased him from his family's memory. It plans to do the same to the rest of the family, starting with the teenage daughter, Elana. She seems to be starting to suspect something's wrong.

NATURE TRAIL TO HELL

A dozen members of the Lemurian Enlightenment Society, a mystical New Age group, ignored numerous signs and verbal warnings and went to McCloud Falls in hopes of using their crystals to contact the Telosians at sundown. Instead, they were attacked.

Three of them were torn apart instantly, and the rest scattered into the nearby forest. Now four of the tourists have returned to civilization, begging for help to find their friends.

The creature that the tourists ran into was a Filthy Lemurian. It's still lurking around the falls. It is now controlling three of the missing tourists like a puppet master, and will use them to either attack its enemies or lure new victims.

If the heroes save the tourists, they earn a boon from the Shasta Sanctuary and Suites, where they had been staying. (And the Illuminati are pleased with them as well.)

UNDER SIEGE

Shasta Serenity Springs is under siege. Filth-mutated animals have been trying to enter the place for weeks, but it's been warded for decades, and thus far the wards are still holding.

Harold and Pamela Cash are holed up in the rejuvenation center, afraid of what may attack them if they leave. For they know that something worse than a Filthy wolf or elk is lurking in the forest just beyond the lodge. They've seen glimpses of the creature prowling the very fence line that leads to the driveway and the lodge itself.

What they don't know is that the beast is a skinwalker that's been infected by Filth. Hungry, devious, and smelling conquest, the skinwalker manipulates and mutilates anything it can for strength and to appease its hunger. However, this one wants the Cash family; its hunger seems to be personal.

Harold and Pamela's son, 20-year-old Tommy, is missing. He has suffered from addiction and mental illness since his teenage years. Three months ago, he vanished into the woods after a particularly intense weekend of drug use. His clothing was found torn and bloody at the edge of the property. Since then, howls, whispered threats, and thoughts that appear out of nowhere have plagued Harold and Pamela.

The Cashes are terrified and desperate. They need someone to help them escape, and to destroy the beast that's stalking them. They fear that the creature is somehow their own son, transformed into something grotesque and evil. But Tommy is dead, and the thing that sometimes wears his skin does so merely to torment them further.

NEW ORLEANS

THE ESCAPE

Ray Hutchinson used to think he could handle living in the Bower Estates. He could follow the rules of the HOA, and turn a blind eye to the cult's violence and cruelty, in exchange for the power and privilege that came with it. But after two years in the cult of Dagon, he wants out.

Hutchinson has exchanged messages with the office of the Louisiana Attorney General. He intends to turn over evidence of the cult's crimes in hopes of avoiding prosecution himself. Unfortunately for him, the cult is aware of his betrayal.

The cult's leader has dispatched a Filthy mud golem to track and kill Hutchinson. Furthermore, he's also framed the traitor for terrible crimes, and has put the New Orleans Police Department on his tail. Just when Hutchinson thinks he's safe,

he may find himself surrounded by a SWAT team that's not terribly interested in bringing him in alive.

The heroes need to help Hutchinson escape with his evidence. It won't be easy—the cult has a lot of powerful allies in the area—but it might be the simplest way to take down a powerful Dreamer cult.

LESTAT'S REVENGE

The authorities are no longer surprised when a tourist disappears from the French Quarter and their friends report last seeing them at the Morts Vivantes bar.

According to rumor, real vampires lurk around the place. Those who catch their eye are seduced away, never to be seen again.

In reality, no self-respecting New Orleans vampire would come near Morts Vivantes. Rather, the sophisticated, pale-skinned man who stalks lone tourists in the saloon is purely human. Laurent Bellemare is a devious serial killer, and no stranger to the Secret World. He has a pack of ghouls as his accomplices, who dispose of the bodies of his victims.

NEW BLOOD

A new species of vampire is stalking the back alleys of New Orleans, and the heroes are called in to help find and stop it.

The creatures are easy to track by the trail of ravaged bodies they leave behind. While investigating the corpse of its latest victim, the heroes are surprised when it gets up and attacks them! Unlike standard Secret World vampires, this new arrival sometimes turns its victims into vampires themselves.

The vampires are essentially mongrel vampires, but they have become infested with Filth. With the power of the Dreaming One supplementing their natural abilities, they are stronger and faster than their compatriots, and their vampirism can be contagious.

The heroes have no lack of allies in their vampire hunt. The Canal Street Boys gang is always willing to throw down with a fanged invader. Even the city's elder vampires are available to offer what assistance they can. They know that their relatively comfortable existence is threatened by the presence of these savage, bestial cousins.



NEW YORK

ICON OF BALZOR

In the subbasement of the Balzor Building is a temple to the demon Balzor. At the heart of that temple is an engraved, golden plate known as the Icon of Balzor. Two weeks ago, the icon went missing.

The Balzor cultists who work in the building are ruthlessly competitive, vicious, and bloodthirsty. They will do anything to get ahead. They've recently split into two factions—one calling for the cult to grow, the other to play it safe—and each side claims the other stole the icon for itself. Whoever holds the icon has Balzor's favor, which can lead to better health, better business deals, and better protection from the Illuminati (or anyone else who wants to interfere with the cult).

With the icon missing, the conflict has turned into a war. Non-cultists who work in the building have been hurt by sabotage and misfiring magic. Six people died when an elevator cable mysteriously snapped. The authorities are starting to get suspicious.

In truth, neither side has the icon. It was stolen by a highly skilled thief working on behalf of a rival cult, at the behest of the Dragon. The Dragon loves chaos, and the Balzor Building is now writhing with it.

MAGIC BULLETS

To be fair, the handgun in question looks more like a piece of art than an actual weapon.

It's called the Mouth of the Abyss. The staff at the Met Arms and Armor Department aren't sure who made it or when. While the shape is similar to a revolver, it's made of a fleshy-looking material, and its oversized cylinders are each loaded with inch-long fangs instead of bullets. Over the course of a day, the gun eventually regrows any of the missing teeth that serve as its ammo. Those shot with the teeth fall under the wielder's control, and will do whatever they say. Those who hold the weapon become obsessed with it, and yearn to use it on people.

Because of its unusual design, the relic was mislabeled as a modern sculpture and added to a collection the Met was loaning to another museum. By the time the Arms and Armor staff realized what had happened, the Mouth of the

Abyss was gone. It's now in the hands of Patricia Harper, the curator of the Icons Modern Art Museum in Brooklyn. Harper was just reported missing.

PASSENGERS

Throughout New York, Secret Worlders are whispering that they're seeing things out of the corners of their eyes: leering faces, gaping mouths, wet tongues and teeth. The only connection between these people is that they have used the bodega network within the last few weeks.

The network doors actually all open into a single pocket dimension for a fraction of a second. Travelers enter this dimension through one door and exit through another. The dimension has been infested with psychic leeches that latch onto those who pass through their realm. The leeches aren't physical entities and are hard to sense. They survive by feeding off the emotions of their hosts, eventually leaving them soulless husks.

Until recently, warding symbols on the network doors have kept extra-dimensional entities (such as the leeches) from entering our reality. But now the wards are fading in some stores. Ideally, the wards could be replaced, but they are slightly different for each location.

Though few know it, the wards were originally placed by a freelance mage in the 1960s. He's in a nursing home in Newark now, suffering from memory issues and persistent heart problems.

SEATTLE

A STAR IS BORN

The secret ingredient in Seattle Star's coffee is anima.

The company's founder, Ben Fowler, was a follower of the Morninglight. In coordination with his superiors, he summoned and bound an incubus. With it, he was able to capture a Bee named Danny Matthews in 1995. While the incubus kept the captive Bee immobile with its mind control, the cultist was able to ritually bleed anima off him and integrate it into Fowler's coffee-roasting process. The result is that the coffee is as invigorating as it is addictive. Those who ingest it have more energy and a quicker

mind for several hours, but then crash hard as the anima leaves their system.

When the Morninglight was exposed and its leaders vanished, Fowler receded from public view. Five years ago, he disappeared altogether, leaving the company in turmoil. Seattle Star Coffee has since stabilized, but the six members of its board of directors are in constant, sometimes violent conflict.

The heart of this conflict is the incubus. As a demon, he hates humans and wants them to suffer. He plays the part of the humble servant, but the truth is that he killed Fowler and is no longer bound to this plane. He remains, however, in order to pull the company's strings from behind the scenes. He enjoys watching the executives scramble for useless power and making the addicts debase themselves for just one more shot of his precious anima-fueled concoction. The only thing that would make it sweeter would be expanding the coffee chain across all of North America—which would involve capturing a few more Bees. He looks forward to doing so.

CLOUDY WITH A CHANCE OF DISASTER

An armed group calling itself the Brotherhood of Freedom has seized control of the Space Needle and taken some 200 people hostage. Its leaders claim to have hidden bombs in the building's structure and are threatening to start shooting hostages unless the government releases what appears to be a random selection of federal prisoners.

This is a ruse, of course. While the Brotherhood thinks it's fighting for freedom, it's actually been infiltrated by agents of both a nihilistic Dreamer cult and an Orochi black ops team. Neither is aware of the other, but both are aware of the weather-control device inside the tower. The cultists want to use it to rain Filth on Seattle. The corporate agents want to break it down and steal it.

Law enforcement has the Space Needle surrounded. The commander on the ground is itching to send in what he believes would be an overwhelming number of SWAT officers. He'd like to do it soon, since a major storm is rolling in.

ROBOT RAMPAGE

The latest prototype from Anansi Technologies was a failure.

It was designed to be a self-sustaining battlefield drone, but its neural networks were incapable of locating enough raw materials for it to repair and empower itself. The prototype, codenamed "Cannibal," was thrown into the electronics recycling pit.

It was here in the pit, surrounded by discarded electronics, that the drone finally had enough wires and circuits to come online. It repaired itself and upgraded its system. When an Anansi employee entered the pit the next day, he found it empty—except for Cannibal, which was now six times its original size. The drone killed the interloper and made its escape.

Now Cannibal is on the loose. Anansi is trying to capture it without damaging it or revealing its origins. The company would rather lose the prototype than suffer the bad publicity that would result in being linked to the killer robot.

SPRINGTON

CUTTING EDGE

Váli loves to use the patients at Springton Regional Hospital as guinea pigs for its experimental procedures. Some have benefited from this arrangement, and have regained the use of blind eyes, shattered limbs, or cancer-filled organs. Others aren't so lucky; some have died screaming, weeping at the betrayal of the "miracle cure" they had been promised. Some merely wish for death.

The Illuminati and other secret societies are curious about what the hospital has been offering people. So far, they've been able to identify the following:

A genetic therapy that unlocks psychic potential in some people, but drives others to madness.

A drug that provides complete immunity to all known diseases for as long as the user takes it. When they stop taking it, they die.

Transplanted animal organs that replace failed human organs. About half of the organ recipients take on animalistic features; their minds fade as their hands turn to pig hooves.

GREAT MINDS

Though few would recognize them for who they are, a surprisingly large number of elderly Secret Worlders call Greenfield Village their home. This isn't a coincidence. They are here for an experimental procedure to install their minds into younger bodies.

The bodies in question mostly come from Wilkins University students. The elders are particularly interested in members of the Delta Tau Society; if the student is already part of that influential fraternity, it gives the Secret Worlder a head start when stepping back into the conspiracy ring in that young person's body. Once a student has been selected, the Orochi Group digs deep into their history and personality so its client can take over their life with minimal disruption.

The mind-transfer procedure is not a surgical one. Both parties are sedated, and the brain patterns of the donor are copied, then superimposed onto the brain of the recipient, effectively overwriting the younger person's memories and personality. The newly installed Secret Worlder awakens in their new body, and sees their virtually brain-dead body wheeled off to join the others in the Village's memory care ward.

Greenfield Village isn't entirely honest about the procedure. For instance, not every procedure goes off without a hitch. Sometimes the recipient's brain tries to reject the implanted mind, which can lead to apparent confusion and memory loss.

Furthermore, the mind donors aren't actually left as brain-dead husks. While the procedure can damage the brain, most donors retain most of their memories and personalities; their minds are not *removed* during the procedure, but are merely *copied* to the recipient. The original elder remains, trapped in their original body, and often at the mercy of Greenfield Village, and therefore Orochi.

THE REAPING

The agricultural biotech company Plethron gives its employees cancer, then offers them the cure in exchange for their silence and loyalty.

This cancer cure comes from the secret crops growing in Milo Noble's special fields. This is just one of the crop's many unorthodox uses,

but it's key to Plethron's control over its workers in certain key territories. Those opposed to Plethron's control would like to shut down its cancer/cure cycle. Those looking for their own cancer cures have heard rumors of the company's "miracle crop" and will eventually start poking around Noble Farms. When they do, they'll find there's a reason there are so many scarecrows in the fields.

TAMPA

FLESH OF MY FLESH

Aphrodite Rejuvenation has started offering its own expensive "anti-aging cream." It's effective, but at a terrible price.

The problems may have something to do with corruption in the raw materials for this high-tech elixir. The fats and proteins are taken from desperate donors in exchange for a few hundred dollars. The donors are left weak and drained. Some of them die. Váli scientists study the bodies to determine what factors make the best donors.

PORTRAIT OF A THIEF

Several dozen pieces of artwork were stolen from the Dragon-affiliated Galleria del Soul. Some of them have been found, but their new owners were all dead. Some deaths were accidents. Others were murders or were self-inflicted. There are too many to be a coincidence, and the police are beginning to see a pattern.

Guided by the Dragon, the art from the gallery inspires and guides, pushing the right people to do the right things for the Dragon's agenda. In the wrong hands, those same pushes throw off the cosmic balance. People who aren't supposed to have a specific piece feel the *wrongness* of the situation; it opens their eyes to the Secret World and can drive them to madness. The buildup of chaos draws violence, and the owners pay the price.

The art thieves are professionals, but they're not part of the Secret World. They were contracted by a local mob boss, who wanted some of the art for his own collection and to give or sell the rest to his wealthy friends. It is those friends who have been found dead. The mob boss sees the connection, but he doesn't blame the art itself. He quite likes the artwork he kept. He feeds off its chaotic energy.

TREASURE MAP

Historian and occultist Austin Paul claims to have discovered a map from a century ago leading to one of the sacred sites of the weather wall. He knows that whoever controls the site might be able to control the storms. It's a lot of power, and he's not going to let it go cheaply. He's selling it to the highest bidder.

Multiple parties are interested in the map, and not all of them are willing to wait and see if they win the auction. Paul has hired muscle to keep himself safe until the map has transferred hands.

The map is legitimate. Unfortunately, the site it shows is on a small Tampa Bay island that's been secretly taken over by drug smugglers. Anyone hoping to seize control of the location will face a storm of their own.

VANCOUVER

CYBER SPREE

Certain flying CyberPal drones have been spotted following random people throughout the city. The operators don't know why the drones choose who they choose, and are troubled. The drones aren't programmed to do this; even the technicians can't explain the glitch.

The people aren't chosen at random. They're all members of the Illuminati. And the drones aren't the ones doing the choosing. Bernadette Cross, an independent operator, has hacked the drone network, and has been stalking the Illuminati herself.

Cross has nothing against the Illuminati. The cyberstalking is just to show what she can do, and prove her skills to any potential clients. Right now, she's looking at hiring on with a foreign government and taking a few CyberPal drones with her when she goes.

SPROUTS

The steam tunnels running beneath Gastown are full of Filthy fungus. At the tunnels' deepest point lies an amorphous fungal mass. It pulses and twitches like an overgrown, tumorous squid,

seeding the tunnels with fresh mushrooms that should never be eaten. Spores from these mushrooms, like the ones from Zagan's mushroom garden, are laced with Filth. Those who are infected with spores or consume the mushrooms are either drawn instinctively to the tunnels, or slowly transformed into fungal zombies.

At certain times of the year, the fungal mass sometimes reaches its tentacles up through sewer grates and manholes to snatch the unwary from the streets above. It embraces them, infects them, and turns them into its own small army of fungal zombies.

There's recently been a rash of disappearances in Gastown. Alexis Rasmussen knows what's happened to them, but she's spent so many years warning people of the monsters beneath their feet that she's tired of being right. She doesn't want to talk about it anymore—especially with strangers, who are probably just going to mock her.

WOOD SONG

A Gaia Engine churns and throbs beneath the forests of British Columbia. It is this engine that draws protectors here, including the McBride clan and even the Black Tongue werewolves.

As the Dreaming One within the engine stirs, its Filth escapes, creating the Filthy fungus so common in the area. The McBride druids seek out the fungus. Performing certain ancient ceremonies that they say they received in visions from the forest itself, they try to ritually destroy the fungus and neutralize its Filth.

Unfortunately, these rituals are complex, and mistakes can be deadly. If performed incorrectly, the Filth escapes, and can contaminate those around it. This has happened once already. The druids were infected by the Filth they were trying to banish, and were transformed into feral, cannibalistic versions of themselves. Even now, terrified loggers tell of seeing naked, half-starved figures crawling through the woods, muttering of taking blood for the forest goddess.

CHAPTER FIVE: THREATS OF NORTH AMERICA

The Secret World is full of monsters, and North America is no exception. Evil spirits, cryptids, and the hideous spawn of the Dreaming Ones lurk in the shadows, ready to devour the weak and the unwary.

Wildcards are noted with this symbol: ⌘.

CLAY FAMILIAR

The word “familiar” usually brings to mind a black cat or an owl perched on a witch’s shoulder. The truth is that witches and occultists play in the same sandbox but use very different rules. While witches traditionally maintain a constant bond and link to their familiars, occultists use the familiar as a conduit, a tool, or a link to an animated vessel when needed.

There are many tasks that familiars can perform. The Innsmouth Academy on Solomon Island uses familiars to test the school’s defenses, as well as for general maintenance. It is quite useful to have dozens of extra pairs of hands to help keep the grounds pristine.

While familiars can be formed from many substances, clay is the most popular. This is most likely because occultists like the on-the-nose approach, often saying things like “dust to dust” and “I molded you from clay.”

Clay familiars look like hairless, mole-like humans. They remain inanimate unless magical forces imbue or control them. Familiars can cast spells with a direct link from an occultist master or magical disturbance. They are usually tame and do not attack. However, if an occultist forms a link and uses the familiar’s body to commit violence physically or magically, the familiar is very hard to destroy. While not the strongest of magical beings, familiars possess superhuman strength, and they can—and will—run headlong into any fight.



Attributes: Agility d8, Smarts d4, Spirit d6, Strength d8, Vigor d8

Skills: Athletics d8, Fighting d8, Intimidation d4, Notice d6, Stealth d6

Pace: 8; **Parry:** 6; **Toughness:** 8 (2)

Edges: Frenzy (Imp)

Special Abilities:

- **Armor +2:** Sturdy clay.
- **Claws:** Str+d4.
- **Construct:** +2 to recover from being Shaken; ignores 1 point of Wound penalties; does not breathe or suffer from disease or poison.
- **Fearless:** Immune to Fear and Intimidation.
- **Low Light Vision:** Ignore penalties for Dim and Dark Illumination.
- **Mystic Link:** Magic wielders who have spent at least an hour ritually bonding with a clay familiar may cast spells through it.

DARK WATCHER

As Spanish colonists (accompanied by the Templars and the Illuminati) expanded into California in the 1700s, they learned of dark figures with glowing eyes who disappeared if you drew too close to them. The stories continued through the centuries and gained attention from everyone that passed through the Saint Lucia Mountains.

The dark watchers are still sighted today. They're now sometimes described as wearing black capes, wide-brimmed black hats, and black veils that can't hide their glowing eyes.



The dark watchers have never been very aggressive. They seem content merely to watch. But recently, they have been associated with a number of disappearances. The Illuminati have deployed a few low-level operatives to investigate the latest disappearance: an entire busload of college students heading home from a debate competition.

The dark watchers are now seen nightly. Natives of the Saint Lucia area have started to add shades, curtains, and blinds to their windows, allowing no one to peer into their homes at any time of day.

Attributes: Agility d8, Smarts d6, Spirit d8, Strength d8, Vigor d12

Skills: Athletics d8, Common Knowledge d6, Fighting d8, Intimidation d4, Notice d10, Persuasion d6, Stealth d10

Pace: 6; **Parry:** 6; **Toughness:** 8

Edges: Arcane Resistance (Imp)

Special Abilities:

- **Claws:** Str+d4.
- **Dark Words:** Dark watchers can issue simple telepathic commands. As an action, they can cast *puppet* for free, using Spirit as their arcane skill., but the power's duration is only one round.
- **Low Light Vision:** Ignore penalties for Dim and Dark Illumination.
- **Resilient:** Dark watchers can take one Wound before they're Incapacitated.
- **Translocation:** Dark watchers can teleport, per the power, up to a mile away. When they do so, they may also transport up to 500 pounds of matter (living or unliving) that they're touching.
- **Untouchable:** The first time each round that a dark watcher would be hit by an attack, it makes a Notice roll as a free action. A success lets it teleport up to d6" away.

DOVER DEMON

Teenagers tell tall tales. Usually this is to avoid trouble or blame. One night in 1977, several teenagers saw something they couldn't explain. They were out too late in a car they weren't supposed to be driving when they spotted a creature in the middle of the road. The creature's eyes glowed in the dark and its head was large and bulbous on top of a very scrawny body. The

hands and feet were humanoid looking, with sharp claws on every appendage. It shrieked, then jumped on a nearby wall beside the highway. It howled again at the boys as they drove away. A few miles away, another teen walking home from work saw the exact same thing and ran home to tell his parents.

By the next day, the papers had picked up the story and nicknamed the monster the “Dover Demon.” Until the late 1980s sightings were frequent, but they eventually dwindled into only the occasional tourist seeing something they couldn’t explain. However, everyone who first saw the creature drew the exact same sketch. Even today, all witnesses swear they know what they saw and would take polygraph tests. It is safe to say that whatever it was that was running up and down the highway that night wasn’t a normal woodland creature. Some have described it as looking like a “gray alien” with predatory eyes, clawed hands and feet, and sharp teeth that it gnashes while shrieking.

Attributes: Agility d8, Smarts d4, Spirit d6, Strength d8, Vigor d10

Skills: Athletics d6, Common Knowledge d6, Fighting d8, Intimidation d8, Notice d6, Stealth d8, Survival d6

Pace: 8; **Parry:** 6; **Toughness:** 7

Edges: Combat Reflexes, Frenzy

Special Abilities:

- **Bite/Claws:** Str+d4.
- **Fear** (–2): Anyone seeing the creature must make a Fear roll at –2.
- **Resilient:** Dover demons can take one Wound before they’re Incapacitated.
- **Shriek:** As a limited action, the demon unleashes a terrifying scream. Enemies who hear it must make a Fear roll at –4. Those who succeed are immune to the it for 24 hours.
- **Wall Walker:** Dover demons can move normally on walls or upside down.

DRAUG LORD

Originating on an island in the Sargasso Sea, the Filth-infested draug are not the zombie-like creatures many seem to think. Clans and castes with intricate systems of rank and authority exist. Draug are intelligent and can coordinate attacks, using the old Viking language to communicate during battle. Sophisticated hunting parties



capture ships that are thrown off course or lose their way in the mysterious fog surrounding their Sargasso island.

Every clan member has a role. Incubators and pods allow draug to mature, while impalers and maulers lead the offensive even through sewers and on beaches. All draug are under the command of a single lord. Witness accounts describe the lord as something like a jellyfish, but standing at least 10 feet tall. The draug lord only ventures into battle once several foot soldiers have fallen. As the most intelligent of the draug, they communicate orders, tactics, and spy mission directives. Lords support their foot soldiers until the majority fall. Only then do they go on the offensive. In battle, draug lords use strong magic attacks, and physically lash out at their enemies.

Attributes: Agility d6, Smarts d10, Spirit d10, Strength d12+2, Vigor d12

Skills: Athletics d6, Fighting d8, Intimidation d8, Notice d6

Pace: 3; **Parry:** 6; **Toughness:** 16 (4)

Edges: Command, Command Presence, First Strike, Frenzy (Imp), Hold the Line, Sweep

Special Abilities:

- **Armor +4:** Barnacle-covered flesh.
- **Aquatic:** Pace 4.
- **Bloodbound Frenzy:** Draug lords expel a cloud of atomized Filth in a 10" radius. All allied creatures within the cloud gain the Fury and Reckless Abandon effects of the Berserker Edge for five rounds.
- **Claws:** Str+d6, Reach 1.
- **Fearless:** Draug are immune to Fear and Intimidation.
- **Size 4 (Large):** Draug lords weigh well over a ton and stand up to 15' tall.
- **Stunning Spell:** Every other round, the draug lord can cast *stun* in a Medium Blast Template using its Smarts as its arcane skill.

EL CHARRO NEGRO

El Charro Negro was first reported during the early 20th century in the Puebla region of Mexico. Today he is found throughout Mexico and beyond.

Wearing a traditional charro outfit, complete with silk shirt, short bejeweled jacket, tie, and wide-brimmed hat, Charro Negro roams the night on a black stallion. His face is covered in shadow, though some claim he is a handsome man with black hair, dark eyes, and a beautiful smile.



Honest folk have nothing to fear from Charro Negro. Many times he will offer food, shelter, or coin to those truly in need. However, cheaters, thieves, rapists, and murderers should fear the horseman's justice. Their crimes are beacons on their souls; Charro Negro can see them for miles. He is the judge, jury, and executioner.

Charro Negro can appear anywhere at any time. Wise people avoid him if they can, or offer him food or money in return for their lives. Those who test him usually regret the choice.

Attributes: Agility d8, Smarts d8, Spirit d12, Strength d10, Vigor d10

Skills: Athletics d8, Common Knowledge d6, Fighting d8, Intimidation d10, Notice d8, Occult d4, Persuasion d8, Stealth d8, Survival d6

Pace: 6; **Parry:** 6; **Toughness:** 9

Edges: Attractive, Quick

Special Abilities:

- **Black Stallion:** Charro Negro's magical steed can travel as fast as he needs it to, and can teleport while out of sight. It does not fight, and can't be harmed.
- **Fist of Judgment:** Str+d4.
- **Invulnerability:** Charro Negro is immune to damage from non-magical sources. He can be Shaken, but can't take Wounds from any weapons or attacks that aren't magical. If Incapacitated by magical weapons or attacks, Charro Negro vanishes, only to reappear 2d6 nights later.
- **Low Light Vision:** Ignores penalties for Dim and Dark Illumination.
- **Target:** Charro Negro targets those with evil in their hearts. His targets are identified by victims who cry out in anguish, ritualists with a score to settle, or his own mysterious ways. Once he has a target, he can sense his target's location anywhere within 10 miles.
- **Touch of Judgment:** When Charro Negro lays his hands upon his target, it is the target's own sins that condemn him. With a successful touch attack, Charro Negro deals damage equal to the target's Spirit die plus d6; this damage ignores armor, and any Wounds it causes cannot be Soaked.
- **Undead:** +2 Toughness; +2 to recover from being Shaken; no additional damage from Called Shots; ignores 1 point of Wound penalties; doesn't breathe; immune to disease and poison.
- **Voice of Judgment:** Charro Negro knows the names of all those within line of sight. As an action, when he calls a person's name, his voice reminds them of all their harmful and selfish deeds. They must make a Spirit roll at -2 or be Stunned.



FLESH GOLEM

Golems are monstrous beings that are controlled and aimed like weapons. Some are made from stone, others mud or clay. Others are simply scraps of metal and random materials combined to create a behemoth. The bond between golems and their creators is strong. Unless a new master takes control of it, a golem is forever a slave to its creator. Golementry was once confined to the secret practices of kabbalistic practitioners. Now, the magic and art have spread internationally and been infiltrated by the Filth. The results are staggering. Armies of golems are being created to serve and protect the Filth and those who use it to their advantage.

The flesh golem is exactly what it sounds like: human and animal flesh, fused and rotting in a grotesque humanoid form that is designed to hunt, eat, and kill. Blood and organs sometimes seep from the folds of the golem's arms and torso. Other times, eyes and mouths are positioned all over the golem in some sick and twisted version of a face, the mouths open in silent screams.



Flesh golems are strong, and loyal because they have no choice. Their goal is utter devotion to whatever course of action their creators (or the Filth) have set before them. They are not autonomous and not intelligent, but their focus is as razor sharp as their claws and teeth. They leave destruction, chaos, and blood in their wake.

Attributes: Agility d8, Smarts d4, Spirit d6, Strength d10, Vigor d10

Skills: Athletics d6, Fighting d8, Intimidation d6, Notice d6, Shooting d6, Stealth d4

Pace: 6; **Parry:** 6; **Toughness:** 12 (2)

Edges: —

Special Abilities:

- **Armor +2:** Thick skin layers.
- **Construct:** +2 to recover from being Shaken; ignores 1 point of Wound penalties; does not breathe or suffer from disease or poison.
- **Fearless:** Immune to Fear and Intimidation.
- **Fists and Teeth:** Str+d6.
- **Flesh Crawl:** The golem blasts a bit of its own flesh at its enemies. This is a Shooting roll with a Range of 3/6/12 that deals 2d6 damage. The fleshy projectiles slowly crawl back to the golem and rejoin the mass.
- **Flesh Explosion:** Tendrils of flesh burst from the golem as a limited action, wrapping themselves around those nearby. Each creature within a Medium Blast Template centered on the flesh golem must make an Evasion roll. Those who fail are Entangled.
- **Flesh Feed:** The golem feeds on those in its grip. As a limited action it deals Strength damage to each creature Entangled in its flesh, and heals one Wound for each creature it Shakes or Wounds with this damage.
- **Low Light Vision:** Ignore penalties for Dim and Dark Illumination.
- **Meaty:** Flesh golems can take three Wounds before they're Incapacitated.
- **Size 3:** Flesh golems stand up to 10' tall and weigh up to a ton.



INCUBUS/SUCCUBUS

Humans' sexuality makes them easily seduced and manipulated by those whose bodies fuel their lustful appetites. The demons known as succubus (female) and incubus (male) exploit this human weakness with their own exquisite demonic flesh. While they have the ability to affect mortal minds, they rarely need to: their human victims are usually entranced and submit willingly.

Incubi and succubi are natives of the Hell Dimension, home to every demon and hellish creature imaginable. Because the creatures of the Hell Dimension were cast aside and cut off from the human world, their curiosity and hatred often cause them to find holes in the carefully constructed dimensional veil. Most succubi and incubi are followers of Theodore Wicker. They hope to reclaim their autonomy and restore the splendor that the Hell Dimension once had.

Attributes: Agility d8, Smarts d8, Spirit d12, Strength d8, Vigor d10

Skills: Athletics d8, Common Knowledge d6, Fighting d8, Intimidation d10, Notice d8, Occult d6, Performance d12, Persuasion d12, Stealth d8, Thievery d8

Pace: 6; **Parry:** 6; **Toughness:** 9 (2)

Edges: Charismatic, Very Attractive

Special Abilities:

- **Armor +2:** Enchanted skin.
- **Bite/Claws:** Str+d4.
- **Essence Drain:** It can spend a full turn to deal 2d6+2 damage (ignoring armor) to an enemy it's touching. It gains +1 Armor for the next two hours for each Wound it inflicts.
- **Hardy:** A second Shaken result in combat doesn't cause a Wound.
- **Immunity:** Poison and disease.
- **Low Light Vision:** Ignore penalties for Dim and Dark Illumination.
- **Resilient:** Takes one Wound before it's Incapacitated.
- **Shape of Temptation:** As an action, the creature can mold its body into any human or demonic form it wishes, of any gender. In its demonic form, it may have wings, which allow it to fly at Pace 12". It remains supernaturally alluring, regardless of its form.
- **Tempting Words:** The demon can cast *empathy* and *puppet* using its Spirit as its arcane skill.

THE JERSEY DEVIL

The Jersey Devil has many possible origins. Maybe it was born the thirteenth child of a witch. Maybe it was cursed by the townspeople as the child of a traitor at the height of the Revolutionary War. Or maybe it was cursed by a passing band of Roma who were denied food and shelter by its pregnant mother. Regardless of its origin, the outcome is always the same: the creature is born a deformed, demonic, winged monster.

Every Jersey Devil sighting is accompanied by the disappearance of a man, woman, or child, and a trail of blood leading from a village or into the woods. Witnesses share vivid descriptions. Napoleon Bonaparte's brother, Joseph, described seeing a demonic horse-faced, cloven-hoofed creature with talons for hands, red fire for eyes, and wings. It howled at him and ran away. The sightings have varied over the centuries, but the demonic eyes, body, and wings have remained consistent. The Jersey Devil continues to eat people and drink their blood, leading the locals to avoid lonely woods and desolate highways at night.



The Templars and Illuminati rarely agree, on principle alone, but both share information when it applies to the Jersey Devil. The origins of this creature are rooted in the period when the Illuminati and Templars' tenuous truce was about to break. Something happened in Leeds, New Jersey, in the 1700s, and neither faction speaks of it except in specific high-ranking circles. Even agents sent to deal with Jersey Devil sightings are given the bare minimum of information, and they're warned they should say their goodbyes to family and friends before they leave for the assignment.

Attributes: Agility d10, Smarts d4, Spirit d8, Strength d10, Vigor d12

Skills: Athletics d8, Fighting d10, Intimidation d8, Notice d8, Stealth d10, Survival d8

Pace: 6; **Parry:** 7; **Toughness:** 11 (2)

Edges: Extraction (Imp), Frenzy (Imp)

Special Abilities:

- **Armor +2:** Thick hide.
- **Bite/Claws:** Str+d6.
- **Fear (-2):** Anyone seeing the creature must make a Fear roll at -2.
- **Flight:** Pace 12.
- **Fearless:** Immune to Fear and Intimidation.
- **Drive Back:** When it makes a successful attack, the Jersey Devil may push its target up to 2" away.
- **Immunity:** Disease and Poison.
- **Low Light Vision:** Ignore penalties for Dim and Dark Illumination.
- **Size 1:** The beast stands over 7' tall.

KUSHTAKA

Deep within the southeastern forests and coasts of Alaska, the Tlingit people whisper of the shapeshifting creatures known as kushtaka.

Kushtaka generally appear as cute and playful sea otters. On the edge of the water, they lure their prey—a curious tourist, a lonely widow, a drunken wanderer—then drown or devour the victim. Some legends speak of kushtaka transforming people into others of their kind. This claim was strengthened after the landslide at Thomas Bay buried an entire Tlingit village. Before rescuers arrived, most of the villagers were lost; only traces of clothing and blood remained. But the number of sea otters

and missing persons in the area skyrocketed in the weeks that followed.

The kushtaka have evolved their tactics throughout the last century. They have taken up mimicking sounds to lure their victims to them. People swear they heard an animal, baby, or family member crying out in the woods. Witnesses explain that they followed the sound or cry for help, only to be met with glowing eyes and gnarled claws that cut through brush and trees. When investigators return to gather evidence, they only find thick, inky sludge in the snow or on the beach. Samples are always taken, and are always confiscated by the FBI.

Attributes: Agility d10, Smarts d6, Spirit d6, Strength d4, Vigor d10

Skills: Athletics d10, Fighting d10, Notice d6, Persuasion d6, Stealth d8, Survival d6

Pace: 6; **Parry:** 7; **Toughness:** 7 (2)

Edges: Dodge

Special Abilities:

- **Aquatic:** Pace 6.
- **Armor +2:** Thick fur.
- **Bite/Claws:** Str+d4.
- **Echo:** The kushtaka can perfectly replicate any voice or sound it hears.
- **Filthy Fangs:** Acidic Filth burns in the kushtaka's mouth. Those harmed by its bite take an additional 1d4 damage at the end of their turns until they take an action to clean off the Filth.
- **Shape Shifting:** As a limited free action, the kushtaka can change its shape from a small otter to a human-sized beast. In its beast form, it has Size 0 and Strength d10, but loses the Dodge Edge. (It can also change back as a limited free action.)
- **Size -2:** Kushtaka look like large sea otters.

LA LLORONA

Every region of Latin America has its own story of La Llorona, a woman whose children tragically drowned, and who in her grief and rage now drowns others in turn.

The details of the children's death vary. In some stories, their mother drowns them, then drowns herself. In others, their deaths are an accident but leave her no less grief-stricken. In every case, she is tied to bodies of water, especially deep lakes and reservoirs. Skeptics claim that the fable of a



woman who will drown children is an old wives' tale meant to deter children from swimming or playing in the water. Others consider La Llorona a real spirit that must not be pursued or angered, and they caution against even speaking her name.

La Llorona is known for her loud crying. Even on the most storm-filled nights, the spirit's gut-wrenching sobs and moans can be heard above raging winds for miles.

Her appearance varies depending on who sees her. Some victims report seeing a woman in a soaked white-lace dress. Others describe her as an old woman in black-and-white mourning robes with her face covered. If she lifts the hood from her brow, the person is hypnotized and



follows her into a watery grave. Perhaps the most terrifying description of all is the apparition with gnashing fangs and black holes for eyes who floats above late-night fishermen.

Attributes: Agility d8, Smarts d6, Spirit d10, Strength d10, Vigor d10

Skills: Athletics d8, Common Knowledge d4, Fighting d8, Intimidation d8, Notice d6, Persuasion d10, Stealth d8, Spellcasting d10

Face: 6; **Parry:** 6; **Toughness:** 7

Edges: Arcane Background (Magic)

Powers: *Empathy, illusion, puppet, sound/silence, teleport.* **Power Points:** 12.

Special Abilities:

- **Aquatic:** Pace 12.
- **Bite/Claws:** Str+d4.
- **Invulnerability:** La Llorona is immune to damage while in or within 10 feet of water. She can be Shaken, but can't take Wounds while near water. If Incapacitated outside the water, La Llorona's body turns liquid and flows to the nearest body of water. She reappears 2d6 days later, but can no longer approach the area where she was defeated.
- **Water Bound:** La Llorona can only use her powers while touching water.

LEMURIAN

Lost continents have fueled conspiracy theories for millennia. Lemuria, a continent sunk beneath the Pacific Ocean, is one such place. Like the people of Atlantis, Lemurians were an advanced society that met a catastrophic end. Those who escaped made it to the shores of what is now California. It's unknown how these survivors eventually chose to live within the caverns of Mount Shasta. Eventually the Lemurians burrowed deep within the hollow parts of the earth and created the city of Telos. This gave them access to the tunnels beneath Agartha, though they don't frequent them. History has taught Lemurians to exercise caution when interacting with other civilizations.

TELOSIAN

Lemurians are humanoid creatures standing seven feet tall with pale-blue skin. The Lemurians of Telos are cautious but largely peaceful when encountered aboveground. Some people even call them friends. Those encountered belowground

are on guard duty. They use their powers to drive away those they can, and destroy those they can't.

Attributes: Agility d8, Smarts d10, Spirit d8, Strength d10, Vigor d12

Skills: Athletics d6, Common Knowledge d8, Fighting d8, Intimidation d8, Notice d8, Persuasion d6, Psionics d10, Research d10, Science d10, Stealth d6

Pace: 6; **Parry:** 6; **Toughness:** 11 (2)

Edges: Arcane Background (Psionics)

Powers: *Boost/lower Trait, confusion, mind link, mind reading, mind wipe, puppet, slumber, stun, telekinesis.* **Power Points:** 20.

Special Abilities:

- **Armor +2:** Thick hide.
- **Bite/Claws:** Str+d4
- **Fearless:** Immune to Fear and Intimidation.
- **Low Light Vision:** Ignore penalties for Dim and Dark Illumination.
- **Resilient:** Lemurians can take one Wound before they're Incapacitated.
- **Size 1:** Lemurians stand up to 7' tall.

FILTHY TELOSIAN

The Filth has infiltrated the tunnels beneath Mount Shasta that connect Telos to the surface world. The Telosians try to destroy those of their number who have been infected, but aren't always successful. Now surface dwellers are reporting hunched humanoids with clawed, dripping fingers that gnash their teeth and wail.

Attributes: Agility d8, Smarts d10, Spirit d8, Strength d10, Vigor d12

Skills: Athletics d6, Common Knowledge d8, Fighting d8, Intimidation d8, Notice d8, Persuasion d6, Psionics d10, Science d8, Stealth d6

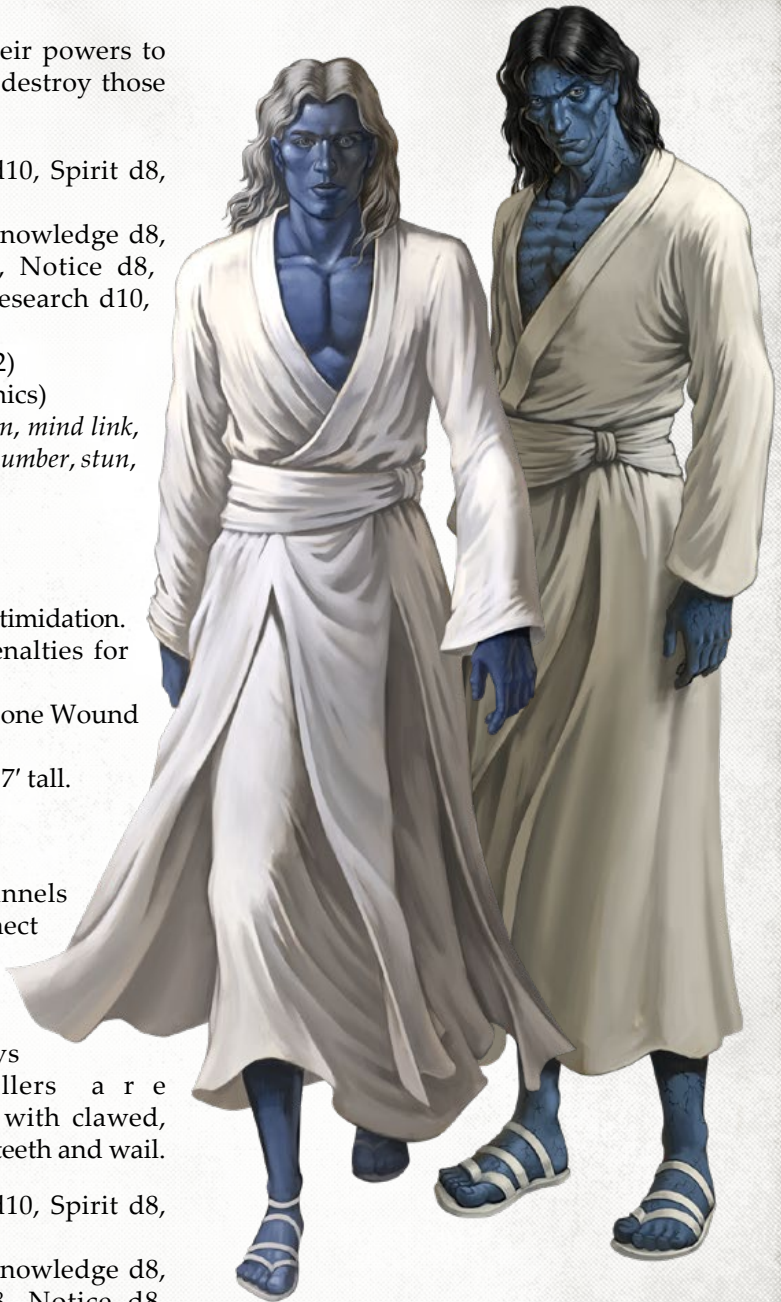
Pace: 6; **Parry:** 6; **Toughness:** 11 (2)

Edges: Arcane Background (Psionics)

Powers: *Boost/lower Trait, confusion, mind link, mind reading, mind wipe, puppet, slumber, stun, telekinesis.* **Power Points:** 20.

Special Abilities:

- **Armor +2:** Thick hide.
- **Bite/Claws:** Str+d4.
- **Fear (-2):** Anyone seeing the creature must make a Fear roll at -2.
- **Fearless:** Immune to Fear and Intimidation.



- **Filthy Mind:** Filthy Telosian mind powers all have the Filth trapping. When one of these creatures uses its powers against an enemy, it may spend 2 Power Points to manifest Filth and deal an additional 1d6 damage to the target.
- **Low Light Vision:** Ignore penalties for Dim and Dark Illumination.
- **Resilient:** Lemurians can take one Wound before they're Incapacitated.
- **Size 1:** Lemurians stand up to 7' tall.

OGOPOGO

The tribes of the Kelowna region have spent centuries on the shores of British Columbia, and their legends are known throughout the area. One such legend is that of the Ogopogo, a 50-foot long dragon-like creature with gray and green scales that resides in Okanagan Lake. The Ogopogo is generally tame, sometimes playful, and has survived the coldest winters and the hottest summers.

A congenial soul that swims and occasionally makes waves, the Ogopogo is beloved by locals and tourists alike. Locals have built playgrounds with Ogopogo rides and swing sets. There are novelty shops associated with all things Ogopogo, and everyone speaks lovingly of their pet sea serpent.

The Ogopogo is generally nonaggressive. Its only crime is sometimes playing a little too roughly in the water, causing waves that have capsized boats and swept away horses and other livestock that were too close to the lake.

Many love the Ogopogo, but there are others who would hunt the creature for a payout or a story. Among those are hunters working for the Orochi Group, who hope to capture the creature for breeding and research. Below the surface of

the lake is a tunnel to Agartha that the Ogopogo can use to escape hunters when they get too close. If the beast can't escape in time, however, it will fight. This may be the reason for the first-ever tales of violence from the Ogopogo. Recently, some local sailors have recovered some boats slashed in half and still drenched in inky blood.

Attributes: Agility d10, Smarts d4, Spirit d6, Strength d12+4, Vigor d12

Skills: Athletics d8, Fighting d8, Intimidation d4, Notice d8, Stealth d8, Survival d8

Pace: —; **Parry:** 6; **Toughness:** 21 (4)

Edges: —

Special Abilities:

- **Aquatic:** Pace 10.
- **Armor +4:** Thick blubbery hide.
- **Bite:** Str+d8.
- **Capsize:** Through a combination of making waves and direct, slamming attacks, the Ogopogo can try to capsize any boat it can reach. This is a contested roll between the beast's Athletics and the Boating of whoever is behind the vessel's wheel. A success makes the boat Out of Control; a raise causes a roll on the Vehicle Critical Hits table in *Savage Worlds*. Each raise also causes a Wound to the vessel.
- **Size 9:** Ogopogo is about 50' long and weighs several tons.



SASQUATCH

Everyone who has gone camping in the Secret World seems to have a story about a mysterious odor, sounds that don't quite sound like animals, or howling that can't be attributed to a wolf or coyote. These are possible signs of a sasquatch. Tall, muscular, and covered in hair from head to toe, sasquatch could easily pass for an earlier version of the human race. They are peaceful creatures that prefer to live in small groups hidden in forests and mountainous regions. Sasquatch rarely engage with humans and traditionally seek solitude.

Their traditions are changing with the introduction of the Filth. Sasquatch clans are being forced out of their once-quiet homes. Mountains, forests, rivers, and lakes are being corrupted by the Filth in many regions. Rival factions are upsetting the balance in these previously pristine areas, causing sasquatch clans to lash out with anxiety and fear.

Territorial, intelligent, and attuned to anima on a different spiritual level, sasquatch tend to simply vanish when faced with conflict. They can become nomadic if their habitat is threatened. The Filth and human corruption are causing increased difficulties for the sasquatch, encroaching and wreaking havoc on age-old unspoken treaties.

When left alone, the sasquatch clans are peaceful. But those who invade their space, and destroy wildlife and land they hold sacred, will incur their wrath. They are some of Gaia's favorite creations, and they revere her almost as much as that other ancient species, the jinn.

Attributes: Agility d10, Smarts d6, Spirit d8, Strength d10, Vigor d10

Skills: Athletics d10, Fighting d10, Intimidation d8, Notice d6, Persuasion d6, Occult d6, Stealth d12

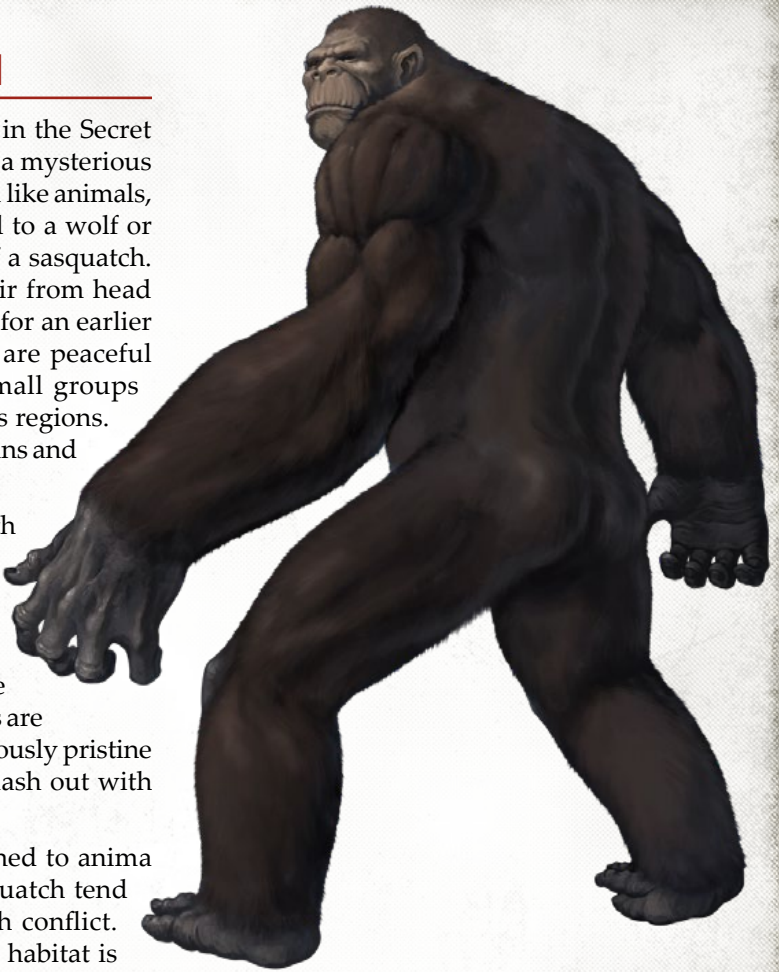
Pace: 7; **Parry:** 7; **Toughness:** 12 (2)

Edges: Brute, Free Runner

Gear: Tree limb (Str+d8), rock (Range 4/8/16, Str+d6).

Special Abilities:

- **Armor +2:** Thick hide and fur.



- **Charge:** If the sasquatch runs at least 5" (10 yards), it adds +2 to the damage of its first Fighting attack that turn.
- **Fists:** Str+d6.
- **Resilient:** Sasquatch can take one Wound before they're Incapacitated.
- **Size 3:** Sasquatch stand up to 12' tall.

SCRAP GOLEM

Scrap golems are controlled by magic or the Filth. They can be more dangerous than other golems because anything can be combined to build their bodies, making them virtually indestructible. "Scrap" is anything the animator wishes: car parts, sheets of metal from a construction site, or bits from abandoned buildings. Everything that can be merged will be, and the golem becomes a walking wrecking ball.

Those who create scrap golems are often found in scrap yards, but they can work their

magic anywhere. They just need to find enough material that can be twisted and fashioned into violent machines. This can mean dismantling buildings, vehicles, and fencing. Golem makers have been known to arm their creations with spinning saw blades or flamethrowers, or to wrap them in ragged barbed wire.

Scrap golems commonly appear in packs. In battle, the primary golem is supported by three or more slightly smaller scrap golem "minions" whose mission is to keep the larger golem up and in the fight. These minions typically stand by unobtrusively unless they are needed; so long as the scrap golem is winning its fight, their only job is to monitor the battle and remain unnoticed. If the primary golem falls, however, the minions spring into action: they surround it, defend it from all attackers, and bathe it in regenerative energies stored within themselves. These energies prevent the fallen golem from further harm, but it can't move or act while recovering. Minions are magically connected to the scrap golems in their care. Their regenerative abilities don't work on other creatures, or each other. They must remain within 20 yards of their primary golems, or spend all their efforts to get that close again. They have little sense of self-preservation; they want to survive only so they can help the primary survive.

⌘ SCRAP GOLEM

Attributes: Agility d8, Smarts d4, Spirit d6, Strength d12, Vigor d10

Skills: Athletics d6, Fighting d8, Intimidation d6, Notice d6, Shooting d6, Stealth d4

Pace: 5; **Parry:** 6; **Toughness:** 13 (2)

Edges: Brawny

Special Abilities:

- **Armor +2:** Metal and thick plastic shell.
- **Barbed Wire:** Anyone who grapples or is grappled by a barb-wired scrap golem suffers 2d4 damage at the beginning of the golem's turn.
- **Construct:** +2 to recover from being Shaken; ignores 1 point of Wound penalties; does not breathe or suffer from disease or poison.
- **Fearless:** Immune to Fear and Intimidation.
- **Flamethrower:** As an action, a scrap golem can spray fire in a Cone Template. It rolls Shooting to hit, and targets who don't Evade take 3d6 damage.
- **Low Light Vision:** Ignore penalties for Dim and Dark Illumination.
- **Minions' Awakening:** The first time a scrap golem is Incapacitated, any of its minions within 50 yards immediately come to its aid.
- **Minions' Gift:** While wounded, and within 6" of at least one of its minions, the scrap golem is Invulnerable, but cannot move or take actions. While in this state, it heals one Wound at the end of its turn.
- **Saw Blades:** Str+d6.
- **Size 4 (Large):** Scrap golems stand about 15' tall and weigh more than a ton.

SCRAP GOLEM MINION

If an agent finds a scrap golem, a pack of three or more scrap golem minions is sure to be nearby. Minions are created with a bit of their creators' mystical essence within them. This essence gives them a single-minded drive to protect their assigned scrap golems, and the supernatural energy to restore them if they fall in battle.

Minions are slightly smaller and nimbler than the golems they protect, though they still tower over most people and are serious threats in their own right.



Attributes: Agility d8, Smarts d4, Spirit d6, Strength d10, Vigor d10

Skills: Athletics d8, Fighting d8, Intimidation d4, Notice d6, Stealth d6

Pace: 7; **Parry:** 6; **Toughness:** 8 (2)

Edges: Dodge

Special Abilities:

- **Armor 2:** Metal and thick plastic shell.
- **Claws:** Str+d4.
- **Construct:** +2 to recover from being Shaken; ignores 1 point of Wound penalties; does not breathe or suffer from disease or poison.
- **Fearless:** Immune to Fear and Intimidation.
- **Low Light Vision:** Ignore penalties for Dim and Dark Illumination.
- **Pack Tactics:** Scrap golem minions add any Gang Up bonus to their Fighting damage rolls.
- **Size 2:** Scrap golem minions stand about 10' tall, and weigh up to a ton.

SKINWALKER

This is a creature the Navajo refuse to discuss. The stories are far too gruesome to tell in polite company and involve ancient tribal legends that are not to be shared with outsiders. Cryptid rumors, intrusive reporters, and cable television documentaries have shed some light on the half-man, half-animal monster that stalks prey for blood and skin to literally wear. However, the Navajo do not speak of this even within their own circles unless it is necessary. The Hopi and Apache have similar histories, but the Navajo have faced skinwalkers for centuries.

The skinwalker is a creature born from darkness, with an evil Intent to become immortal or seek retribution upon its enemies. Some have described the skinwalker as a large moose, deer, or bear that walks almost like a man but can run with the speed and gait of the animal it resembles. It is not only the skin the man-beast has acquired, but the senses, tastes, instincts and some abilities of the host animal.

Only the Illuminati have successfully captured a skinwalker. The creature had to be destroyed within 48 hours after the loss of an entire unit of agents, and further study wasn't possible. Skinwalkers are first on most lists of subjects slated for research by all major factions.

Claws that tear and fangs that sink into flesh are their first offensive attack. When the skinwalker is well fed, it can project thoughts, speak into its prey's mind, and stalk its target for days upon end. If a skinwalker is emaciated, its telepathic abilities are weaker, but its instincts and senses become stronger. Perhaps it is the mind control that keeps these creatures steeped in such mystery.

SKINWALKER

Attributes: Agility d8, Smarts d10, Spirit d12, Strength d8, Vigor d10

Skills: Athletics d8, Common Knowledge d6, Fighting d8, Intimidation d10, Noticed d6, Occult d8, Persuasion d8, Spellcasting d10, Stealth d8, Survival d6

Pace: 6; **Parry:** 6; **Toughness:** 9 (2)

Edges: Arcane Background (Magic)

Powers: *Blind, bolt, boost/lower trait, entangle, fear, fly, mind link, mind reading, mind wipe, puppet, shape change, protection.* **Power Points:** 20.

Special Abilities:

- **Armor +2:** Magically enhanced skin.
- **Bite/Claws:** Str+d4.
- **Changing Shape of Horror:** The skinwalker can use its *shape change* power to turn into other people. To use its *shape change* power, the skinwalker needs to wear the skin of the creature it changes into; the skin melds into the skinwalker's new shape and allows the evil spellcaster to retain the shape indefinitely. Once worn, the skins don't decay. (Skinwalkers may have closets full of old skins.)
- **Feast or Famine:** When a skinwalker has less than half its Power Points remaining, its Spellcasting die is reduced to d6, and both its Fighting and Strength dice are increased by one die type apiece. This modification continues even while in a changed shape.
- **Heart of the Beast:** When the skinwalker takes on an animal form with its *shape change* power, it may retain that form indefinitely.

FILTHY SKINWALKER

When a skinwalker is infected with Filth, its mind is given over to chaos and cruelty. While it still stalks and kills indiscriminately, it's more likely to obsess over a single victim or group of victims, feeding almost as much on their ongoing terror as on their flesh. It sometimes even uses

a stolen skin and its mental powers to infiltrate the victim group, in order to torment them from the inside.

Attributes: Agility d8, Smarts d10, Spirit d12, Strength d8, Vigor d10

Skills: Athletics d8, Common Knowledge d6, Fighting d8, Intimidation d10, Noticed d6, Occult d8, Persuasion d8, Spellcasting d10, Stealth d8, Survival d6

Pace: 6; **Parry:** 6; **Toughness:** 9 (2)

Edges: Arcane Background (Magic)

Powers: *Blind, bolt, boost/lower trait, entangle, fear, fly, mind link, mind reading, mind wipe, puppet, shape change, protection.* **Power Points:** 20.

Special Abilities:

- **Armor +2:** Magically enhanced skin.
- **Bite/Claws:** Str+d4.
- **Changing Shape of Horror:** The skinwalker can use its *shape change* power to turn into other people. To use its *shape change* power,

the skinwalker needs to wear the skin of the creature it changes into; the skin melds into the skinwalker's new shape and allows the evil spellcaster to retain the shape indefinitely. Once worn, the skins don't decay. (Skinwalkers may have closets full of old skins.)

- **Consuming Hunger:** When the creature kills a living target with its bite, it may heal a Wound or regain 1d4 Power Points.
- **Feast or Famine:** When a skinwalker has less than half its Power Points remaining, its Spellcasting die is reduced to d6, and both its Fighting and Strength dice are increased by one die type apiece. This modification continues even while in a changed shape.
- **Filthy Touch:** When the skinwalker attacks with its bite or claws, it may spend 2 Power Points to deal an additional 1d6 Filth damage.



STONE GOLEM

Stone golems are stronger and more durable than flesh or scrap golems. Made of solid rock, these creatures are virtually indestructible. Basic weapons do little damage—magic itself is sometimes the only way to bring a stone golem to its knees.

Kabbalists have practiced reanimation and golemtry for millennia. These stone beasts once guarded Atlantis and Lemuria's great halls. They once served benevolent, powerful rulers and their magic practitioners. Now, they are a force of destruction. Mages animate these monstrosities with hopes of using muscle, might, and magic to obtain whatever they need. The Filth can control any golem because all that is needed is magic and willpower.

Stone golems are more resistant to weapons, magic, and projectiles. Many launch their own missiles, often chunks of stone from their own bodies. When fighting such a creature, agents and mages know to dodge, use shield magic, and find the animator to ultimately bring the golem to its knees. Like flesh and scrap golems, a stone golem will not go down easily or quietly. It has a single focus: obeying its master, the magic wielder who animates it and owns its will. Stone golems are often found in mountain regions and off the coasts of older coves. But they can also be created from pavement in the heart of a major city. Stone, magic, and a master are the only requirements.

Attributes: Agility d8, Smarts d4, Spirit d6, Strength d12, Vigor d12

Skills: Athletics d6, Fighting d8, Intimidation d6, Notice d4, Stealth d4

Pace: 6; **Parry:** 6; **Toughness:** 15 (4)

Edges: Arcane Resistance

Special Abilities:

- **Armor +4:** Stone flesh over stone bones.
- **Charge:** If the golem runs at least 5" (10 yards), it adds +2 to the damage of its first Fighting attack that turn.
- **Construct:** +2 to recover from being Shaken; ignores 1 point of Wound penalties; does not breathe or suffer from disease or poison.
- **Fearless:** Immune to Fear and Intimidation.
- **Hardy:** If Shaken, a second result does not cause a Wound.
- **Low Light Vision:** Ignore penalties for Dim and Dark Illumination.
- **Resilient:** Stone golems can take one Wound before they're Incapacitated.
- **Stomp Quake:** As a limited action, the golem can stomp the ground in front of it with such force, it creates a quake that affects everyone in a Large Blast Template. Those affected must make an Evasion roll; those who fail take 3d8 damage and are knocked prone.
- **Stone Fists:** Str+d6.
- **Size 3:** Stone golems stand up to 12' tall and weigh up to 2,000 pounds.



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